

SCHLELBERG

A NOVEL

RAFIF

CHAPTER ONE

The King's Measure

On the ninth day of the occupation, the soldiers came for the seed.

Tobious was waiting outside the granary when the gate's shadow reached the last storage jar. He counted seven soldiers, a scribe, and four donkeys carrying empty panniers. A boy followed them with a water jug. He was too young to have worked a harvest after dark, but someone had put a rope around his neck, like the ropes on the two prisoners beside the well.

Tobious looked away before the boy could see him.

Beside him, Mariya nudged a small board with her foot. Fourteen pebbles lay on it, one for each jar they had inspected. She drew three apart from the others.

"Let me finish before you say anything."

"If they take these, we'll have nothing to sow."

"I know."

She tied her hair back again. Flour marked her temple where she had wiped away sweat at the mill. She was wearing the same shawl she had worn on the night of the attack. One end had burned; she had cut it on a slant to stop it fraying.

"You said three jars."

"And I'm still trying to get three jars."

Boots struck the paving. Tobious folded his hands behind his back so the soldiers would not see them close.

From the granary yard, Aras fell away in terraces toward the bay. Mud-brick houses stood on stone foundations, divided by narrow stairs and courtyards where figs should have been drying. Below them lay the harvested barley fields. The olives grew higher up, leaning inland from the sea wind.

Smoke still rose from the boatbuilder's house. Tobious no longer noticed the smell. People returning from the groves covered their noses when they passed it.

Across the valley, the red cloth of Telassar flew above the old ruler's house. That building had not burned. The invaders had spared its roof, its oil stores, its stables. Of all the promises the citadel had made to Aras, only its walls remained useful. They now sheltered the men who had broken the village gate.

The officer stopped in front of Mariya. A bronze corselet covered his chest; its edges rasped against the padded cloth beneath as he breathed. The other soldiers wore thick tunics and carried spears and hide shields. Without waiting for orders, they took their places on either side of the granary door.

Mariya bowed just enough.

"Fourteen jars. Eleven for the palace. Three for sowing after the rains."

The scribe crouched and rested a clay tablet on his knee. From a fold in his clothes he took a pointed stylus.

"Open them," the officer said.

Tobious lifted the lid from the nearest jar. Barley filled it almost to the neck. He had selected those grains himself: whole, heavy, untouched by beetles. Seed from the patch that had remained standing when last season's winds flattened half the slope.

A soldier dipped a wooden measure into it.

Tobious watched the rim.

"That's too deep."

Mariya turned her head.

The soldier stopped. "What?"

"Your measure." Tobious pointed to a dark line around the wood. "The rim used to end there. You've added another band."

The officer took it from the soldier. He turned it once, examined the join, and handed it back.

"That's the palace measure."

"It isn't the one you brought yesterday."

"Yesterday we collected oil."

"We know how much grain is in this store."

"Good. You'll find it easier to count what's left."

The stylus moved across the clay. The scribe had not looked inside a single jar.

Tobious stepped forward. Mariya caught his wrist.

"Those three are seed," she told the officer. "Take them and next year you'll have to bring food here before you can collect anything."

The man considered her.

"How many can still plough?"

"Nineteen. Twenty-one if you release the two beside the well."

"Oxen?"

"Three healthy pairs."

Tobious looked at her. Yesterday there had been four.

"Two jars," the officer said. "Load the rest."

"Three."

He pointed with his whip handle. "Mark those two."

The scribe pressed lumps of damp clay around the cords securing their lids. He lifted a carved stone from the thong at his neck and stamped each lump. A bull stood in the impressions, its head lowered.

Mariya's fingers remained around Tobious's wrist. Then she let go.

"Those two are not to be touched."

The officer was already turning to supervise the loading.

The soldiers poured barley into sacks. Grains scattered across the paving—not many, but enough to make Tobious kneel and gather them. He could not leave them to be trodden underfoot.

When he stood, a soldier was dragging the third jar toward the threshold. A leaf had been scratched into the clay beside its handle.

That one was his.

His mother had made the mark before the clay dried, years ago, so they could find their jar among the things held in common. At the end of every harvest, Tobious scrubbed its inside by hand and filled it again. It held the seed for his field, and seed entrusted to him by the family whose house had become the soldiers' kitchen.

"Wait."

The soldier kept dragging.

Tobious caught the other handle.

"I said wait."

“Let go.”

“Take my share of the food. Leave this.”

The man pulled harder. The base struck the threshold. A small, dry sound came from the clay.

Tobious did not think of the seven spears. He saw a crack running down beneath the leaf.

He hauled the jar toward him.

The spear shaft struck his wrist.

His grip opened. Before he could catch the handle again, the shield's rim drove into his breastbone and emptied his lungs. He stumbled backward, trying to keep his feet. A boot swept his ankle out from under him.

His cheek hit the paving.

For a moment he could see only barley. One grain had lodged between two stones. An ant walked across it.

Tobious pressed his palms against the ground. His right knuckles scraped the stone as he pulled that hand free from beneath him.

A spear point touched the back of his neck.

“Stay down.”

He stopped moving.

At the gate, nine days ago, he had stopped like this. He had been holding a wooden fork then. A man with a shield had come so close that Tobious could no longer bring the tines around. He remembered the wood breaking. Someone had fallen beside him. His own hand had searched the wall for an opening, somewhere narrow enough that the spear could not follow.

He still did not know how to get past a shield.

“He's your sluice worker,” Mariya said.

Footsteps approached.

“And?” the officer asked.

“Your men came yesterday. They wanted someone who knew the channels beneath the old storehouse. I gave them his name.”

The spear point pressed a little harder.

“Tobious. He repairs the water gates every season.”

The officer told the scribe to check another tablet. When the man nodded, the officer crouched beside Tobious's head.

“You'll start now.”

He gripped Tobious's hair and lifted his face.

"Under the hill. Until the work is done."

He let go. Tobious's cheek struck the stone again.

When the spear was lifted, he did not immediately rise. The soldiers resumed loading. Wood scraped the sides of the jars, and the grain poured into their sacks. He could hear next year's fields leaving the village.

Mariya waited until they had moved away before kneeling beside him.

"Can you breathe?"

He nodded.

"Look at me."

He turned his head. Beyond her shoulder, the people who had been watching were returning to their work. A woman swept spilled barley into a fold of her dress.

"We still have two," Mariya said quietly. "Help me keep them."

Tobious could not answer.

* * *

Behind the granary, Mariya wet the corner of a cloth and cleaned the blood from his lip.

He supported his right wrist with his left hand. The skin had not yet changed colour, but whenever he moved his fingers, pain travelled to his elbow.

"You gave them my name?"

"They're taking workers from every household. I offered someone who actually knew the channels."

"Without asking me."

She stopped wiping.

"You were on Samon's roof until dark yesterday. This morning you came before sunrise. I hadn't had a chance."

"They killed people at the gate. Now I'm supposed to work for them?"

"Right now you're alive because they need the work done."

She said it without raising her voice. That made it harder to argue.

She returned to his lip, and this time he let her.

In the lower yard, the water boy struggled to lift his jug onto a donkey's back. A soldier helped him, then tugged the rope around his neck to make him follow.

"They'll come back," Tobious said. "When those two jars are empty, they'll come back."

"That's why we have to sow."

"So they can take it again?"

Mariya folded the bloodied side of the cloth inward.

"I want the people here to keep eating until we find another way."

Tobious studied his right hand. It could lift a sack Mariya could not shift alone. He could dig until sunset, reset the stones of a terrace wall, hold an ox frightened by fire.

In front of the granary, none of it had bought him time to strike back.

"If I'd had a sword—"

"He would have taken it from you."

Tobious looked up.

She lowered the cloth into the bowl. Blood clouded the water.

"I saw it, Tobi."

He almost told her to leave. The words were behind his teeth when he noticed the split skin beneath her thumb, and the flour still caught in her hair. She had not eaten since they opened the granary.

He reached into the fold of cloth at his waist and took out half a barley loaf. It had been flattened beneath him when he fell.

He broke it in two.

Mariya accepted the smaller piece, inspected it, then exchanged it for the one in his hand.

They ate without speaking.

* * *

The old storehouse lay beneath the terrace where Aras kept its images of the dead. Steps descended between two walls so old that no one remembered who had built them. The houses above had fallen and been rebuilt three times. The stones below had not shifted

even in the earthquake that brought down the western gate, when Tobious was still small enough to be carried on someone's back.

A wooden fence usually barred the stairs. Today it was firewood.

Three soldiers were lowering the statue of the woman with the bowl from its place beside the well. They had wrapped her head in cloth to keep it from breaking.

Tobious slowed.

As a child, he had been taught to wet the statue's feet with the first water he drew to drink. The old people said the spring remembered a grateful household. He had never decided whether he believed them. But the pale circle where she had stood made him want to put something there.

A guard pushed him between the shoulders with a spear shaft.

"Down."

The air below was cooler and smelled of lamp oil. Six people from Aras were clearing rubble and sediment from a passage. Tobious recognized Samon by his bent back. The older man was fastening a rope around a block of stone.

"What's wrong with your hand?" he asked.

"Someone hit it."

Samon looked at his lip, then offered him the unfinished knot.

"Use the other one."

He asked nothing else.

The passage ended in a circular chamber. Water seeped through the eastern wall and stood ankle-deep across the floor. In the centre, the workers had uncovered an opening beneath a stone slab. Another short flight of steps led down into it.

A Telassari overseer waited there with a three-wicked lamp. A leather tube hung at his waist. None of the other soldiers carried one.

"You know the channels?"

Tobious nodded.

The man pointed at the water. "Get it out."

Tobious crouched beside the wall. Moss filled the joints, but the lower stones were clean, worn by the flow. He felt along the floor until his fingers found the drain.

A piece of broken pottery had lodged across its mouth. Mud and roots had caught behind it.

He pulled the shard free.

The water began to move. A faint current tugged at his ankles.

“Don't go down yet.”

The overseer already had one foot on the steps.

“Why?”

Tobious pointed at a dark line on the wall. “The water stood higher than the opening. That drain's been blocked a long time. There could still be a chamberful below.”

The man waited. Only a moment, but long enough for Tobious to feel something he had not felt all morning: his words had made someone stop.

They lifted the mud out in baskets. Samon held a lamp while Tobious worked a wooden rod through the channel. His right wrist began to swell. He slowed, then changed his grip so he would not have to bend it.

As the water receded, a line appeared along the lowest step.

At first Tobious took it for a joint in the stone.

It was too straight.

The overseer opened his tube and withdrew a thin piece of hide covered in marks. He looked at the steps, checked the hide, then rolled it away before Tobious could make out anything more.

“The rest of you. Out.”

Samon glanced at Tobious.

“He stays.”

The workers gathered their baskets. Samon's footsteps paused at the entrance, then followed the others up the passage.

Only Tobious, the overseer, and a soldier guarding the stairs remained.

“What's down there?” Tobious asked.

“Storage.”

“Storehouse doors usually have handles.”

The overseer raised the lamp.

Tobious could see it clearly now: a black surface inside a stone frame, without hinges or sockets for a locking bar. It was wide

enough for two people abreast. Mud crusted its lower edge, but the clean part did not reflect the lamp.

The overseer pointed to a recess in the frame.

“Clear that.”

Tobious used the corner of his clothes. A piece of green metal crossed the recess like a clamp. One end had broken away.

He touched it with the wooden rod.

A humming travelled through the wood into his palm.

He let go. The rod splashed into the water.

“Pick it up.”

“There's something inside.”

The overseer stepped closer. “I told you to clean it.”

Tobious glanced at the way out. The soldier on the steps shifted his spear into his right hand.

Tobious crouched again.

He drew the packed mud from behind the clamp with his cloth. Grit caught in the scrape across his knuckles. Without thinking, he wiped his hand against the edge of the recess, leaving a smear of blood.

The humming stopped.

The water around his feet went still.

The overseer lifted his head.

A line of light appeared on the black surface, level with Tobious's face.

He stumbled backward into the man's legs. The lamp swayed. All three flames stretched toward the opening, although Tobious felt no wind against his skin.

Something metallic moved inside the wall.

The overseer seized his shoulder.

“What did you do?”

Tobious did not answer. The light was widening.

Beyond it was sky.

Not another room. Not a passage lit with lamps.

Pale sky opened between buildings taller than the hills above Aras. Roads joined their upper reaches without a single pillar beneath them. Something long and silver passed along one, moving

so quickly that Tobious only managed to follow its path after it had gone.

He could still feel cold water around his ankles. Behind him, the oil lamp hissed.

A man stood on the other side.

Shadow hid part of his face. His clothes fitted closely across his shoulders and arms, without folds or fastenings Tobious recognized. Blood escaped between the fingers pressed against his right ribs.

The man looked first at the overseer.

Then he found Tobious.

“Don't go with him.”

The voice was hoarse, broken by difficult breaths. Tobious knew the way it swallowed the ends of words, the effort to speak without letting anyone hear the fear.

He was listening to his own voice.

The overseer's grip tightened.

“Who is that?”

The man beyond the opening reached toward them. Behind him, a section of roadway bowed downward. Only then did Tobious understand that the small things falling from it were people.

“Tobi. Listen. They aren't looking for stores.”

A crash sounded in the passage behind him. The soldier on the stairs shouted to someone outside the chamber.

The man came close enough for the light to reach his face.

A long scar ran beneath his left eye. His hair was shorter. He looked older than Tobious, though Tobious could not have said by how many seasons.

“That door is what they came for. And now they know you can open it.”

The Door Without Wind

The man with Tobious's face vanished while Tobious was still trying to reach him.

He pulled free of the overseer and stepped into the water. The black surface held a pale street, a broken road, the place where the man had stood. Tobious could see between the towers now. Whatever had fallen from the road was lost beneath them.

"Move back," the soldier on the stairs said.

Tobious heard him without understanding why the words were meant for him. He knew the line beneath the stranger's eye. He knew the voice. He had seen himself bleeding in a place beyond the span of any road he had ever imagined.

He reached for the light.

The overseer caught him by the collar. "Tell me what he said."

"You heard him."

"Tell me what you did."

In the passage behind the soldier, clay broke against stone. The water boy had dropped his jug. Tobious saw him appear at the bend, the rope still around his neck, one hand pressed to his mouth. The soldier turned long enough to shout at him to get out.

Tobious used the moment to take the wooden rod from the water. He pushed it toward the opening. It struck something hard where the distant street appeared to begin.

The impact jarred his swollen wrist. The rod slipped from his hand and fell into the chamber. He watched its ripples spread through the shallow water. None crossed the black line.

The man had not been standing in a doorway. Tobious had seen him as one sees a figure at the bottom of a still well: near enough to recognize, impossibly far to touch.

The towers thinned. Light passed through the man's empty place. Then the surface went black again.

For a breath, nobody moved.

"A picture," the soldier said.

The overseer shook his head. He had let go of Tobious and was already drawing the rolled hide from his tube. He held it close to the lamp, glancing from the marks to the green clamp in the frame.

“There should be a second contact.”

“Should be?” Tobious asked.

The overseer lowered the drawing. There was a small circle pierced through the hide at its edge, and beside it a mark Tobious had seen on the soldier's requisition tablet that morning. Not a Telassari seal. Something stamped for men who could ask a king's soldiers to dig beneath graves.

The guard came down two steps. “Darran. We should fetch the captain.”

So the overseer had a name. Darran examined the broken end of the clamp, then wedged the butt of the soldier's spare spear beneath it.

“Hold it there.”

“The captain—”

“Will ask why you stood and watched it close.”

The soldier braced the spear. Tobious backed toward the stairs. The boy was still at the bend, staring at the puddle of his lost water. He had a narrow face and a freshly rubbed patch of skin where the neck rope lay.

“Go up,” Tobious told him.

The boy hesitated. He looked at the soldier.

Tobious understood. The boy had been ordered to bring water below. He did not yet know whether fear of this place was a reason anyone would accept.

Darran pushed the damaged clamp into its recess. Metal clicked against metal. Tobious felt pressure in his teeth, as if he were descending too quickly into deep water. The black surface bent inward. The lamp flames leaned toward it again.

This time the water moved.

A breeze touched his wet ankles and brought a smell he could not place: hot stone after rain, spoiled salt, something sweet beneath it. On the other side stood no shattered road. He saw a narrow place lined with pale walls, lit without a flame. The air at the threshold drew at his tunic.

"That's open," he said.

Darran's delight was so immediate it frightened him more than the breach.

"Keep it steady."

The soldier shifted his grip on the spear. In the bright passage beyond, a shape moved against the wall. Tobious thought it was a man approaching sideways to fit through a confined gap. Then the shape unfolded a second set of limbs.

The boy made a sound. Tobious turned and saw that the soldier had barred the stair with the length of his spear to keep him down. The order must have been to collect the broken jug. The boy crouched on the lowest step, too frightened to pass either way.

"Let him go," Tobious said.

The soldier did not look at him. His eyes were on the pale passage.

Something placed a hand against the threshold. It had too many joints and no nails. The hand went thin as smoke, then gathered itself again when the air flowed over it. A long shoulder followed. Where a chest ought to have been, Tobious saw the bright wall beyond, distorted as though viewed through flowing water.

The creature turned its head toward the boy.

The soldier released the clamp. The spear butt struck the chamber floor. He snatched his own weapon from against the stair and thrust. Bronze passed through the creature's hollow middle. The point rang against the far wall.

The creature closed around the shaft.

Its outline hardened for the space of a heartbeat. At its collar, where the neck narrowed into the empty torso, a dark knot appeared, wet and ridged. The soldier pulled back. Bronze scraped it. The creature convulsed, and the smell of burned salt filled the chamber.

It struck him with one of its limbs. His hide shield took the blow and folded against him. The force drove him against the stair. He screamed for men above.

Tobious had already reached the boy.

He seized the rope at the child's neck and dragged him toward the passage. The rope caught under the soldier's foot. The boy fell.

Tobious pulled again, felt the child's cry through the line, and stopped. With his left hand he found the knot. It had swollen wet and tight.

"Your name," he said, though he had no idea why he asked now.

The boy stared at him.

"What do they call you?"

"Lios."

"Lio. Stay against the wall."

He put the rope around a stone projection and hauled until it slipped free of the soldier's boot. His right hand failed him halfway through. He wound it once around his left forearm and drew Lios past the fallen man.

The soldier thrust again. This time the spear point found the collar knot. A spray of dark grains struck the steps. The creature pulled itself away from the bronze, and its lower limbs blurred. The guard tried to stand. Its hand closed around the back of his neck.

Tobious did not see the moment he died. He heard the spear fall.

Darran was at the clamp, trying to wrench it free with both hands. His lamp lay in the water, one wick still burning. As he pulled, the open passage widened another finger's breadth. The creature turned toward him. He abandoned the metal and stumbled past Tobious up the steps.

At the circular chamber, Samon and two other workers were running back with their baskets and ropes. They had heard the screaming. The sound of boots followed them from the upper stairs.

"Out," Darran ordered. "Seal it."

"How?" Samon said.

The creature entered the lower passage. Its limbs touched both walls. Each time it reached into the cooler air away from the light, it loosened at the edges, then drew substance again from the open threshold behind it. Tobious saw the rhythm. It was not following them on a body it could keep for long. The doorway was feeding it.

He looked up at the rope Samon had tied around the lifted slab. One end ran through a notch in the masonry to a wooden lever on the chamber floor. He had used it an hour earlier to raise a basket of mud. The beam could shift the slab a little. It could not lift the whole doorway.

But the clamp sat beneath its near corner.

“Samon. The rope.”

“Leave it.”

“The metal is keeping the door open.”

Lios pressed himself behind one of the basket carriers. Samon looked from him to the lower passage. His face changed. He had chosen to believe Tobious.

“You two, take the boy upstairs,” he told the workers. “Tell them the stair is blocked.”

One woman picked up Lios and carried him despite his protests that he could walk. The second worker ran beside her. Darran went after them, shouting for soldiers.

The creature came into the chamber.

It paused beside the lamp. Light passed through its open middle and made moving bars across the old stones. Tobious could see no eyes. Still, he felt it attend to the two men left there, and to the rope Samon was fastening around the lever.

“Where does the drain lead?” Samon asked.

“Down the west channel.”

“Then if the roof comes?”

“The water goes that way.”

Samon gave him a flat look. “I meant us.”

They hauled. The rope stretched; the slab shifted no more than the width of Tobious's thumbnail. The creature moved. Samon let go to throw his basket at it. Wicker struck the wall. The Iwang flowed around it, thinning through the weave, then became heavy again as its collar came near the old stone.

Tobious took the lever with his left hand. The right could only steady it. He set his foot against the base and pulled until the wood bent. The slab moved another fraction. A line of green metal appeared beneath it.

“A stone,” he said. “Put it under.”

Samon jammed a loose block into the gap. The Iwang struck at his back. He rolled away; one limb touched his tunic and left a hole through wool and skin. He made no sound. He only caught the rope again, grimacing.

Together they hauled. Tobious thought of the sluice gate above his own field, which never yielded to a straight pull after silt dried in the channel. Lift, wedge, release, lift again. The work did not care whether he was afraid.

The creature gathered itself. At the lower stair the guard's bronze spear lay half in the water. Tobious let go of the beam, caught it with his left hand, and swept the point across the Iwang's collar. He was not quick enough to stab. Bronze touched the knot for an instant. The creature recoiled from the contact.

"Now," Tobious said.

Samon pulled the rope alone. Tobious shoved the stone wedge into the new space. The slab dropped against it. The clamp snapped sideways out of its recess with a sound like a jar cracking at the kiln.

Air rushed down the passage. Then it stopped.

The light in the lower chamber began to narrow. The Iwang recoiled through the doorway, drawing itself along the wall with its limbs. It did not flee from Tobious or his poor strike. It followed the vanishing current. For a moment its collar knot hung in the passage, solid enough to cast a shadow. Then it passed beneath the slab and into the shrinking seam.

The floor lurched.

Samon threw himself at Tobious and drove him clear of the lever. Stone fell between them. A beam from the old ceiling hit Samon's left leg and pinned him below the knee.

Tobious landed against the wall. Dust filled his mouth. The chamber had gone dark except for the dropped lamp and a thin, declining line of light under the lower stone. It narrowed to nothing.

"Samon?"

"Here."

Tobious crawled to him. The older man's leg lay twisted beneath the beam. He touched it once and took his hand away.

"Don't pull me," Samon said.

The command came through clenched teeth. Tobious wanted to lift the stone. He could not even make his right hand close around its edge.

People shouted above. He called to them for poles, for wedges, for someone who knew how to set a crushed limb. He could name what was needed. That was the only strength he had left.

Darran returned with soldiers. They raised the beam a little at a time while Samon bit through a fold of his tunic. At the upper passage, Tobious saw Lios sitting against a wall, alive, his broken jug arranged carefully between his knees. Someone had cut the rope from his neck.

The boy lifted the two pieces of the jug when he saw Tobious. "It was full," he said.

"I know."

Lios looked back down the stair toward the dead guard. Tobious wished he had a better thing to say. He had saved the boy, and the boy would still have to remember the sound of that spear falling.

At the top of the stairs, the sky had begun to dim. Aras remained where it had been all day: the roofs, the bay, a line of women coming from the well with vessels balanced against their hips. The world had made room for a door, then closed around it without so much as changing the color of the evening.

Darran walked beside the men carrying Samon. He stopped when they reached the yard.

"The boy goes to his household," he told the soldiers. "The injured man gets a litter. This one stays."

He pointed at Tobious.

"Samon needs someone who can tell them how the beam fell."

"They can ask you tomorrow."

Tobious glanced at the empty place beside the well where the statue with the bowl had stood. He thought of the man in the impossible city, of blood at his right ribs, of a warning spoken too late to tell him what to do now.

Two soldiers took him by the arms. His swollen wrist flared when one tightened his grip. He went with them because Samon was breathing on the litter, Lios had been carried into the lane, and the black surface beneath their feet had gone quiet.

He had closed a door. He had no idea how long it would stay closed.

A Blade of Quiet Light

By morning, Tobious had learned which of the storehouse walls received the first heat of the sun. He had been awake long enough to watch its pale square of light travel over seven baskets of dried figs, a stack of broken jar lids, and the single sealed door.

The soldiers had taken his belt. They had left him his damp tunic because it was not worth having. His wrist had thickened during the night. Whenever he forgot and tried to use it, pain drew a sharp line up his arm.

Someone stopped outside the door. Tobious rose. It was a mistake; his knees had stiffened, and his shoulder struck the wall.

Darran came in carrying bread and a water bowl. He set both on a low crate just beyond Tobious's reach.

"You opened it by touching the green metal," he said.

Tobious stared at the bowl. "How is Samon?"

"The leg is still attached."

"That's not an answer."

"It is the answer I have." Darran drew the hide from its leather tube. In daylight it looked worse than the fragment Tobious had seen underground: old creases, a repair of neat stitches along one edge, several marks added in a different ink. "There was no command to put a hand inside the frame. What did you feel before the light?"

Tobious said nothing.

"If it opened once, it can open again."

"A man died the last time."

"Because a guard mistook something he did not understand for something he could stab."

Tobious remembered the bronze tip finding the creature's collar. Without it, he and Lios might have been the ones left on the stairs.

"He hurt it," he said. "For a moment."

Darran looked down at his drawing. "Did you see what was beyond?"

“A passage.”

“Before that.”

Tobious moved away from the crate. The thing he had seen before the passage was a city and a man whose face had been his own. He had thought of that face all night. In the time it took to draw a breath, he could recall the cut beneath the left eye, the strange close-fitted clothes, blood escaping through a hand. He could not recall where the buildings had ended. Perhaps they had not.

“You knew what was there,” Tobious said.

“I knew enough to order you to clear it.”

“Your own hands were free.”

Darran's eyes lifted. His cheeks were marked by the narrow straps of a surveyor's leather cap. He wore no officer's bronze, but men with bronze had obeyed him below.

“Eat,” he said. “You'll need your strength.”

He left the bowl and bread on the crate as the door closed behind him.

Tobious waited until the steps had passed. Then he ate, because hunger could not punish Darran and would only weaken him.

* * *

The captain came shortly after noon. Captain Therren had removed his corselet. Without it, the man from the levy yard seemed narrower, but the effect vanished when he sat across from Tobious and asked how many workers the flooded chamber had required.

“Six,” Tobious said. “Not counting me.”

“How many did you send out?”

“I didn't. Darran did.”

Therren nodded to the scribe at his shoulder. The man made a mark in the clay.

“He says you broke the apparatus.”

“I broke the thing that held the doorway open.”

“The apparatus.”

“It was coming through.”

“And you acted without his order.”

Tobious looked at the clay tablet. A man could move the boundaries of an event merely by choosing where to press a stylus.

"Samon was hurt because he came back for me," he said. "A guard died because Darran opened it again. You can put that beside my name."

Therren did not glance at the scribe. "If I put every man's account beside his name, we would have no clay left before winter."

"Then you're measuring with the wrong jar."

The captain's mouth tightened, though Tobious could not tell whether he was hiding anger or something like amusement.

"You have a useful skill," Therren said. "That's why you're sitting in a room with bread instead of beside the dead guard."

There it was again: useful. It had saved him from a spear point in the granary yard, and it had brought him beneath the hill.

"Have Samon taken to Nerissa," Tobious said. "She sets limbs. He needs clean water and people who know him."

"He has been taken there."

Tobious looked up.

"My men have to walk those stairs," Therren said. "I want the man who knows the drain to survive. I want him capable of telling us whether the ground will go under our feet."

It was not kindness. Tobious could use the result without mistaking it for kindness.

"How bad?"

"Bad enough that she asked for splints, oil, and two hands she trusts. I gave her the hands."

Therren stood. The scribe followed. At the door, the captain paused.

"Someone who knows the device is coming. My commission is to deliver the site in working order. Darran's is to find it. Those are different obligations."

"Who gave him his?"

Therren opened the door. "Ask him."

* * *

Near dusk, they marched Tobious back to the ancestor terrace. The well's stone rim was bright with late sun. The statue of the woman with the bowl had been propped against the wall of the old storehouse, still wrapped in cloth, as though she were waiting for another household to claim her.

Samon was not among the workers clearing the approach. Tobious knew better than to hope he would be.

Darran and Therren stood beside a stranger in plain dark clothes. The man was older than the captain, his hair silver at the temples. He had the stillness of someone saving his breath for work, though when he turned, his left knee delayed him slightly. A narrow case hung at his side.

The stranger spoke to Darran in a language Tobious could not follow. Darran answered too quickly. The stranger held out his hand, and after a moment Darran gave him the drawing.

Then the man addressed Tobious in Aras speech, marked by an unfamiliar coast in the vowels.

"You touched the broken regulator."

"I cleared mud from it."

"And after that?"

"A man appeared. Then the passage opened. Something came through."

The stranger did not ask whether Tobious had dreamed any of it. He unrolled the hide, traced a line near the pierced circle, and folded it away.

"I am Panjios."

"Who sent you?"

"A warning from the coast. One of the older stations still sends a signal when this one wakes."

"Older than what?"

"Older than the stones around it."

Tobious glanced toward Darran. "He was trying to wake it."

"Yes," Panjios said. He did not make Darran bear the whole answer. "Someone supplied him with the drawing. I intend to learn who accepted the request and why."

Darran gave a short laugh. "You brought the authorization."

Panjios turned the hide over. Pressed into one corner was a small device of three lines enclosing a gap. Tobious recognized it: the same mark beside the order Darran had shown underground. On Panjios's case, a metal tag bore it in relief.

"The permission to inspect a buried site," Panjios said, "is not permission to open an unstable route with unprotected workers."

Therren cut in. "If the inspection is yours, inspect it. If it's unsafe, tell me how to keep my people alive. I have no men to spare for a dispute over whose seal means what."

Panjios asked to see the lower chamber. He told the captain he would enter first. Tobious was brought along because Panjios needed him to describe exactly where the light had formed.

Below, the walls seemed ordinary. A broken basket lay where one worker had dropped it. Someone had washed the dead guard's blood from the lower step, and the dark water had carried it to the drain Tobious had opened.

Panjios stopped before the fallen beam. His fingers passed above it without touching. A dim line gathered around his forearm and widened until it surrounded him from shoulder to boot. It had no hard edge; Tobious saw it best where dust drifting down the stairs changed direction before reaching his clothes.

The soldier behind Tobious drew a breath.

Panjios looked back. "Only I am protected. Keep your distance."

He approached the lower doorway. The black surface was inert. The bent clamp had fallen against the frame, trapping a band of green metal beneath it. Panjios knelt and opened the case at his side.

Inside lay a short dark blade with a narrow powered seam along one side. Its grip was wrapped in plain, unmarked material. It was not the great weapon Tobious had imagined when he had lain on the paving and wished for a sword. It looked like a tool someone had kept because it worked.

Panjios set the blade against the fouled metal.

The light around his body went out.

"Back," he said.

He held the edge in place. A faint thread of brightness ran along the green band, then through it. Three breaths passed before the

metal parted. Panjios withdrew the blade and a shimmer returned around him.

The soldier behind Tobious swore softly. Darran came down from the passage with another man and shoved past them to see the frame. The second man, a young guard with a bandage at his neck, saw the severed clamp and raised his spear toward Tobious.

"He did that yesterday," the guard said. "My brother is dead."

Panjios was still crouching. He turned between Tobious and the spear. Bronze struck the shimmer at his shoulder and stopped an arm's length from cloth. The impact pushed Panjios back against the stone. He did not look invulnerable. He let the force move him, found his footing, and lowered his empty hand.

"Your brother died," he said. "No one here is going to make that untrue by killing another man."

"He opened it."

"The part I cut was already broken. The next opening was forced."

The guard looked to Darran. Darran said nothing. Therren had followed them down; he took the spear from his soldier and sent him up with another man.

Tobious watched Panjios close the case. He had seen three things in less than a minute: a blow stopped in the air, a blade that could cut a substance unknown to any smith in Aras, and the brief interval when the one who held that blade had no protection at all.

"What was the thing?" Tobious asked.

"An Iwang." Panjios glanced at the dark frame. "People on this shore have an older name for them. The Hollow Ones."

"There are more?"

"Yes."

Tobious wanted a gentler answer. He trusted this one further.

Panjios touched the place where the clamp had sat. "This station is shut for now. It won't stay that way without repair. The broken regulator used you to steady its first contact."

"Used me how?"

"I can explain what we've measured. I won't pretend it answers everything."

They returned to the light above. On the ancestor terrace, Lios was helping gather the fallen fragments of his jug into a cloth. He paused when Tobious emerged. A bruise darkened the side of his neck, but there was no rope on it.

Tobious stepped toward him. A soldier blocked the way.

"He isn't free," Lios said before Tobious could ask.

The boy said it matter-of-factly, as one might report that the jug could not be mended. Then he bent back over the pieces.

* * *

Panjios asked to speak with Tobious where the captain could hear them. That was no assurance of honesty, but it changed the shape of the trap. Darran could no longer pretend that his instructions came from the same authority as Panjios's warning without being challenged.

"The damaged route needs a living reference," Panjios said. "At present, that is you. If we try to force it from you, we may injure you and open it badly. If you learn to hold it safely, we may be able to repair what Darran damaged."

"Where do you want to take me?"

"Across the coast station, to the city you saw."

The city. The man who might be Tobious. The road falling with people on it. Tobious looked at the bay until the vessels moving there were just dark strokes against the sun.

"You can take me there," he said, "and bring me back?"

"There are return procedures. They have limits. I won't promise a day I haven't measured."

"What about Aras?"

"We can provision a small number of households and treat the injured while the route is secured."

"All of them?"

"Not on the authority I carry."

"Then ask for it."

"I will. That is different from telling you it has been granted."

Tobious looked at Therren. The captain's expression did not soften. He was weighing a future worker against an immediate one.

"Samon needs a splint made properly and something for pain," Tobious said. "Lios goes to his own people. And the seed your men took gets replaced. Before I leave."

"Those are three demands," Therren said.

"You counted fourteen jars yesterday. You're able to count three."

Panjios did not smile. "I can bring dressings and a brace fitted to the leg. I can bring grain equal to what I can carry through Salt Gate on the next scheduled opening. I can arrange for the boy's release from this labor assignment. Therren must agree to that last part."

The captain glanced toward Lios. "A broken jug has made him expensive."

"Then take my labor against it," Tobious said.

"Your labor is already taken."

Panjios said, "The stores I bring will be entered under my seal, not his. There will be a written count and a local witness."

Therren thought for some time. At last he nodded once. "The boy goes to the village. Your supplies may pass. Darran will not touch the lower frame until your people repair it."

Darran began to object. Therren silenced him with a hand.

Tobious had the sensation of watching men divide a field that belonged to neither of them. Yet Samon could receive care. Lios could sleep somewhere without a rope. A little grain could return. There was a price on each thing, and he would be the one to go.

"I haven't agreed," he said.

Panjios met his eyes. "No."

"I need to speak to Mariya."

"Then speak to her. At the lower granary before morning. The supplies should be there by then."

They released Tobious from the soldiers' hold. He reached Lios before anyone could call him back. The boy was tying the cloth around his broken jug.

"You can go home," Tobious said.

Lios looked past him at Therren, waiting for the order to be taken back. The captain turned away.

"My aunt's on the lower street," Lios said. "She'll be angry about the jug."

"Let her be angry at me."

“She knows who breaks things.”

Lios tucked the bundle under his arm and ran before a soldier could invent another task for him.

Tobious watched him go. The boy had asked to keep the pieces of a vessel he could no longer use. Perhaps his aunt would know how to mend it. Perhaps she would give him another and he would refuse, because this one was his.

Panjios came to stand beside Tobious, leaving him room to walk away.

“A city isn't an answer to a village,” Tobious said.

“No.”

“And a sword isn't one either.”

“It may help you bring an answer home.”

Tobious studied the older man's hand. Its knuckles bore small scars where the blade's case had rubbed them over years. It was a working hand, though it had learned a work Tobious did not know.

“Show Mariya the grain,” Tobious said. “Then we'll talk.”

Two Jars

Mariya found another false count before the sun had set.

The palace tablet named four Aras workers assigned to the lower storehouse. Mariya knew seven had been sent below: Samon, Tobious, and five others. Samon had returned on a litter. Tobious had returned under guard. The remaining five still needed finding, and the tablet left three of the seven without a name at all.

It might have been carelessness. The same man had written thirteen beside a levy of fourteen jars and had corrected the number only when she put her pebbles on the ground in front of him. He made mistakes most often where Aras stood to lose something.

She pressed the tablet flat between her palms so she would not break it. Breaking the record would give the captain a reason to charge her for its absence. She would need its marks the next time he claimed he had never taken the men.

At the lower granary, three households waited for food. Mariya had promised to open the door before dusk. Now dusk had come, and the two clay seals with the stamped bull barred her from opening the seed jars without being accused of theft.

She opened a side bin of lentils instead. Hessah's family received a measure less than they had last week. Thesia, whose husband had died at the gate, accepted a portion for herself and then asked for one for her sister's children. The sister's household was missing from the occupation list. There had been no adult name on their door when the scribe passed through.

"I can't put them under your name every time," Mariya said.

"Then put them under their own."

"I'm trying."

Thesia looked at the measure of lentils in Mariya's hands. "Will they eat a name tonight?"

Mariya gave her the second portion. It had to come from a jar already counted for another household. She made a mark on the small waxed board she kept under her arm. By morning she would

have to explain it to someone, perhaps to the household that had expected the missing measure.

She had made this kind of decision before the soldiers came. Once, after a poor olive pressing, she had followed the village allocation exactly. A widow who had moved into her daughter's empty house was left off the list and received nothing for three days. Mariya still remembered the clean, unbroken seal on that jar. There were ways of being honest with a record and false to the people it claimed to describe.

When the last household had gone, she sat on the granary step and counted what remained by touch. Pulse jars, two official seed jars, barley in smaller household stores she could not simply take. At the mill, they had flour enough to make tomorrow's bread if the soldiers kept to their own kitchen. If they did not, her numbers were wishes.

"You forgot to count yourself," Nerissa said.

The midwife lowered herself beside Mariya with a jar of broth. Her back was bent from work, but her eyes missed little.

"I ate at noon."

"A crust isn't a meal."

"There was more."

Nerissa opened the jar. The steam smelled of onion and a bone that had given all it could. "You can lie to a tablet. At least make the lie useful."

Mariya took it. From Nerissa, this counted as an offer of peace.

"Samon?"

"I straightened the leg as much as I dared. The flesh has been badly crushed. He'll need it held still, and I cannot promise how much use he'll have after it heals."

Mariya swallowed a mouthful of broth that was too hot. "Does he know?"

"He asked whether he'd walk to the spring again. I told him I would do what I could."

"That's what people say when—"

"It's what I say when I know what I can do." Nerissa eased herself up. "Eat the rest. Then come help me change the wrapping."

Mariya watched the old woman go. In the yard below, the statue from the ancestor terrace stood against a wall under its cloth. Someone had left a cup of water at its feet. She hoped the soldiers would overlook it. She was tired of spending courage on whether a cup might be taken away.

* * *

The stranger's supplies arrived on two handcarts after nightfall.

Mariya met them with Nerissa and a lamp. Panjios himself pushed one cart. A younger porter pushed the other, accompanied by a Telassari soldier who looked unhappy to be there. Therren's scribe carried a fresh tablet. Darran was absent.

"Show me what you brought," Mariya said.

Panjios began with the grain. He lifted the lids of two sealed containers and allowed her to weigh their contents on the granary balance. Barley, clean and dry, nearly enough to fill two of the village's jars. Not the twelve that had left yesterday. It would feed people while the remaining seed was protected; it would not make the occupation harmless.

She took a handful and let it run through her fingers. The kernels were whole. In the lamp's light she could see no powder from insects.

"Where did you get this?"

"From the coastal stores assigned to our service route."

"Can it be sown?"

"The supply record says yes."

"I can read the king's tablet too. That doesn't make it true."

Panjios held out his hand. She gave him the kernels. He put them back in the container without offense.

"Keep some aside to test. I won't ask you to stake a field on my record."

The scribe began recording the grain under Therren's seal. Mariya placed one of her pebbles on his tablet.

"Measure it with ours," she said.

The soldier shifted his weight. Panjios looked at the scribe. For a moment Mariya thought he might invoke whatever authority had

brought the grain. Instead he asked her for the wooden measure she trusted. She fetched it. Two complete jar loads and a smaller remainder were counted in both men's presence, then carried inside under her direction.

The medicine came next. Clean wrappings, a brace made from a substance lighter than wood, a vial whose contents Panjios named but did not ask them to use blindly. Nerissa took the brace to Samon. She insisted on seeing the adjustment done while she watched, so that if it shifted in the night she would know how to set it back.

Samon lay in his sister's back room, sweating despite the cool air. He cursed when the old wrapping came free, then apologized to no one in particular.

"Don't waste your voice," Nerissa told him.

"I thought you'd ask how it feels."

"I can see how it feels."

Panjios knelt at the end of the mat, showed her where the brace opened, and asked permission before lifting Samon's leg. Mariya noticed that he waited for Samon to answer. Darran had treated bodies underground as parts of a machine; the distinction mattered even if it could be practiced by someone serving the same distant seal.

The brace held the leg without pressing on the worst swelling. Samon's jaw loosened when the weight was taken off it. Nerissa inspected each point of contact and adjusted one strap herself.

"It works for tonight," she said. "Tomorrow is another count."

Panjios accepted that verdict.

Outside, Mariya asked him how many people his coast station could carry away.

"Under present authorization? Exceptional patients. A small team. Supplies."

"That's not what I asked."

"The opening can take people. The crossing isn't the part that's forbidden."

"So whose rule is it?"

Panjios glanced at the occupied ridge across the valley. "Several people have made that rule useful to themselves."

"Including your people?"

"Yes."

His answer was brief. Mariya preferred it to a speech, but it did not buy him her trust. If the rule could be changed, then every day it remained was somebody's decision. She thought of Thesia's sister and the missing names on the clay.

"Can Tobious come home after he goes?"

"There is a return procedure. I won't promise that a dangerous site will become safe on a date I choose."

"You'll have to say that to him."

"I have."

"Say it again."

* * *

Tobious arrived before dawn, escorted as far as the granary gate and then allowed to walk the last stretch himself. His lip was swollen. He had bound his right wrist in a strip of old linen, badly; the knot pressed where the swelling was greatest.

Mariya untied it without asking. He watched her hands.

"You always pull the knot toward the sore place," she said.

"It stays tied."

"So does a trap."

She rewound the cloth. It was easier to look at his wrist than at his face. Yesterday she had sent him below because he knew the channels. That had been reasonable; the reason had not saved Samon's leg or the dead guard. She had given his name to the officer without asking him, and he knew it. The words she needed were both defense and apology. She could not make either stand in for the other.

"I should have told you first," she said.

"I wouldn't have gone."

"I know."

"Then you still would have told them."

Mariya finished the knot. "I might have. We needed someone below who knew the drain. I should have let you answer for yourself."

He flexed his fingers once and winced. "They found something they wanted. I don't think Darran knew what would answer when he opened it."

"Did you?"

"No."

He glanced at the two protected seed jars behind her. The clay seals remained unbroken. It was a small sight, but she saw him take steadiness from it.

"Panjios brought grain," she said. "Two jars' worth, and a little more. The kernels look sound. Nerissa says the brace helped Samon."

"Lio?"

"At his aunt's. He made her keep the broken jug. She says she'll make a cup from the bottom."

Tobious exhaled. It was the first unguarded breath she had seen him take since he arrived.

"He asked me to go," he said.

"I heard."

"I wanted to say no."

"What changed?"

"I saw that place." He looked over the granary wall toward the sea. "He was there. A man with my face. I don't know if he was waiting for me or if it was already happening somewhere I can't reach."

Mariya let the silence stay long enough for him to hear himself. Then she asked, "What can Panjios teach you there?"

"How to keep the door from opening. Maybe how to go through it without bringing another of those things home."

"That's useful. It's a reason to go."

"You don't want me to?"

"I want you here. I also want this place to have more than two seed jars and a guard who knows he can take the rest."

"I could bring everyone across."

"Panjios says the crossing allows it. Their rules don't."

"Rules change."

"Sometimes. Learn which ones are walls and which ones are men standing in front of a doorway."

He gave her a sidelong look. "You sound as if you've already made me leave."

"I haven't made you do anything."

That, at least, was true. She knew how easy it was to turn love into a claim over someone else's choice. She had come close yesterday without giving it that name.

They went to the granary's rear steps. In the narrow space beneath the fig tree, the morning was still cool. Tobious sat with his injured hand resting on his knee. Mariya leaned against the wall beside him, their shoulders touching.

"When this is over," he said, "I want a week when the only thing we count is how many figs you take before they dry."

"You'd have to stop taking them first."

"I could learn."

"That's a more difficult training than Panjios is offering."

He laughed once, surprised by it. Then his face changed. "I mean it."

"I know."

She looked down at their hands. His left lay open on the step between them. She put hers beside it, close enough that the sides of their fingers met. There was no promise in the contact that could make a road safe or a village free. She wanted it anyway.

"I want the week too," she said.

For a while they listened to people opening shutters along the lane.

"I'll stay here," she said. "I'll find out who they send below and where. You come back with what you learn. Don't come back with a promise that everyone will be safe."

He turned his hand beneath hers. "Then what do I promise?"

"That you'll tell me what you actually know."

He agreed. In the first light, they worked out something less beautiful and more useful than a vow. Mariya would scratch the leaf from his family's jar onto any supply wrapper she sent through Panjios's next delivery, with a second mark beneath it for the number of workers she had counted. Tobious would ask at the coast station when a return message could travel. If no message came, neither would pretend the silence meant consent.

Below them, the mill began to turn. Somebody had found enough grain to keep it working for another day.

The Far Shore

Tobious spent the morning repairing a door he did not want anyone to use.

The lower frame remained sealed, but water had begun to rise behind the stones dropped in the collapse. If it filled the chamber, pressure would find a crack. Tobious showed Panjios where the old west drain met the bay channel and watched the older man order a new brace placed above the broken clamp. Darran stood on the far side of the chamber with Therren's men, permitted to observe and forbidden to touch the frame.

Tobious had drawn the short straw for fastening the drain grate. His right wrist was bound, so he worked with his left hand while a village mason held the bar. Every task took longer than it ought to. Twice he dropped the peg. Once the mason picked it up without remark. The second time she said, "You can hold the lamp."

He gave her the tool. She had come below because her father knew the old walls and she knew how he had repaired them. Tobious knew the water. Between them, the chamber stayed dry. He wondered whether the future city had people who spent their days refusing to let ancient stone fail.

At the top of the stairs, Samon waited on a chair brought from his sister's house. He had insisted on coming to see the brace before Tobious left. The fitted support held his leg straight, and someone had given him a stick he could not yet use.

"The east joint?" Samon asked.

"Packed. The overflow goes west."

"Until the next rain."

"The mason knows."

Samon watched the woman follow Panjios out of the passage. "She does."

Tobious had expected approval. Instead Samon looked toward the channel leading under the village.

"Who's taking the sluice above your field?"

"Mariya has it arranged."

"With whom?"

"The millers. And the mason's brother."

"She didn't ask me."

"You told her yesterday you would break the other leg before you let a novice adjust it."

Samon grunted. "Then she listened."

Tobious crouched so they were eye to eye. Samon was a man he had known since he was small enough to carry one end of a reed mat while Samon bore the other. There were things Tobious wished to say about the beam and the rope, but Samon had not asked for thanks or apology. He had asked about the sluice.

"I'll come back," Tobious said.

Samon looked at the right hand Tobious kept close to his body. "Come back with that healed. I don't need two useless repairers."

It was as much blessing as Samon would give in front of Darran.

* * *

Mariya walked with Tobious as far as the path descending from the lower terraces. She carried a small bundle of bread, figs, and a change of linen. He told her Panjios had supplies enough to feed him. She handed him the bundle anyway.

"This is food from here," she said. "You'll know what you've eaten."

The morning wind moved the olive leaves in pale waves. Below the fields, the bay lay blue and ordinary. Fishermen were drawing in their boats under the watch of two soldiers on the beach. Tobious had walked this path all his life, carrying baskets to the shore. Today every bend seemed to belong to some earlier version of himself.

They stopped where the last field wall gave way to scrub.

"Panjios says the clocks move together," Tobious said. "When I spend a day there, you spend one here."

"He showed me the return register."

"You checked?"

"It had dates, names, and arrivals written in two hands. It could still be false. It was better than a promise with no names in it."

"You shouldn't have to count every word anyone says to us."

"Then they should stop giving us reasons."

He knew the line of her mouth when she was tired. He could have reached for the old easy argument, told her that when he returned, she could rest. She would have called it a lovely plan and then shown him the list of things that needed doing before sunset.

Instead he asked, "What will you do today?"

"Ask why the lower labor tablet lost three names. Send Thesia's sister a portion under her own household. Talk to the boatmen while they're angry enough to answer."

"You planned all that before breakfast?"

"I planned the last one during breakfast."

She adjusted the bundle on his shoulder. The cloth brushed his neck. He wanted her hand to stay there, and felt ashamed that he wanted it when she had so much left to do.

"You can want me here," she said.

He looked at her.

"You keep treating it like an accusation."

"I don't want to leave you to this."

"I know. I don't want to be left. Both things can be true."

The village bell sounded from above, a bronze dish struck when water was drawn for the common store. He had never thought he would miss that badly made noise.

"If I find a way to bring you through—"

"Tell me what it costs before you decide for me."

He nodded. She had given him the same condition yesterday. It had sounded simple then. Now he understood that the distance he was about to cross could make truth harder than reassurance.

He took her hand with his left. She leaned forward and rested her forehead against his for a breath. The touch was brief, but it outlasted the bell.

"Come back honest, Tobi," she said.

Panjios waited where the path turned toward the shore. He watched the sea and allowed them their time. When Tobious joined him, Mariya was already walking uphill. She did not turn. Tobious understood that she had work to do; he watched until the wall hid her from sight.

It took them forty minutes to reach the salt flats and another twenty to follow the broken shore to the abandoned storage caves. Tobious counted the turns. If he had to return alone, he wanted to know where the sea cut off the path at high water and where a person could climb the rocks.

The cave mouth had been disguised with a wall of collapsed jars and brushwood. Panjios entered first. Inside, the air was dry enough to sting Tobious's throat. Salt had left white fur in the cracks of the stone. Men had once scraped it into baskets here; their grooves remained in the floor.

Three people waited beside a low frame of dark material fitted into the back wall. One checked Panjios's tag against a tablet that gave off its own soft light. Another inspected the bundle at Tobious's shoulder. The third stood by a shallow basin whose surface remained smooth despite the draft from the cave mouth.

"The village station was damaged," Panjios told Tobious. "This one is scheduled, watched, and used for small loads. You may still turn back."

Tobious looked at the basin. A lantern's flame leaned toward the frame as a line of brightness formed along it. The water stirred; a cold, clean current came through the opening. Whatever appeared this time, air was moving. There would be a floor to step onto.

"If I cross, how do I know when I can return?"

The clerk turned the tablet so Panjios could read it. He translated the entry for Tobious, then made the clerk repeat the terms slowly. The register named a receiving station, an outgoing opening time, and a corresponding day on this shore. Some dates were marked delayed, with a reason beside each; several had been completed. Tobious could not read the marks, but Panjios pointed to the people standing there who had traveled through on previous schedules. They described the same number of days elapsed on both sides.

"And if the route is closed?" Tobious asked.

"You wait for authorization or a safe diagnostic opening," Panjios said. "I will not pretend that the return is yours to command today."

It was a hard answer to give to a man standing by a door. Tobious believed Panjios wanted him to cross. He also believed the man had left room for refusal. That room mattered.

Tobious put his palm on the dry stone beside the frame. He thought of the old chamber, the guard's spear falling, Samon's leg under a beam. Then of Mariya's fingers on his hand. The two thoughts did not balance like grain on a scale. One did not cancel the other.

"I want the next message window written for me," he said. "And for Mariya."

Panjios spoke to the clerk. A mark was entered beside Tobious's name, with Mariya's scratched leaf beside it.

Tobious stepped through.

The floor did not disappear. He felt one change of pressure, like entering deep shade after walking in sun. The cave fell behind him. Ahead was a room of light and smooth walls, crowded with cases, workers, and a smell of warm metal. A woman in gray asked him to move clear of the receiving line. Panjios repeated the instruction in his language, but Tobious was already stepping aside. People behind him needed to come through.

He turned once. Through the gate he saw the salt cave, its white walls and broken jars. The clerk on that side raised a hand in farewell to the people beside him. A field narrowed across the view; the cave was gone.

He had crossed centuries, though the movement itself had taken less time than lifting a jar.

* * *

The city called Veyr climbed the cliffs where Tobious had known only a ridge and a citadel.

Panjios led him onto an open walk. Above them, roads crossed through empty air. Some were broad enough for whole crowds; others carried narrow silver carriages without horses, their motion so smooth that Tobious had to watch their shadows to see how fast they went. Along one wall, water rose in clear tubes to terraces planted with unfamiliar green. Higher still, a surface darkened as

the sun struck it, shading windows beneath. The city seemed to know the heat before its inhabitants did.

At the far end of the valley stood towers layered with gardens. Their upper reaches caught cloud shadow; their lower floors opened onto workshops, food stalls, and passages under repair. People wore fabrics that moved easily with them, some patched and some so fine that no seam showed. A child rode in a wheeled chair that followed her father's hand. A worker carried a basket of fruit on his head in the old way. Tobious had expected the future to make the past impossible to recognize. It had found room for both kinds of effort.

He stopped at the edge of the walk. Through the open space below, he could see the bay. Its shoreline had been moved. A long wall now reached into the water where his village's small boats would have beached. For a moment he could not place Aras at all. Then he found the shape of the hill and knew that somewhere beneath these roads lay the stone his mother had once touched.

"How many people live here?" he asked.

"More than I could count for you without a register," Panjios said.

"That many?"

"I think you'd object if I guessed."

Tobious smiled despite himself.

They boarded a carriage that ran inside a clear-sided channel. Tobious kept one hand around a rail. At the first turn, a voice spoke from the wall. He understood Panjios's reply but none of the written signs that changed above the doors. He tried to keep the symbols in mind. They changed faster than he could name their shapes.

The carriage stopped partway through the climb.

At first nobody complained. A woman closed her eyes and leaned against the wall. Then the lights dimmed and a low alarm sounded twice. Panjios asked the driver a question. She answered in a rush; Tobious caught only the translated words *carrier delay* and *service tier*.

Below the channel, people in gray work coats emerged onto a narrow maintenance walk. One held up a darkened unit from the carriage's side. Another passed her a replacement, but the bracket

would not seat. A queue gathered behind the stopped carriage, and heat began to collect inside it.

“Can we open this?” Tobious asked.

“Not while the next carrier might move,” Panjios said. He touched a panel beside the door and spoke to the driver. A vent opened above them, letting cooler air in.

Through the floor Tobious could see the repair team working. The towers and bridges had seemed to hang by will alone. Here were bolts, hands, a woman asking for a different tool because the first had slipped. The city was held up by people who knew where it failed.

When the carriage moved again, the passengers continued their interrupted talk. For Tobious the delay stayed with him. Wonder had acquired a sound: the knock of a worker fitting a stubborn bracket into place.

At the upper stop, Panjios guided him away from a gallery whose walls displayed bright images of armed figures. Tobious slowed at the sight of blades.

“Later,” Panjios said. “First, someone looks at your wrist.”

“It works.”

“You held the rail with the other hand for the entire ride.”

Tobious looked down. The binding Mariya had tied remained firm. He had wanted the city to see him as the man who closed a dangerous door. Panjios had seen a patient protecting a swollen joint.

They entered a clinic beneath a roof that filtered the afternoon light into a gentle gold. A man with a burn on his arm waited beside a woman asleep against a stack of folded coats. Nobody asked which of them had come from an ancient shore before bringing them water.

Tobious took the cup offered to him. It was clear and light and did not break when he set it down too hard. He thought of Lios collecting the pieces of his clay jug. An entire city lay between the two boys' cups, and the distance had been crossed in a step.

He drank. Then he gave the cup back and followed Panjios toward the examination room.

A City That Does Not Sleep

The physician asked Tobious to put both hands on the table. He put down the left. The right stayed against his chest.

“That one too,” she said.

Panjios had spent the walk to the clinic translating for him. Now a small curved piece rested behind Tobious's ear, and the woman's words arrived in Aras speech a fraction after her mouth moved. She pointed at the device when she noticed his glance.

“It will miss some words,” she said. “Ask when it does. My name is Edda.”

Tobious offered his right hand. Edda did not take it until he nodded. She turned it gently, studied the swelling and bruising, then passed a wand above his wrist. An image appeared on a pane beside her: pale bones suspended inside a dark shape that had the outline of his own arm.

He jerked back.

“It's a picture,” she said. “You can put your arm down if you'd rather.”

He looked from the pane to the wrist. “How did it get inside?”

“It didn't. I can show you with mine.”

She scanned her own forearm. Another image appeared. Its small bones moved when she flexed her hand. He tried his fingers, and watched their counterparts stir on the pane. The city outside had roads in the sky; here it displayed a man's hidden skeleton without cutting him. Wonder was beginning to feel like labor. Every marvel needed learning before he could decide whether to trust it.

“No break,” Edda said. “The tendons need rest. This bruising along the ribs is less pleasing.”

She examined the place where the soldier's shield had struck him and cleaned the cut at his lip. The treatment stung, though less than the damp cloth Mariya had used. Edda sealed the cut with a clear dressing that clung without thread.

"I need the wrist in a support for several days. After that, movement a little at a time. A sword is out of the question until I say otherwise."

"I didn't say I wanted one."

"Panjios brought you through the Wardens' entrance. People often do."

She turned to write something on a tablet. Through the open door Tobious saw a woman in work clothes arguing with a clerk. A young man sat beside her with a burned palm pressed to his chest. The clerk kept pointing at a list. Edda set her tablet down and went out to them.

"The palm first," she told the clerk. "The registration can wait."

"The service company hasn't certified him."

"His hand has."

The clerk stepped aside. Edda brought the man to a wash station, then asked the woman how the burn had happened. He was not a Warden, not a visitor with Panjios. His care began before anyone established which office should pay for it.

When Edda returned, Tobious asked whether she worked for Panjios.

"For the clinic and the service ward. We take Concord patients because people arrive injured from Concord work. That doesn't give the Concord my records unless a patient permits it."

The translation piece rendered her last words slowly. He asked her to say them again. She did, and marked his injury certificate with a separate civic seal.

"This also lets me request a casualty review if an incident puts residents at risk," she said. "It doesn't mean every commander does as I ask."

Tobious believed that. He had met commanders.

* * *

Ypin arrived with a tool roll and an expression that suggested he would have preferred a broken pipe.

"I inventory field exposure," he said. "Anything you touched, anything that touched you, how long the route was active."

“Edda has already looked at me.”

“I’m not here to look at your bones.”

He set a slim recorder on the table and waited. Tobious did not pick it up. Ypin was perhaps a year younger than he was, with cropped hair and a jacket repaired at one elbow. Its pockets carried the small weight of tools. He had the fingers of someone used to reaching into narrow places.

“You sound angry,” Tobious said.

“I have three transport pumps waiting because a station that shouldn’t have been commissioned woke under your village.”

“Then blame whoever commissioned it.”

Ypin considered him. “I do.”

It was a more useful answer than Tobious had expected.

They began with the lower chamber. Ypin asked how the water had stood, which hand Tobious had used, where his blood had touched the frame, how long he had heard the first hum. Tobious could answer some questions exactly. Others dissolved when he tried to distinguish one frightened heartbeat from the next.

“You don’t know the duration?” Ypin asked.

“I knew the water was going down.”

“That is a condition, not a duration.”

“And it was the condition that mattered to us.”

Ypin looked at his recorder. “Fair.”

The translation piece faltered whenever he named a part of the root. He stopped using the terms, drew a quick picture instead, and showed how three surface sites joined one lower line. Tobious recognized the village frame, the shore cave, and a third place uphill among old stone workings.

“This is the Quarry,” Ypin said. “We can service it. We cannot build you a fourth place to stand.”

Tobious asked why a machine buried beneath Aras could have a repair station in Veyr. Ypin showed him a layered drawing: one outline of the bay and ridge, another fitted over it, with roads and towers where the old terraces had been.

“Same ground,” he said. “Twenty-six hundred years between the two readings.”

Tobious did not know the marks representing the number. Ypin made groups on the table with Edda's spare counters: twenty-six stones, each one standing for a hundred harvests. They covered the length of the table. Tobious ran a finger beside them and stopped halfway.

His mother had once stood on the terrace where the Civic Spine rose. Twenty-six hundred winters had passed over that piece of ground. The stone might have been moved, ground to dust, built into another wall. He could not measure such time by walking it.

"Does anyone remember Aras?" he asked.

"There are records," Ypin said. "Some names. Less than you'd want."

Tobious looked at him sharply. Ypin met his gaze.

"I meant the records are incomplete. I wasn't saying the people were."

He finished the inventory without trying to make Tobious less uneasy about the distance. Before leaving, he adjusted the translation piece so that it sat more securely behind Tobious's ear.

"It will understand common speech," he said. "Labels are another matter. If a door tells you something, ask a person before walking through."

"You said you had pumps waiting."

"They've waited this long."

The corner of Ypin's mouth moved, barely.

* * *

On the fourth day, Panjios took Tobious beyond the clinic. Edda had cleared him to walk, provided he kept the wrist supported and rested when his ribs began to hurt. Tobious nodded at the instruction in her presence and broke it within an hour by trying to climb a service stair two steps at a time. The ribs reminded him before Panjios did.

They crossed a public terrace beneath a roof that changed its shade as the sun moved. Food grew behind clear walls: climbing beans, leaves the size of his hands, roots suspended in moving water. In Aras they counted jars because a bad season could leave empty

fields. Here people cultivated above the road, yet a line at the food counter stretched around the terrace.

At one end of the terrace a musician played a stringed instrument whose sound moved through the paving in low pulses. A small crowd had gathered around her, some eating while they listened, others waiting with empty bowls. Across the open walk, a cleaner was replacing a cracked transparent tile with a tool that lifted it without touching the people passing on either side. The city gave the impression of having solved every old difficulty from a distance. Up close, it held a woman trying to keep a tune steady over the noise of repairs, and a worker asking pedestrians to give him enough room to do a careful job.

Tobious tried to buy a portion for the musician. The counter would not accept the old bronze bead he had carried from home. Panjios paid from his service account and then showed Tobious how the public meal credit worked. Visitors received a small allotment until they were registered; residents earned and exchanged more through their work and civic share. The system was generous enough to feed someone who had just crossed from Aras. It was also a system he could not use without a translator and a person willing to explain its marks.

“Why are they waiting?” Tobious asked.

“A reservoir in the lower ward is down,” Panjios said. “Those growers will use more water to keep the roots cool. Some kitchens are cutting portions until the service teams finish.”

“All that green, and a broken pump still makes people hungry.”

“Yes.”

At a transit junction, a warning sounded. It was not the soft delay from Tobious's first carriage ride. A service platform had stopped above an open maintenance shaft, its underside caught on a bent guide. Three workers were stranded inside. Below them lay a walkway crowded with people trying to move away. The platform lurched as its drive tried to reset.

A man in a dark field jacket crossed the junction at a run. He looked once at the platform, once at the guide, and began giving orders. Two Wardens formed a line at the lower walk, directing

people back. Another brought a shield unit to the shaft's edge. The man's voice carried through the noise without rising.

"Cut the drive. Manual hold at the west rail. No one underneath it."

Panjios moved to the rail. "Suss."

The commander glanced at him, then at Tobious. "Keep your visitor behind cover."

Tobious disliked the word *visitor* enough to follow the order slowly. He saw why when the platform jerked again. A length of guide peeled away and struck the floor where he had been standing.

One of the Wardens set a shimmering field between the falling fragments and the people retreating along the walk. The field caught the first piece. The second struck beside it and showered them with dust. The Warden braced herself; the shield had changed the force, not removed it.

"Shield line, how much heat?" Suss called.

"One more hit this size. Then I move."

"Move before it."

He climbed a narrow service ladder toward the platform. A shield gathered around him, so faint Tobious had to find its edge against the flashing warning lights. Another Warden held a line from below. Ypin appeared at a maintenance panel with his tool roll already open.

"The west latch isn't taking a command," Ypin shouted. "The bracket is bent through the socket."

"Manual access?"

"One span above you. The hatch opens inward."

Suss reached it. The platform tilted. He caught a rail, pulled himself to the hatch, and called to the people inside. They answered, frightened but coherent. He gave them one instruction at a time: move to the east wall, secure the loose case, put their hands where he could see them when the hatch opened.

He drew a short blade and set it against the twisted latch. His shield vanished. The line operator stepped closer below, lifting his own field toward the exposed commander. Three heartbeats passed as Suss held the blade in place. The latch parted. The platform shifted hard enough to drive his shoulder into the frame.

“One at a time,” he said.

He brought the first worker through and clipped her to the line. The operator lowered her. The second came with a cut above his eye. The third had a trapped ankle and could not move. Suss did not pull him free by force. He asked Ypin whether the drive could hold still for thirty breaths.

“Twenty,” Ypin said. “I’ll give you twenty and then you have to get clear.”

“Make it nineteen.”

He reentered the platform with the blade and freed the pinning bracket. When he passed the worker to the operator, a warning heat shimmer crossed Suss’s shield and went red at the edges. He dropped down the ladder rather than pretending it would take another blow.

The platform sagged onto its manual hold after he reached the floor. No one cheered until the third worker was on a stretcher. Then the sound came in fragments, from people who had seen someone they knew come back alive.

Tobious went to help move a loose barrier from the evacuation route. His wrist resisted. The shield operator took the heavier end without comment, letting him carry the light one. Suss noticed them as he checked the rescued man’s ankle.

“You came through Salt yesterday,” he said to Tobious.

“Yes.”

“Your hand’s still injured. Don’t make my operator explain to your physician why you used it here.”

The operator made a sound that might have been a laugh. Suss took off his shield unit and handed it to a technician.

“The charge is spent,” he said. “Replace it before the next lift. A shield you cannot trust should be called a lamp.”

He walked beside the stretcher until the clinic transport arrived. Tobious had seen him risk his life for workers who looked nothing like commanders. That did not prove what kind of man Suss was in every matter. It proved he knew how to bring people down from a failing platform.

* * *

On the fifth day, Panjios and Suss brought Tobious to a room overlooking the coast. Ypin was there to run a map. He stood apart from the two Wardens, with the posture of a man who expected to be asked for numbers rather than judgment.

The map rose from the table in layers. Tobious found the old ridge only after Panjios turned off the future roads. Three points burned in the ancient landscape: beneath Aras, beside the salt shore, and in the quarry hills. A single line joined them to a point under Veyr's Civic Spine.

"One root," Panjios said. "Three places to reach it from your side."

"The one beneath Aras is broken."

"Damaged," Ypin corrected. "It still takes power. That's why yesterday's thing could come through."

"It didn't stay," Tobious said. "Why?"

Ypin spread his hands, searching for an ordinary comparison. Suss answered first.

"It can hold a shape near an active route. When you collapsed that route, it lost the current that held it here. It retreated before it came apart."

Tobious remembered the creature drawing itself back toward the fading light. What he had taken for fear had been need.

"If the door opens again, others can come."

"Yes," Suss said. "And the root is beginning to lean on your contact to remain steady. We need you to learn how to hold it while we repair the damaged receiver."

"Lean where?" Tobious asked.

Ypin separated the two outlines of the bay with his hands, then let their edges touch. "When the damaged root cannot keep the eras apart, the pressures in one begin to reach the other. A wall can shift where no wall should be. A service line can carry heat from a room that hasn't been built yet. The old records call the runaway overlap Schlelberg."

Tobious tried the word once. It told him nothing about the stone under his mother's field. "And the Iwang?"

"They use the gradients between the volumes," Ypin said. "A live seam lets them take shape on a side they could not otherwise reach. The overlap gives them more seams."

The map had three bright points. Tobious thought of a fourth appearing where Mariya slept, or where the city held its gardens. A word for the process did not make it less frightening. It made it possible to ask which part of it they had actually measured.

"And if I won't?"

"Then we have worse options. I would rather make a trained operator than a trapped man."

Panjios showed him the first training schedule: care for the wrist, observation, controlled movement, then contact work. Nothing on the page promised a sword before he could close his hand without pain.

"What about the people living near the other two places?" Tobious asked. "If you open them, do they know?"

Suss touched the Salt point. "This route operates under an arrangement with coastal authorities. Openings are logged and limited. The quarry is surveyed before use."

"And Aras?"

"Its receiver should not have been woken without a guarded crew," Panjios said. "Darran's commission is under review."

Tobious watched the three lights. The map showed land and routes, not homes. He tried to place Mariya's granary, Samon's sister's house, Lios's aunt. Their village was a bright point no larger than his fingernail.

"I want messages going both ways," he said. "If the work in Aras changes, she needs to know. If the village counts people your map doesn't, I need to know."

Ypin looked at him for the first time as though a question had been asked of him rather than about him.

"The shore relay can carry a small packet on its service window," he said. "I can show you what fits."

Suss nodded. "Within the safety schedule. And if the village site shifts, I want the report as quickly as you do."

Tobious believed that, too. He had watched Suss work under a falling platform. He had learned enough in five days to know that wanting to save people did not make anyone's numbers complete.

“Then I'll train,” he said. “Tell me where I begin.”

Names on Clay

On the sixth morning after the seed levy, Mariya broke one of the king's seals.

She did it with a narrow piece of wood, lifting the clay from the cord so that the bull's head remained almost whole. It was a small deception, and she disliked how readily her hands found it. Behind her, the granary was empty. The first light had not reached the jars.

The lower quarter had no barley left for the day's bread. A woman from the shore had brought three fish, but they would not feed the children whose fathers had been kept at the old storehouse. An older household had spent its last pulses and was living on figs too hard to chew. Mariya could wait for the next coastal delivery; she could not make a hungry child wait with her.

The granary wall held the clay marks of families who had deposited seed before the occupation. Some had brought a full basket; some had poured a handful from a cloth. The jar she approached belonged to all of them in uneven shares. She knew which household had carried grain uphill despite a sick child, which had argued about keeping more for the next sowing, and which had given because the village would otherwise have no field to plant. The king's seal had been pressed over those smaller choices as though his mark made the contents his.

She took a shallow bowl from the jar she had opened. Each scoop felt heavier than it was. The grain smelled sound. A measure of it could keep six people through the day if it was ground with what the mill still held. In the field, that same measure might become enough seed for a row that would feed them next year.

She replaced the cord and pressed the old seal back onto it. The edge would betray her to anyone who looked closely. On the back of her waxed board, where she kept the household portions, she cut a private mark for the withdrawal. She did not put a name beside it.

At the mill, she gave the grain to Thesia, who was waiting with her sister's two children. Hessah's mother helped turn the stone. No

one asked where the barley had come from. Mariya understood that their silence might be gratitude, or fear of being asked to testify. She let them work.

The handstone rasped over the grain. The younger child wanted to turn it and was allowed three slow circles before his arms tired. Thesia showed him how to gather the flour from the edge without spilling it into the dust. Hessah's mother worked the larger stone with her whole weight. She said the flour would be coarse, then took it to the oven anyway. Mariya had expected the stolen measure to become bread almost at once. Between the jar and the meal were hands, heat, water, and time she had not provided.

By midday the bread had gone. One child saved a piece in her sleeve for her father, who was among the workers below. Mariya did not tell her when he would come home. She had made enough promises on behalf of men with spears.

Nerissa found her washing the empty bowl.

"Which jar?"

Mariya kept the water running over the wood. "The one nearest the wall."

"Did the households agree?"

"They were hungry."

"I heard your answer. It isn't the one I asked for."

Mariya set the bowl down. Nerissa's sleeves were rolled to the elbow; a smear of medicine darkened one cuff. She had come from Samon's house, where the leg would still need tending after the visitor's brace stopped being new.

"I marked what I took," Mariya said.

"For whom?"

"For when we meet."

"And if somebody opens the jar before then?"

"Then they'll see it."

"A broken seal tells them who used the grain. It doesn't tell them why you thought you alone could decide."

Mariya wanted to answer that she had been the one awake before dawn, that the children would not have thanked a meeting for making their food arrive tomorrow. Both things were true. Neither made the other households' share hers to spend without a word.

"I'll tell them," she said.

Nerissa dried her hands on her skirt. "Tell them before someone else finds the mark."

Mariya nodded. When the midwife left, she turned the board face down. She had meant what she said; she also knew she would delay until she had an amount precise enough to defend. The habit felt too much like the seal she had pressed back into place.

* * *

The missing labor names led her to the well.

Every day the palace men demanded water for the crews under the ancestor terrace. The delivery went by the lower lane and returned with fewer vessels than it took. Mariya waited where the mill wall shaded the path and counted the bearers. Four village adults went down. Three came back at dusk. The fourth was reassigned to the night shift without being entered on the public tablet.

At the well, the scribe said the worker had been counted with the quarry crew.

"Then let me see the quarry tablet," Mariya said.

"It is at the ridge."

"I can walk there."

"No passage without a permit."

"Then you can send for it."

The scribe lowered his stylus. He was a tired man whose hands had the calluses of someone who wrote more than he dug. He did not threaten her. He called a guard to move her away from the well.

Mariya went. The exchange had given her what she needed: the tablet was not here, and he expected her to stop at that answer. She waited until the guard was back by the shade, then circled through the potters' lane to the house of the reassigned worker. His wife knew nothing of a quarry posting. She had prepared supper for him and now sat with it growing cold.

There were two bowls on the low table, both filled. The wife had left the larger one beside the door, where her husband would find it after a late shift. She asked Mariya whether the scribe had written an

injury. He had not. Then she asked whether Mariya had seen anyone carried out under cloth. Mariya had not seen that either. She gave the answers separately. A single “I don't know” would make the woman imagine both possibilities at once and might sound as though Mariya had not bothered to ask.

The wife told Mariya the man always tied his work sandal twice because the heel had split. It was a detail no tablet kept. Mariya put it on her own board beside the missing name. If she saw a sandal through the ration hatch, she could ask before the guard moved its wearer away.

“Don't go to the captain yet,” Mariya said. “Let me ask the water carriers.”

The woman looked at the bowl on the table. “If he's below, why did they say he's uphill?”

“I don't know.”

It was an answer Mariya was learning to give more often, and still hated.

Lios found her at the lower cistern. He carried a cup made from the bottom of his broken jug. The rim had been ground smooth. He offered it for her water without explaining why he had brought it; she drank and returned it carefully.

“They use the passage behind the old ovens,” he said. “Not the stairs by the well.”

“Who?”

“The ones who carry water down after dark. I went with them before the rope came off.”

“Where does it meet the storehouse?”

“At a door with a broken red mark. They leave full jars there. Somebody opens it from inside.”

He put his finger on the cistern's stone rim and drew the turn of the path. It was a child's route, remembered because he had walked it carrying too much weight. Mariya knew the ovens. If Lios's door was where he placed it, the public labor stair did not account for everyone going below.

“You don't need to go again,” she said.

“I wasn't offering.”

“I know.”

He took back the cup. "My aunt says I should stop looking down the old lane. She says if I keep thinking about it they'll put the rope back."

"Your aunt wants you safe."

"I want that too." He hesitated. "Does wanting it make me a coward?"

Mariya thought of Tobious pulling him up the stairs while a man died behind them. "No. It means you know what happened."

He looked at the cup in his hands. "It holds less now."

"It's still yours."

He went to fill it again, though he had not emptied it. Mariya waited until he was out of sight before tracing his route in her own board. She had a place to watch and a name to ask about. The palace tablet had offered neither.

* * *

At the shore, the fishers were arguing with a group of grain carriers from the next inlet. Therren's men had raised the passage toll, and the carriers wanted payment in oil as well as a share of anything they brought. Mariya knew one of them, a woman who had borrowed Aras's millstones in the spring after her own cracked.

Their boats were pulled above the tide on rollers slick with fish oil. A boy was scraping barnacles from a hull while the adults argued; he kept listening because the toll would decide whether he went to sea with them tomorrow or walked the ridge with a basket. One carrier had already paid the soldiers and wanted the others to pay too, before refusal singled out his household. The woman Mariya knew said a second toll would leave too little oil for the lamps used on the night crossing. Nobody at the shore was choosing between courage and cowardice. They were choosing which risk their families would see first.

"If we keep the grain on your boats," Mariya said, "the soldiers will take it when you beach."

"If we carry it over the hill, they will take it on the road."

"Then send what you can in small loads with the fig traders. They already have permission to pass."

“Small loads feed fewer people.”

“They arrive.”

The carrier woman looked toward the occupied ridge. “You want us to break the toll?”

“I want you to tell the other inlets what is happening here. If their carts stop for one day, the captain has a problem too.”

“And if he sends soldiers?”

“Then we’ll have to decide together whether a day is worth it.”

“My mother lives beyond the ridge,” the woman said. “If the carts stop, her bread stops with them.”

“Then we do not call a stoppage without arranging hers,” Mariya answered. “Tell me which households cannot wait a day.”

The woman named three. Mariya wrote them before she wrote any proposed action. She was learning that a demand could only be as strong as the people it could keep fed while they made it.

Mariya had no authority to pledge other villages to danger. She could ask them to see the leverage they shared. The carrier promised to speak with two more households before sending an answer. It was less than Mariya wanted. It was a real promise she could count.

That evening, Panjios’s supply porter came through the lower lane. He had no grain this time, only medical cloth and a small bundle of service parts. He would return by Salt Gate before the next scheduled opening. Mariya wrapped a scrap of linen around one part and scratched a leaf through the wax with her thumbnail. Beneath it she made seven short strokes: the original labor group as she knew it. On another fold she marked four, the number the palace tablet admitted. She added the name of the man reassigned at the well and the route Lios had shown her.

“This goes to Tobious,” she told the porter.

“There are limits on what I can carry.”

“It is one strip of cloth.”

“I meant what can be said about the site.”

“If you leave it here, you will have to tell him yourself why you did.”

The porter put it under the service parts. She watched him close the bundle. She could not know whether the message would survive the station clerk, the route, or the people who liked their records

short. She could make it legible to the one person who would recognize the leaf.

When he left, she climbed to the granary. The sealed jar waited in the dark, a hairline fracture visible in the clay she had pressed back around the cord. She had counted seven workers and four names. She had measured out grain and hidden the measure. The difference between her and the scribe did not absolve her. It told her how urgently she needed to put her own account where other people could challenge it.

The Weight of a Shield

On the sixth morning after the levy, while his wrist still held the shape of the soldier's blow, Tobious learned that a shield could not save him from his own feet.

Suss gave him a wooden training blade and told him to reach a painted line on the floor. A smaller trainee stood between him and it, protected by a field that showed only when the ceiling light slid across it. Tobious advanced as he would have gone at a man beside the granary door: fast, square-shouldered, determined not to be pushed back.

The trainee stepped half a pace aside. Tobious's wooden blade struck the field and skidded. She touched his unguarded ribs with hers. He tried to turn. His front foot caught behind the rear, and he fell.

The floor was softer than stone. His bruised chest did not care.

"Why did she reach you?" Suss asked.

"I missed."

"You gave her your whole weight before you knew where she would be."

Tobious sat up. "The shield stopped the blade."

"It redirected one short blow. Then she moved. The shield didn't move your feet."

Suss offered him a hand. Tobious took it with his left. The commander did not mention the right wrist. Edda had written its restrictions on his training card, and Suss had read them.

They tried again. This time Tobious watched the trainee's shoulder instead of the line. He kept his stance. She took a step toward him, he hesitated, and her blade touched his forearm before he could retreat.

"Better feet," Suss said. "Bad distance."

By the ninth attempt Tobious could feel the difference between advancing and falling forward. He still could not reach the painted

line. The trainee had trained for years. Her victory did not surprise anyone but him.

At the rest bell, he set down the wooden blade and found a cup of water. The room had clean walls, even light, a floor that softened when someone fell. At the granary, seven soldiers and a hard stone threshold had taught him the same lesson once. Here they had made a place where he could survive learning it again and again. He resented the difference as much as he was grateful for it.

Suss brought him a small shield unit, no larger than a fist, fitted to a band worn at the ribs.

"This protects against sudden force," he said. "It won't hold up a roof. It won't stop a slow hand from moving you. If you couple a powered blade to another field, your own full protection drops until the contact resolves."

He demonstrated with one of the experienced operators. Their blades met close enough that Tobious could hear a faint pulse between them. Suss held his edge there while the operator counted three heartbeats. His shield went pale, then disappeared at the moment his blade passed through a small marked sector of her field. A second operator stepped into his exposed side, raising cover while he drew back.

"Why bring the second person?" Tobious asked.

"Because I would have been unprotected where you stood."

The first operator, Jorra, took off her headpiece and wiped sweat from her brow. The other, Sennos, reset the timing board. They had the movements of people who trusted one another enough to complain about each other's habits. Sennos accused Jorra of counting too slowly. Jorra told him the shield did not care how flattering his numbers were.

Tobious looked at the narrow place where Suss's protection had failed. In Aras he had wanted a sword because the soldiers had one and he did not. Here a sword demanded that someone else keep him alive while he used it.

"Why a blade?" he asked. "You have machines that can move a carriage over empty air. Can none of them throw a point faster than a man?"

Sennos went to a cabinet and brought out a practice launcher. Its short bolt had a blunt head and a cord fastened to the shaft. He checked the cord's length with Jorra, then fired at her field from the marked distance. The bolt struck the faint light around her, lost its forward force across a wide curve, and fell. Tobious heard the head hit the floor before he heard the launcher settle in Sennos's hands.

"It still hurt," Jorra said. "Don't believe anyone who tells you the field eats a blow. It spreads one. A heavier bolt could move me; several might overheat this unit."

Sennos reeled the bolt in. On the second pass he aimed at a shield stand with no one behind it. The stand's warning rose after three impacts. Suss stopped the demonstration before the fourth.

"Why stop?" Tobious asked.

"Because now you've seen what happens when a defender has time to turn," Suss said. "The next bolt would tell you only how much this stand costs to repair."

He took the training blade and walked slowly toward Jorra. She let him bring its wooden edge close to her field. When he held it there, the shield did not throw him away as it had thrown the bolt; its light gathered at the point of contact. He made no cut. The exercise had no powered edge to complete one.

"Something held against one place can find a weakness," he said. "Our blades use that time. The person holding one must come close enough to be struck back. That is why the other shield matters."

Tobious thought of the spear at his neck in the granary yard. A Telassari archer could loose an arrow from beyond the threshing floor. Against these fields it would usually fail; against the workers behind them it would not. He asked whether Veyr had weapons large enough to break a shield from afar.

"Of course," Suss said. "Not ones I will turn on a cooling station with people inside, or on a root chamber whose walls are holding two cities apart." He returned the wooden blade to Tobious. "There are places where destroying the room wins a war. Our work begins when the room must survive."

Tobious took the blade. He understood why a Warden learned to stand close. He did not yet know whether a commander's promise to preserve a room included everyone standing in it.

The first days were short. Edda examined the wrist after every session and sent him away when the swelling returned. Suss accepted her limits without praising Tobious for obeying them. Panjios gave him tasks that required looking and thinking while his hand recovered.

On the tenth day they brought him to a training channel beneath the Civic Spine. Water ran through three clear-walled courses above a maintenance floor. If the downstream gate opened, a marker boat would pass safely. If they chose the wrong branch, it would strike a barrier. The exercise was meant to teach reading a system before cutting into it.

"You know water," Panjios said. "Tell me where the boat will go."

Tobious watched the small eddies gather at the west fork. "That one. The eastern channel looks open, but the water leans away from it."

He was right. The marker passed west. For an instant he felt the ease of being useful at something he already knew.

"Now change it," Panjios said.

Tobious found a gate wheel and turned it. Nothing moved. He put his shoulder against the rim, then stopped when a sound came from inside the wall: a low, rising strain. Panjios did not intervene. Ypin, who had been sent to keep the exercise from damaging a real pump, appeared from the service hatch.

"That's a powered valve," he said. "The wheel is an emergency release. Keep forcing it and you'll snap the hold."

"Then why put a wheel on it?"

"For when the power fails."

"It hasn't."

"No."

Tobious let go. He had treated a machine from this century as though it were the stubborn sluice above his field. Both moved water; they did not yield to the same hand.

Ypin opened a panel and showed him the valve's state. One line indicated commanded position. Another showed where the gate

actually sat. They did not match because silt had lodged against the lower lip.

“Which of those is true?” Tobious asked.

“Both. One says what someone asked. One says what the water got.”

Tobious looked at the marker boat waiting upstream. “Then we clear the lip.”

They shut the feed, drained a small section, and worked side by side with short scrapers. Tobious's wrist tired quickly. Ypin handed him a lighter tool without comment. When the valve moved cleanly, the water changed direction and the marker slipped down the east course.

Panjios wrote something on his card. Tobious could not read it, so he made Panjios say it aloud.

“You recognized the flow. You stopped when your first method failed. You asked for a different skill.”

“And if I had kept turning?”

“You'd be helping Ypin repair the whole assembly tonight.”

“He already is,” Ypin said. “I have to check what your shoulder did to it.”

Panjios left them with the panel open. Ypin inspected the housing while Tobious held a light. The technician showed him which parts were accessible to a maintenance worker and which still required an authorization from the root staff. Tobious asked why a man responsible for pumps could not open every panel. Ypin said that keeping someone from making a mistake was one reason. Keeping a fault from being noticed was sometimes another.

“Which reason is this?” Tobious asked.

“I haven't decided.”

It was the first time Ypin had said *I don't know* in a way that invited Tobious to look with him.

On the following day Suss gave Tobious a shield exercise with no blade. Two trainees stood at opposite ends of a short corridor. A barrier would send a harmless but forceful pulse toward them, first from one side and then from the other. Tobious could extend his field across one opening at a time. He placed himself halfway between the trainees and waited for the first warning.

The pulse came from the side he expected. He covered the nearer trainee, then ran to the far end while his shield unit warned of heat. By the time he arrived, the second pulse had struck the other trainee's practice field. The exercise ended without anyone hurt. Suss asked what Tobious had done well.

"I reached both."

"You reached the second after her own shield took the hit. What would you have done if she had been a patient with no field?"

Tobious looked at the corridor. He had treated his body as the only movable shield. Jorra showed him a stand that could hold the first opening while he covered the second. It required setting the stand before the warning, accepting that he could not know which side would be struck first. He resisted because choosing one place felt like giving up on the other. In the next run he placed the stand and called the two trainees by name before the pulse. Both had cover. He reached neither with a dramatic sprint.

"Better," Suss said. "A shield protects where it is. You cannot make it protect where you wish you had been."

Afterward Tobious sat with his wrist in Edda's cool support and watched the others reset the corridor. He could not train away the time he had been absent from Aras. He could learn to leave a place safe for someone else to stand. It was a less satisfying form of strength than he had imagined at the granary. It was beginning to look more useful.

* * *

In the days that followed, the clinic released Tobious's wrist from its support for longer periods. Edda measured how much force he could bear and sent him back to small motions when he tried to skip them. His pain changed from sharp to dull. It did not vanish.

He cut his hair one afternoon because the loose tie kept catching on the training collar. The woman who did it asked how short. He held his hand above his ears and then wished he had kept one lock longer when he saw himself afterward. Ypin said it made him look like every other recruit who had lost an argument with a collar.

Tobious asked whether Ypin had ever won that argument. Ypin touched his own cropped head and conceded he had not.

At a market under the service towers, Ypin bought them two thin cakes filled with sour fruit. Tobious had never tasted the fruit. Its sharpness made him pull a face so emphatic that the seller laughed. He bought a second cake to decide whether he liked it. Ypin said the fact that he had to check was answer enough.

For half an hour they sat at the edge of a public garden while water ran beneath the paving. Tobious described how a fig tasted when it had been stolen too early from a branch, and how Mariya could tell whose hand had taken it by the cut on the stem. Ypin told him which stalls in the service ward kept prices steady when the upper concourse ran short. Neither tried to turn the conversation toward the root. Tobious found that he had wanted such an hour more than he had known.

The next day Suss put a powered practice blade in his left hand. It was weighted like a working weapon but would shut down before it could cut flesh. Tobious expected the field to make the old motions easier. It made them more exacting. Contact had to be kept through movement, his own shield would drop, and a partner had to be in place before he committed.

He failed by rushing. He failed by waiting so long that the opponent moved. He failed once because he watched the blade and forgot where the exit lay. Suss stopped that attempt and took him to the room's edge.

"I can teach you a faster strike," he said. "It will not put an exit behind you. Your assignment is to get the people at the door home."

"I know the assignment."

"Then show me."

Tobious disliked the words. They resembled something Mariya would have said, and therefore gave him no one to blame for hearing them.

* * *

On the sixteenth day, Panjios gave the group a timed exercise. The painted room stood in for a damaged receiver. Jorra and Sennos

would operate the protective line; Ypin controlled a fixed shield stand at the exit; Tobious's task was to approach, make one guarded cut at a marked point, and withdraw with two civilians represented by weighted frames.

The first run failed before the cut. Tobious had calculated the distance to the marked point and left too little space for the first frame to turn. The training alarm sounded while he was still forcing it around a corner.

"They're people," Jorra said when they reset. "People don't become thinner because your diagram requires it."

She showed him how to angle the frame and where a stretcher bearer would need to stand. Sennos checked the line length. Ypin moved the shield stand nearer to the exit, but refused Tobious's request to place it at the marked point.

"It will lose the coverage we need at the door," he said. "I'm not putting everyone behind you without cover so your cut looks clean."

Tobious started to argue, then saw the uncovered strip Ypin meant. He altered his approach.

On the second run he waited for Jorra's signal, went in low, and held the blade against the marked point. One heartbeat, two, three. His own protection dropped. The empty air at his back felt suddenly very wide. Sennos stepped where they had agreed he would. The cut registered. Tobious withdrew.

An opposing trainee fell back, disarmed by the exercise field. Tobious took one step toward him, wanting to secure the room. He saw the first weighted frame still waiting beside the exit. He let the opponent go, took the frame's handle, and helped Jorra move it behind Ypin's cover. Sennos brought the second.

The alarm remained silent until all five were out.

Tobious expected triumph. What he felt first was relief that nobody had needed him to be brilliant. He had been where he said he would be. The others had been where they said they would be. The room had not rewarded courage; it had responded to a working arrangement.

"You gave up the chase," Panjios said.

"The exit was the assignment."

Panjios nodded. "That part was good."

Suss checked the recorded timing. “Your cut is still slow. Against a trained opponent, Jorra could not stand open for you that long.”

“I know.”

“Tomorrow we make it shorter.”

Panjios handed Tobious a new authorization card. He explained its marks before Tobious could ask: permission to observe the relic demonstration in Root Hall, not permission to carry the blade. Tobious looked at the three-line seal on the card. The same sign had appeared on Darran's drawing. In Veyr it opened doors; in Aras it had put men under the hill.

He slid the card into his pocket. He wanted to see what lay beyond that next door. He wanted, just as strongly, to know who had decided where the seal could be used.

The Unbroken Edge

The blade was shorter than the one Tobious had imagined when he was on his knees in the granary yard.

It lay under a clear cover in the memorial gallery, beside a shallow basin of black stone. The metal was pale and almost dull. A narrow dark channel ran from the guard toward the tip, stopping before the edge. The grip had been bound and rebound; one section wore a darker repair, another the faded impression of a hand that had held it for years. A small opaque core sat at the pommel. Nothing in the case moved. No light passed over the blade to tell him it was waiting.

Visitors had left tokens around the basin: a bent service pin, a child's painted stone, a strip of cloth worked with the old Warden crest. Someone had scratched a name on the pin so small Tobious could not read it. At home a village might hang a bronze spear above a hearth and tell the story of the arm that bore it. Veyr had kept a sword beneath a case, surrounded by offerings from people whose lives it had touched. He wanted to believe the object deserved them. He was wary of what people had been asked to forget in order to put it there.

"Severance," Panjios said. "The older title is the Unbroken Edge."

Tobious rested his hands on the rail. "The edge has been repaired."

"Several times. The name tells you what people needed it to mean."

Panjios opened a side panel showing the repairs. One had been made after a bridge collapse, another when a bearer held a seam through a cooling failure. The dark wrapping at the grip was newer than either. No bearer had carried the exact blade as it had first been forged. What endured was the work of people who refused to discard it when it could still protect a passage.

"Then why call it unbroken?" Tobious asked.

“Because the story was written before anyone saw the repairs up close,” Panjios said. He closed the panel gently. “The story kept people coming to the case. The repairs kept the blade worth coming for.”

Beyond the case, a wall carried the names of Wardens who had died defending crossings. Each name held its own small light. At the center was an image of an earlier bearer standing on a bridge whose far end had filled with Iwang. In the image she held Severance against a seam while people ran behind her. It was not a picture made with a painter's brush. The figures moved through a brief repeated interval: the bearer turning her head, a child lifted over the rail, the bridge's darkening span.

Tobious watched it twice.

“Did she live?”

“Long enough to close the route,” Panjios said. “Not much longer.”

The inscription described an evacuation in a sentence. It gave one number for the people saved and one name for the person who held the blade. Tobious felt the old desire stir in him: to be the one who could stand at a breaking point and change what followed. He also thought of the child in the image. Someone had lifted her. The blade-bearer had both hands occupied.

Ypin stopped beside him, a tool roll tucked under his arm.

“The maintenance crews aren't on the wall,” he said.

Panjios heard. “No.”

“Four teams held the bridge services open. Their report is in the archive. The inscription says she brought the people out.”

“She kept the route alive,” Panjios said.

“So did they.”

Tobious looked back at the moving image. He did not want it less because it was incomplete. He wanted to know who had decided that one visible courage was easier to remember than many.

“Could they put the names here?” he asked.

“They could,” Ypin said. “If somebody with the authority cared enough to request the correction.”

Panjios turned toward him. For a moment Tobious thought they would argue. Instead the older Warden said, "Bring me the report. We'll make the request."

Ypin's expression did not change. Tobious had come to know that he was more skeptical when given what he wanted than when refused it.

"The request has been made before," Ypin said.

Panjios looked at the wall. "Then bring the earlier answer too."

They left the gallery by a door that passed beneath the moving bridge. Tobious glanced up at the woman with Severance. In the repeated moment she turned her head, always toward something outside the frame. He could not see what she had seen before she made the cut.

* * *

The calibration room was smaller and less beautiful. Cables lay in marked channels on the floor. Three workers checked their instruments before allowing anyone near the blade. Edda had already certified Tobious's wrist for limited contact. She remained by the medical station, close enough to stop the test if his pulse or the root load changed too quickly.

One worker took a dry cloth to the grip and cleaned away the marks visitors had left on the case. Another checked the core without touching its surface. The third set a blank injury slate beside Edda's station. They had done this for other bearers and would record the result if this bearer failed. Tobious felt suddenly less like a hero arriving at a relic and more like a patient waiting for a procedure whose risks everyone else knew by name.

Another trainee lifted Severance first. She could hold it, turn it, and use its ordinary edge against a practice target. The dark channel remained dark. The core offered no sign that she was anything but a person carrying a well-kept weapon.

She handed it to Panjios. He set it on the stand before Tobious.

"No oath?" Tobious asked.

"There are oaths for Wardens. This isn't one of them."

"No test of character?"

“If it had one, our history would be simpler.”

Panjios said it quietly, then seemed to regret how much the answer held. Tobious could not ask for its meaning now. Three technicians were waiting, and the blade lay before him.

He placed his left hand on the repaired grip. It was warm from Panjios's hold. With the right, he touched the flat near the guard. Pressure gathered behind his teeth, the same pressure he had felt at the broken Receiver. The opaque core clouded, then cleared from within. A fine line traveled along the dark channel.

The instruments changed tone. Ypin named the readings to the senior calibrator, who confirmed each one. Tobious had expected a surge through his arm, perhaps a voice. He felt only the weight of the blade becoming more exact. It had been made for a purpose; the part of him the Receiver had taken could complete its circuit.

The line in the channel reached the old repair and hesitated. Tobious thought it would stop there. The calibrator held up a hand, asking the room to wait. The line crossed the repaired section and continued to the tip. No one cheered. Ypin let out the breath he had been holding. Tobious understood the crossing as a test of the work done on the blade, not of the man holding it. A weaker repair would have broken the circuit no matter how badly he wanted to be chosen.

“The reference accepts you,” the calibrator said.

“The machine accepted me by accident,” Tobious said.

She looked at him over the instrument. “Yes.”

The answer did not diminish the blade in his hand. It diminished the ease with which someone else might claim the blade proved him worthy.

Ypin showed him the service record. He pointed to an empty slot marked for a synthetic regulator and then to the reading from Tobious's contact. The regulator had broken before the Storehouse opening. In its absence, the system had used the first viable living signal against the exposed frame. Tobious remembered the blood on his knuckles. He had thought it might have called the door to him. It had merely helped carry his contact into a broken part.

“Could you put a new regulator in?” he asked.

“We would if we had an equivalent reference material,” Ypin said.

“We can replace the casing. The core is another matter.”

“Then use another person. Someone who knows what they’re doing.”

Panjios answered before Ypin could. “We can transfer a living reference under controlled conditions. It takes seven uninterrupted days with every receiver idle and both people present. We would install a substitute regulator, hold the root steady, and calibrate the change. It is possible.”

“Why haven’t you?”

“The damaged Storehouse isn’t reliably idle. The other two routes still carry essential service. You can be trained now. We haven’t yet been given seven quiet days.”

Ypin added, “A willing expert would still have to become the new reference. Expertise doesn’t make the seven days shorter.”

Tobious looked at the sword. He could set it down. The chamber would not punish him for doing so. Aras would still be beside a broken gate. Panjios would still need to find a way to close it. The possibility of another bearer mattered because it made the choice real, even if the easiest available person was him.

“Then show me what I would be doing,” he said.

The calibrator fitted a line from the stand to a practice barrier in the next room. She explained the modes without ceremony: an ordinary edge, a guarded local cut, and a terminal function intended for the root itself. The last required prolonged living contact and consumed the active core. Panjios did not dwell on it. The current task was to keep a receiver stable, not to destroy every route.

Tobious heard enough to remember. A tool that could end a connection might one day matter differently from a tool that kept it open.

* * *

On the practice floor, the barrier rose like a slab of dusk. It was not an Iwang and not a doorway. It held a measured field that would register whether Severance could separate one marked band without damaging the space beside it.

Jorra stood at Tobious’s right. Sennos covered the exit. Ypin monitored the barrier and held a reserve shield stand ready. Suss

watched from the far edge of the room; Edda watched Tobious's hands.

"Three heartbeats to find the contact," Suss said. "Do not chase the light. Keep the edge where the field presses back."

Tobious advanced. The blade seemed lighter once he moved, but his wrist objected when he tried to control it with both hands. He kept the right near the guard and let the left carry the weight.

He set the edge to the marked band. A line gathered in Severance's channel. One heartbeat. The barrier pushed sideways. He followed it too eagerly. His own shield faded, and he felt cool air against the back of his neck. Two heartbeats. The edge lost contact. The line died.

"Withdraw," Jorra said.

He did. She lifted cover between him and the barrier while the sword settled. Edda checked his pulse; it had climbed, but the root readings were within the range the calibrator wanted.

"I had it," Tobious said.

"For one heartbeat," Ypin said. "It needed three."

"I know how many."

"Then knowing isn't the part you need help with."

Suss came forward. He pointed to Tobious's feet. "You followed the band with your shoulders. Move one foot. Let the arm remain quiet."

Tobious tried the motion without the blade. It felt small. The first attempt had felt brave, as though forcing the sword through resistance might prove something. The small motion kept his balance.

They waited for the core to settle. A clock above Ypin's board counted thirty seconds from the end of the failed contact. Tobious watched each one. In the granary a soldier had ended his defense in less time than this sword needed to become ready again. A weapon that made a man wait was difficult to imagine as a miracle.

On the second attempt, Jorra told him she would cover his side when his field fell. He made himself believe she meant it. He placed his left foot, set the edge, and kept the right hand steady without asking it to bear the strain. One heartbeat. The barrier pressed back.

Two. He felt the temptation to turn his shoulders and stayed still. Three.

The marked band opened. Severance passed through a space no thicker than a stalk. The rest of the barrier held. Its dark surface trembled once, then quieted.

Tobious stepped back into Jorra's cover. His shield returned after the blade withdrew. A low sound went around the room. It was the crew acknowledging a successful calibration, not a crowd naming a king. He found himself wishing Mariya had seen it. Then he was glad she had not been made to stand near an untested root just to witness him use a sword.

"Again," he said.

Ypin held up a finger. The recovery clock had begun anew. "When it settles."

Tobious waited. Suss studied the clean cut and gave him a brief nod.

"Useful," the commander said.

Tobious had been called useful by Therren when the captain wanted his labor, by Darran when he wanted a hand on a broken frame. In Suss's voice it sounded like a place he might choose for himself. He knew the difference should matter. For one breath, the pleasure of being needed made it hard to remember why.

The Ninth Step

Mariya gained permission to enter the lower worksite by telling Darran that his people were eating from the wrong count.

She brought no accusation to the old storehouse. She brought a board of rations, its grooves worn deep by twenty-one days of revisions, and three small loaves she could show were missing from the delivery. Darran stood beneath the empty place where the woman-with-bowl statue had once rested. He wore a clean tunic, though the men coming up from the stairs had salt on their skin and gray dust in their hair.

"Your scribe writes a portion for every person assigned below," she said. "The kitchen sends a portion for every name it has. Those aren't the same people."

"The kitchen is your concern."

"The workers fainting under your stone are yours."

He studied her board. She had been careful to include genuine shortages from the mill and not only the names hidden from the tablet. A lie would be easier for him to dismiss than a problem that cost him labor.

"You can reconcile the meals," he said. "A guard goes with you. You touch no machinery."

Mariya almost asked whether the machinery could account for its own meals. She held her tongue. She wanted to reach the people who went through Lios's red-marked door.

The lower passage had changed since Tobious left. Wooden props braced the old walls. A new rail kept carts from striking the black frame. Thin lines of pale material had been fitted between stones that did not match them. Their glow was intermittent, like a breath taken under a blanket.

At the foot of the first stair stood baskets of crushed shell used to keep the damp floor from becoming slick. A village mason had shown Darran's crew where the old vault could bear a cart; someone had repaid him by adding his name to a longer labor shift. Mariya

recognized his wedge marks in the new props. The occupation had not built this place from nothing. It had used the knowledge of people who would later be told the works did not belong to them.

The guard brought her to a ration hatch built into the annex beyond the circular chamber. He kept one hand on his spear. Behind the hatch she found people stacking cut stone, sorting the pieces by marks Darran had given them. Another group cleared silt from a channel. The work had purpose; that made it more dangerous than mere punishment. Whoever wanted the old threshold had planned how to uncover more of it.

Thesia came first, asking for a sole to be tied back onto her sandal. "If I go down with a foot open, it will split," she said. She showed Mariya where the leather had parted. There was dried blood along the edge.

She had wrapped the broken sole in twine cut from a grain sack. Mariya offered to take her off the stone shift until it could be repaired. Thesia shook her head. "If I leave, they put my sister's eldest in my place. He still trips over his own feet." It was not pride in endurance. It was a choice made inside a rota Darran controlled. Mariya wrote the child's name beside the repair request so Darran could not solve one shortage by creating another.

Mariya added the repair to her board and gave her a strip of linen from the bundle she had carried in. The guard began to object, then saw Darran watching the cart work and let it pass.

Pehl, a broad-backed potter who made the jars for the common store, wanted a share of food kept aside for his child. "My daughter brings water at dusk," he said. "She won't eat until I do."

"What is her name?" Mariya asked.

"You know her. She spilled dye on the threshing floor last spring."

"I know. I want it written here."

He watched her carve the marks. The board could hold a line for a child whom the palace tablet did not count. It could not get her father out.

Annet complained that the water skins smelled stale. She spoke quickly, with the sharpness of someone who had asked twice and been told the smell was harmless. Hessah took one of the skins,

turned its mouth inside out, and found a seam leaking against the stopper. She retied it with a strip torn from her own hem, then gave it to Annet to test.

"I know the taste of bad water," Annet told the guard before drinking. "I do not need your permission to notice it."

The guard said the kitchen had delivered what it was ordered to deliver. He was not lying about the order. He had still watched them drink from the skin. Mariya made him hold the vessel while Hessah checked the rest. Two more mouths were damp. They would need clean strips and time to dry, neither listed on Darran's ration board. She added them there while he watched.

"The water is old," Hessah said. "The skin was making it worse."

Annet drank and passed it to a woman behind her. Mariya recorded both the complaint and the repair. If she wrote only the complaint, Darran could claim the vessel had been sound. If she wrote only the repair, the people who had drunk from it would vanish from the account.

The guard counted ten workers at the hatch. Mariya saw twelve. One had gone behind a baffle before he arrived, another knelt near a drain and was hidden from the passage. She kept her face on the board. When she reached the end of her ration marks, she had names for eleven. The twelfth had refused to say his while a Telassari guard stood beside him. She left a blank line rather than make one up.

Darran came to the hatch as she was closing it.

"You didn't need to speak to each one," he said.

"I need to know who eats."

"My man can give you a total."

"Your man gave me ten." She turned the board. "You have twelve."

Darran's gaze moved past her into the annex. "Two are on a different shift."

"They are here now."

For a moment his face lost the surveyor's patience. Mariya saw that she had taken a measurement he had preferred to keep fluid. Then he gestured toward the stairs.

"Finish before the next baffle cycle."

The ninth step was marked by a crack running through its center. Lios had told her to notice it. Water gathered in the crack, though the floor around it stayed nearly dry.

Mariya paused there as the guard went ahead. In a shallow bowl abandoned on a ledge, the surface trembled. She thought someone was walking on the upper stair. The sound came instead from inside the wall: a sequence of clicks, one high, two low. A pale seam opened across the passage a hand's width ahead of the guard. He stopped. After the third click, he crossed.

She watched where he put his feet. The seam had already begun to fade.

"Wait," Darran said from below.

She was halfway through moving. The guard caught her shoulder and pulled her back. A line of cold air passed over the toe of her sandal. The seam reappeared exactly where she would have stepped.

"Three clicks," she said.

"Three before the crossing," Darran answered. "Not three after the last opening."

Her mistake had been reasonable and would have hurt her. She wanted to be angry at him for letting her approach it. He had called out before she fell. She would have to use what he had shown her.

The bowl trembled again. This time she counted the clicks from the first one, not from the guard's movement. The seam held long enough for a cart to pass and then withdrew into the stone. The guard crossed. Mariya waited until Darran told her to follow.

On the other side, she looked back. The crack in the ninth step had caught a dark fleck that moved when the wall clicked, though the water did not otherwise flow. A person with a bowl could watch that fleck and predict the cycle's beginning. They might also confuse a delayed pulse for a safe one, as she had nearly done.

"Who taught the guards the count?" she asked.

"People who understand the structure."

"Your men?"

"Enough questions."

He led her to a storage niche where new fittings lay wrapped in cloth. She could tell they had not been made by any smith in Aras. The metal held a blue tint at its edge. An instruction sheet bore the same three-line mark she had seen on Panjios's case. Darran folded it before she could study the drawing.

Mariya checked the meal sacks, found another two portions undelivered, and made the guard carry them to the annex. She had earned entry by offering to reconcile food. She would not leave the people hungry merely because the wall had given her a more interesting problem.

Outside, she sat beneath the shade of the displaced statue until her pulse settled. She drew nine short lines on her board for the stairs, then tapped the ninth. She marked the bowl, the three clicks, the guard's wait, and the seam. The marks did not make her understand the device. They made her able to describe exactly where her understanding had failed.

That was a beginning.

* * *

At the coastal store, the carrier woman from the next inlet waited with a cart of barley wrapped beneath baskets of salt fish. The fig traders had carried it past the ridge in three small loads. None would appear impressive to Therren's men. Together they would let the lower quarter make bread for several more days.

"The toll is higher again," the woman said as Mariya checked the sacks. "If we keep coming openly, the captain will take the cart."

"There is a path from the north reed beds."

"Only in dry weather. After rain the wheels sink."

"Then we need a house on this side to receive it before the road. And another place for anyone hurt going through."

The carrier named an old fisherman whose nets were stored in a covered yard. He would shelter a load if it did not endanger his grandchildren. Mariya asked to speak to him herself. A shelter was only real if the person inside it knew what had been promised in his name.

They moved the grain in ordinary baskets. The work made Mariya's shoulders ache. It was good to be tired from something that had arrived, rather than from a plan she could not yet prove.

Pehl's daughter came down to the store that evening to collect her father's share. Mariya had put his bread aside as he asked. The girl took it but did not leave.

"He said he would be on the day shift," she said. "The guard says night."

"I saw him today."

"Then why can't he come home?"

Mariya looked at the wrapped loaf. The girl would carry it up to the site and might be turned away at the gate. Mariya had no answer that would make the arrangement just. She told her which guard had allowed food through, and what hour to try. The girl nodded with the seriousness of a person given a route instead of comfort.

Later, Lios carried a sealed bundle from the mill to the fisherman's yard. It was a short walk through familiar lanes; Mariya had asked his aunt first, and his aunt had walked the route with him once. The bundle held a ration tally, not a secret device or an order to approach the Receiver. When he returned, his repaired cup was tied at his waist.

"He had room for it," Lios said. "The fisherman. He says one stretcher can fit by the nets if we move the hooks."

"Did you move them?"

"No. His granddaughter did. She said I'd put them where people would step on them."

Mariya smiled. The network was growing through people who could correct one another.

At the granary, she prepared a second marked wrapper for Tobious. She scratched the leaf, then drew the ninth step and the three clicks in marks she knew he would recognize as a water pattern. She wrote the names she had confirmed at the hatch. She left a space for the person who would not speak under guard.

The porter checked its size and tucked it into his supply case. This time he asked no question about what could be said. Mariya watched him carry it toward Salt Gate.

She had passed through the wall and returned with more names than the tablet had held. Darran had seen her count them. Tomorrow he might close the worksite to her. The door would remain, and the people behind it would still need food. She began thinking of another way in before the porter was out of sight.

A Useful Victory

The trouble began at a cooling station that served a thousand homes.

Tobious knew the number because Ypin had made him look at the service map before they left Root Hall. It was easy to admire the pale water descending through clear conduits above the city. It was harder to imagine a thousand kitchens growing hot at once because one door inside the station refused to open.

At the site, steam had gathered beneath the ceiling. A maintenance team was trapped between two powered barriers. Their voices reached the operations desk through a narrow line; the images from that corridor broke into bands of light whenever the root load rose. An Iwang had flattened through a thinning seam beside the cooling return. It moved between the workers and the only manual exit.

Suss spread the station plan across the desk. He pointed out the route before assigning anyone to it. Jorra and Sennos would hold a shield line at the outer corridor. Ypin would identify the barrier seam from maintenance access. Tobious would make one guarded cut and then withdraw with the workers. Suss would cover the route behind them and isolate the return once the people were clear.

“One cut,” Suss said to Tobious. “If you see another opening, you report it. You do not follow it.”

Tobious nodded. The word *one* had been repeated enough that he could hear its purpose. No one was paying him to be brave twice.

They entered through a service walk that narrowed near the cooling pipes. Condensation slicked the floor. Below the grate, water ran at a force that would break a faller’s bones. Tobious set his feet with care. Jorra touched his shoulder once, a signal that she had room to extend cover past him when his shield dropped.

The trapped workers had gathered behind the inner barrier. One sat with her hands over her ears. Another held a short metal bar as though it could matter against the thing in the corridor. The third had a cut on his cheek and was talking steadily to the woman, telling

her what he could see beyond the door. None of them wore field protection.

“The Iwang is at the return bend,” Sennos said.

Tobious saw dust cross a seam in the wall. The clicking came a moment later. He remembered the open chest and the guard's spear beneath Aras. This creature's struts were paler, or the station light made them so. Its body narrowed as it pressed near the active boundary, then took shape again beside a live conduit. It was not looking for a duel. It was following a gradient toward the protected cluster of people.

“Seam?” Tobious asked.

Ypin crouched at a maintenance plate. “Third mark from the floor. The others belong to the cooling wall. Cut those and the water hits the corridor.”

Three marks looked almost alike. Tobious waited for Ypin to touch the right one with a short probe. He would have chosen the second.

The Iwang shifted. Sennos raised his field as it struck the bend. The impact drove him back a step. Tobious started forward, wanting to cut before the next blow. Jorra held him by the arm.

“On my line,” she said.

It was the same phrase she had used a dozen times on the practice floor. He felt embarrassed by the need to hear it. Then she moved, and his body followed the arrangement they had made.

He set Severance to the third mark. The channel darkened, then gathered its pale thread. One heartbeat. The Iwang's limbs scratched along Sennos's field. Two. Tobious wanted to rush the blade through. He kept contact instead, shifting one foot as Suss had taught him. Three. The barrier opened in a narrow band.

His own shield fell. Jorra's covered him from the bend. Ypin pulled the manual lever on the service plate; the divided panel swung away from the trapped team.

“Come through one at a time,” Tobious called.

The worker with the cut cheek helped the woman forward. She looked at the Iwang and froze. Tobious did not order her to be fearless. He reached through the opening with his left hand and

showed her the grip she could take. She held on. He drew her into Jorra's cover, then turned for the others.

The Iwang struck again. Sennos's shield gave a warning pulse. The man with the bar pushed the cut worker through. He then backed toward the gap, refusing to turn his back on the creature. Tobious saw that he was too far from the exit for one pull. He wanted to go after him.

"Let him take two steps," Ypin said. "The floor line is clear."

The man stepped. Suss shifted the outer field to meet the next strike, leaving the Iwang's collar exposed for an instant. Tobious saw the dark nexus; Severance had not yet settled for another cut. He could have tried the ordinary edge if he reached beyond cover. The man with the bar was close enough now. Tobious took his sleeve, drew him through, and heard the panel shut behind them.

"Exit," Jorra said.

They moved as a group. The woman who had been frozen now steadied the cut worker over the grate. The third worker kept his metal bar until the outer door closed, then set it down carefully, embarrassed by his own hand.

They had all come out.

Behind the sealed corridor the Iwang struck the return wall, then thinned as Suss dropped the local gradient. It retreated into the seam. Tobious watched until he was certain it could no longer reach them. Only then did he feel how wet his shirt had become under the shield band.

At the operations desk, Suss recorded the time and the one cut used. He did not call it a miracle. He asked Edda's team to examine the workers and ordered a repair crew to inspect the barrier before the cooling load returned. Two of the saved workers had families in the service ward; their names were entered as witnesses to the field fault.

The woman who had frozen at the opening asked whether her shift would be marked as abandoned. She had left her tools behind the barrier, and an abandoned shift would dock the pay that kept her mother's room heated. Suss told the registrar to mark it as a controlled evacuation. Tobious watched the woman check the entry herself before she let Edda's aide take her to the clinic. He had

brought her through the door; the day's harm could still follow her home in a line of text if someone counted badly.

The worker with the metal bar wanted to return for it. "It belongs to the station," he said, embarrassed that he had carried it like a weapon. Ypin promised to put it on the recovery list when the corridor was safe. Tobious had thought the man would want to forget the bar. He wanted to return a tool to a place where he still meant to work.

Jorra touched the edge of Tobious's wrist support. "You didn't follow it."

"You told me not to."

"Some people hear instructions as suggestions once they've succeeded at the first part."

Tobious looked back at the service door. The room still held a thousand homes on its other side. Had he chased the Iwang and left the barriers failing, those homes would have remained at risk. The thought did not make his part small. It made its boundary clear.

* * *

After the workers were safe, Suss asked the team to stay for a controlled test.

The test load sat in an isolated chamber, made to resemble a receiver branch without any living anchor or open path to a settlement. Ypin checked the isolation marks twice. Panjios checked them a third time. Suss wanted Tobious to see a faster operating setting; he told everyone exactly what he would do before his hand went to the control.

"A guarded cut waits for the core to settle," he said. "Thirty seconds is manageable here. If those three workers had been injured while the Iwang held the bend, thirty seconds might have cost one of them a leg."

Suss adjusted the gain control and asked Tobious to place Severance against the artificial seam. Tobious kept the edge steady. A high-gain pulse crossed the chamber and opened the seam more quickly than before. The indicator above Suss's hand climbed. The

reset lamp returned to green without counting a full thirty seconds. Heat rose through the floor.

"You can repeat it?" Tobious asked.

"In a mapped load. With a limit and a place for the strain to go."

Suss had not said there was no cost. Tobious could see the station's cooling draw rise. The second pulse would take more. He could also see the usefulness. A trapped worker might live because a commander refused to wait for a safe clock.

Panjios moved closer to the readout. "The receiver carried the excess."

"The artificial receiver," Suss said. "With a rated sink."

"There are live branches without rated sinks."

"Then we map them before use."

They held each other's gaze for a moment. Neither raised his voice. The disagreement belonged to the numbers on the screen, and to people Tobious could not see from this room.

"Would you have used it today?" Tobious asked.

"If the third worker had been caught behind the panel, yes," Suss said. "I would have accounted for the heat after I got him out."

Panjios turned to Tobious. "The word *after* needs somewhere real to put the cost. Ask for that place before you agree to a live cut."

Tobious wanted to answer that a dying person could not wait for a perfect map. He had watched three people come out alive because they had been given one. He kept the thought; he did not yet know which man it supported.

* * *

Ypin's room in the lower service ward was narrow enough that two chairs blocked the cupboard if their occupants leaned back. Plants grew on a warm pipe by the window. A small domestic water unit sat on the table in pieces, waiting for Ypin to remember how it had fitted together.

From the window Tobious could see tiers of gardens cut into the sides of other buildings. A tram passed high above them without a rail he could see. Below, neighbors crossed a suspended footway carrying food in covered bowls to a family whose cooking line was

out. The city could lift a road over the sea and still depend on someone deciding to take supper across a bridge. He had been too busy learning its dangers to notice how often its people made room for one another without a command.

“You repair pumps for a living,” Tobious said.

“This one is for tea. It has more rules.”

Ypin shoved the pieces into a bowl to make space for supper. He had made a dish of cultivated greens and fermented grain cakes, browned at the edges. Tobious took a bite. It was soft where he expected it to be crisp. The flavor pleased him less than Ypin's evident pride.

“Good?” Ypin asked.

“It wants salt.”

“It has salt.”

“Then it wants to be fried twice.”

Ypin made a wounded sound and pushed the pan toward him. Tobious used the little stove and turned the cakes until their surfaces caught. The smell changed. Ypin tried one and conceded that the extra heat had helped.

“At home,” Tobious said, “we would put onion between the layers. Mariya would tell me I had spent too much of it. Then she would take the crispest piece.”

“You say her name differently when you remember a meal.”

Tobious considered denying it. Instead he said, “I miss how she would ask whether I had thought about the next day's work. I hated the question when it came. Now I hear it while nobody is asking.”

Ypin had cleaned his plate. He set it by the broken water unit. “Sometimes I want a repair that is only a repair,” he said. “Fix a valve, go home, and let it stay fixed because I measured it correctly. No command route hidden behind a service panel. No category in a table whose contents nobody will let me check.”

Tobious looked at him. The last sentence was more specific than Ypin's ordinary complaints. Ypin shook his head before Tobious could ask.

“I haven't proved anything. I keep seeing categories I don't like.”

“Then let's see them together.”

“When I have the records.”

Ypin picked up the domestic unit, turned it twice, and set it back in the bowl. It was easier for him to make an uncertain machine the subject of his hands than an uncertain ledger the subject of his voice.

Tobious could have pressed. He wanted to celebrate the day while it was still intact: three people alive, a thousand homes cooling again, supper improved by a trick learned long before anyone had called him a reference. They ate the last cake between them.

On his way back through the service ward, Tobious passed a window where the city glowed beyond stacked roofs. He knew that if he sent Mariya a message, he would tell her they had brought people out. He would also tell her whose plan had worked and where he had needed another person's hand. She would ask what he had learned from it. He had an answer he could give without pretending to have learned everything.

What the Records Keep

Mariya's messages reached Tobious after he had stopped expecting them to arrive together.

The two wrappers lay in a tray at the dispatch desk, beneath routine parts from Salt Gate and a notice about delayed medicine. Inspection marks covered one corner of the first. The second had been opened and resealed with a strip that bore the Concord's three-line sign. Whoever had examined it had not bothered to hide the fact.

The dispatcher brought out the route slips when Tobious asked why they had come together. One wrapper had waited at Salt for an outgoing service load. The other had reached the station on time but been held while a clerk compared its marks with an authorized supply manifest. The delay was written in ordinary terms and signed by people Tobious did not know. He wanted a single man to blame for keeping Mariya's words away from him. Instead he found a chain of small permissions and queues, each one acceptable by itself, together long enough for her first warning to age.

"Can we give her a faster route?" he asked Ypin.

"A diagnostic relay, if the Storehouse branch can spare power. Until then a person still has to carry this across Salt."

Tobious folded the route slips with the wrappers. The future had not abolished distance. It had given distance clerks and reasons.

Tobious knew the scratch of a leaf at once. He had watched Mariya make it in the soft clay of his mother's jar when they were children and had no ink worth keeping. Below it stood seven strokes. On the reverse, four. He unfolded the linen carefully enough that Ypin, waiting beside him, lost patience and took the torn corner so it would not catch.

Mariya had written names in the marks she knew Tobious could recognize, with the porter translating a few into future script at the margin. She had traced the way the water trembled at the ninth step, the three clicks, the seam that opened when the guard crossed. A

later line named the red-marked passage Lios had used with the water crew. Near its end she had made a small drawing of his repaired cup. It told Tobious the boy was alive in a way no official seal could.

“She sends a lot for one strip,” Ypin said.

“She had to.”

He found the line about Pehl, the potter. Pehl had repaired the handle of Tobious's mother's jar two harvests earlier, arguing that it was too well made to discard for one cracked fitting. Another name, Annet, belonged to a woman who had helped watch an injured goat when his parents were ill. He had not known she was working below. A village could make a person familiar without making him attentive. Mariya's marks corrected his memory.

“I need to go back,” Tobious said.

“You need to see what the manifests say first.”

“She saw them with her own eyes.”

“Yes. I want a record that makes your commanders answer for the same people.”

Tobious began to argue, then noticed Ypin's hands. He had already sorted the wrappers by their dispatch marks. He believed Mariya's count enough to search. He was asking for proof that could travel farther than belief.

They went to the service records. Ypin's access opened the maintenance layer, not the command layer. Each ancient site had a page for power, material flow, and biological load. A separate public page showed protected residents. Tobious could read only the translated headings, so Ypin held the display still while the words settled behind his ear.

At the Storehouse branch, the first column read **UNREGISTERED BIOLOGICAL LOAD: 58.**

The next read **PROTECTED PERSONS: 0.**

Tobious pointed to the zero. “Mariya sent names.”

“The first column doesn't say they aren't people,” Ypin said. “The second says none of them qualify for protection under this register.”

He opened a subpage. The loads had shift times and food allocations. One entry aligned with the day Pehl had received bread

from Mariya. Its ordinary service label carried his physical identifier in a field hidden from the public tally.

“That's him,” Tobious said.

Ypin did not answer at once. He checked the identifier against another page and found the same shift. “It is consistent with him. I want an independent match.”

“How many matches until you call him a person?”

Ypin flinched. Tobious knew the question was unfair even while he spoke it. The technician had not made the column. He had helped maintain it without knowing who might be in it; that was the part both of them were afraid to name.

“One,” Ypin said. “For me. More for the board that will say I changed a number after I lost my head.”

They retrieved two more records. A ration dispatch to the annex showed fifty-eight portions. A repair request mentioned a living stabilizer shift beneath the painted seam. It did not use a human name. The records were precise where precision kept the system running and vague where it might invite a question.

Tobious asked for a copy. Ypin gave him an authenticated excerpt and kept the access trail. He could see that someone else had opened the same pages before them, but not who; the command layer held that detail behind another permission.

They brought the excerpt to Edda before meeting Panjios. She compared the fifty-eight biological loads with the ration record and said she could open a preliminary patient inquiry, but could not certify injuries without a way to examine the people or their direct accounts. Tobious put Mariya's names beside the column. Edda copied them carefully, leaving blank spaces where Mariya had not been able to confirm a person under guard. “Do not fill those with guesses to make the form look finished,” she said. “A blank here tells the next person where to ask.”

Ypin agreed to preserve the service trail while Tobious prepared to cross. It was the first piece of the investigation that could survive if the field visit failed. Tobious wished the protection of a copy felt more like protection for the people themselves. Edda did not pretend it did.

“Mariya is near fifty-eight people your count refuses to see,” Tobious said. “We need to know how many of them can leave.”

“I agree.”

“Then help me get there.”

“I will.” Ypin closed the display. “But don't mistake a number that proves they exist for a map of what happens if you move them.”

Tobious looked again at the zero beside *protected persons*. It was a kind of blindness chosen carefully enough to have columns.

* * *

Panjios met them in the calibration gallery. He had been reviewing the Storehouse anomaly from the day Tobious first touched the frame. Tobious had not told him every detail of what he had seen. He had feared that a man who understood the root might tell him his bleeding future was fixed beyond his choosing. The new records made withholding it feel like another way to stay ignorant.

“The person in the first image was me,” he said.

Panjios set down his stylus. “You recognized his voice?”

“And his face. He had a scar here.” Tobious touched below his left eye. “He was holding his right ribs. There was a road above him, and it was falling.”

Ypin turned the diagnostic record toward them. It showed a short flare at the moment of acquisition, forty-one seconds long. No street appeared in its saved data, only a disturbance in the return line and a trace that ended as abruptly as it began.

“That's all?” Tobious asked.

“The root recorded that a signal crossed its own history,” Panjios said. “It did not record what you saw.”

“Can we make it happen again?”

“No. It was the first reference contact. There is no second first contact to choose.”

Panjios showed them a model of the paired line, with one end at Tobious's acquisition and another near a terminal disturbance not yet dated in the current forecasts. The latter was only a range of possible load states. It was not a calendar he could use to avoid a fall.

“A damaged root can carry a sensory trace from its closing end to its beginning,” Panjios said. “One brief trace. Air and matter do not go with it.”

“He spoke to me.”

“Then he spoke in the event that produced the trace.”

“Could I tell him something now? Could he tell me how to stop it?”

“There is no open channel to him. The trace has happened. It was not a door you could enter when you touched it.”

Tobious remembered the rod striking the image of the street. He had learned that with his own painful hand. Yet he had kept a second hope hidden behind the first: that if the man was him, he might one day choose better words and send them back to save everyone.

“If he was me,” he said, “then the road will fall.”

“You saw a road falling,” Panjios said. “You did not see who lived beneath it, or what became of you after you spoke. A glimpse does not tell you which choice made the scene, only that it belongs to this history.”

Tobious looked at the trace. He had seen the man bleeding but still standing. He could not use those forty-one seconds as proof that Mariya would live through the next hour, much less the next weeks. The image was real. It was not permission to stop asking what his decisions would cost.

Panjios saw the wrappers in his hand. “You want a field visit.”

“I want to see whether those fifty-eight are the people she named.”

“We need to map the load before we remove anyone.”

“You already have the numbers.”

“We have a count. Not the distribution.”

Tobious heard the distinction. He hated it because it was exactly the kind of thing a man might say to keep a person waiting. It was also the reason he had stopped turning the powered valve when Ypin told him he would break it. He did not yet know which use Panjios was making of the truth.

* * *

Suss received them in the operations room on Day 40. The city behind the glass wall was bright with morning, though one service tier was shaded dark for repairs. He had read the excerpt and Mariya's names before they entered.

"An unregistered load can contain people," he said. "The category is not a declaration that they are stone."

"Then why does the protected column say zero?" Tobious asked.

"Because the compact defines who we can move under civil priority. The ancient territories were not registered with it."

"They live beside your receiver."

"Which is why I will send a team."

Suss placed a field map on the table. The Storehouse branch had been active more often than the public schedule showed. The main chamber was stable only during a short Day-42 window. A repair team could enter through Salt Gate, inspect the annex, and test the damaged component. Tobious would come as the living reference. Panjios would supervise field safety. Ypin would record the human tally. Suss would direct the operation from Veyr, with a route officer listening at Salt.

"An inspection," Tobious said.

"An inspection and a repair. If we know who is inside, we can plan movement without collapsing their support."

"Mariya has been counting them for weeks."

"She has counted people. I need to know what the receiver is doing to them."

Suss's answer sounded like the one Ypin had given him at the records desk. It could be care, or it could be a reason for leaving a dangerous arrangement intact. Tobious had seen Suss spend a shield to rescue workers whose names he had not known. That memory made it harder, not easier, to decide what the commander intended here.

"What if one of them is in danger while we inspect?" Tobious asked.

"You can stabilize the branch under Panjios's direction. You cannot cut a live load line until we map where its strain will go."

Suss looked directly at him. "Your first response is to pull someone out. Sometimes that is right. At the Storehouse, a wrong cut could put the cost on the people you do not see."

Tobious wanted to say that a system which hid them had made seeing difficult on purpose. He would say it when they had reached the annex. For now Suss was giving him a route home and a chance to measure what Mariya had found. He accepted the limits aloud.

After the meeting, Ypin walked with him to the service lift.

"You sounded as though you believed him," Ypin said.

"I believe the cut can hurt people I can't see."

"And the rest?"

Tobious looked at the map in his hand. The three ancient sites were marked there, Aras no larger than a fingernail. He knew Mariya had gone below with food and come back. The next time a guard threatened someone there, he did not know whether he could stand beside her and leave a person to the system's care.

"The rest," he said, "we find out when we get there."

He had agreed to an inspection. He intended to keep it an inspection until someone he could name was harmed in front of him. It was a private exception to a spoken promise. He did not tell Ypin or Panjios, because he knew what they would say. The silence was a choice before the cut ever happened.

The First Crossing Back

Mariya did not run when she saw Tobious at the end of the salt path.

She was waiting where the road rose through the olive trees, a bundle of work cloths under one arm. He had imagined the moment often enough to be embarrassed by what he had wanted from it: her hands around his neck, a day in which neither of them had to count anything. She walked toward him at her ordinary pace. Only when she was close did he see that her thumb had healed in a pale, uneven line and that the burned edge of her shawl had been mended with a piece of blue cloth.

"Your hair," she said.

"It got in the way."

"That answer applies to most of you."

He laughed, and she put down the bundle. Their embrace made his right wrist ache; he did not move away. She felt familiar beneath a change of cloth and weeks of work. She rested her cheek against his shoulder for a long moment, then stepped back to look at him.

"What do you know?"

He had missed the precision of her questions. He took out the copy of the manifest. "Fifty-eight unregistered biological loads. Zero protected people. Pehl is there. I think others on your list are too. Suss authorized us to inspect and map the branch."

"Can you get them out?"

"I don't know yet."

Her eyes moved across his face. She could tell when he was trying to make uncertainty sound temporary. He let it remain what it was.

"Good," she said. "That's an answer I can use."

She told him who had been reassigned since her last wrapper and how Darran had begun moving carts through the red-marked door after dusk. She named the households that had lost a worker, the ones that still received a ration, and the ones that had stopped asking because the guards punished questions with extra shifts.

Tobious wanted to ask about all of Aras at once. She made him listen to one route at a time.

Samon waited in his sister's yard. He could move from the door to a chair with a stick and someone close enough to catch him. The left leg was thinner beneath the brace. When Tobious thanked him for being alive, Samon waved the sentiment away and asked whether the new metal in Tobious's case could repair a water gate.

"It can cut a field," Tobious said. "It may not help with a gate."

"Then don't let anyone put it near my sluice."

Mariya had made an arrangement for the sluice with the mason's brother, who had since discovered that he preferred walls. Samon had been explaining the water to him from a chair. Aras had continued without Tobious. The fact hurt for an instant, then relieved him. He had wanted home to be safe because of him; he was glad it had found ways to remain itself in his absence.

Near the well, Lios showed Tobious his cup. Its bottom came from the jug broken on the day of the opening, and its new rim had been smoothed by his aunt's hand. The boy examined Severance's case but did not ask to touch it.

"They still take water below," he said. "I can carry it when there's no rope."

"You don't have to."

"I know."

Mariya caught Tobious's glance. "He carries from the well to the outer hatch. The guard who allowed it is on duty today. I'll be with him."

Tobious nearly told her to leave Lios away from the site. He had been gone six weeks. She had spent those weeks arranging safe paths and knowing which guard kept his word. He asked what the boy's aunt thought. Mariya said she had agreed to this one delivery because Lios's cup marked whose water reached the workers. The answer did not make the risk disappear. It made it an informed risk he did not own.

Panjios and Ypin joined them by the old storehouse. Jorra remained at the outer corridor to protect an exit; Sennos had the Salt relay and a route back to Veyr if the site failed. The team was

small enough that Darran could call it an inspection without looking foolish.

Ypin took a thin wafer from a padded pocket and showed it to Mariya before asking her to carry it. It was no larger than her palm, with a shallow edge she could find in the dark.

"Touch here to record," he said. "It will hold short messages until a diagnostic window sends them. You can see a mark when the packet leaves the wafer. That does not mean Tobious has read it."

"How long does it last?"

"Several days if you use it only for brief recordings. Less if you leave the display bright. It doesn't open anything."

"Can it tell you where I am?"

"Only when it reaches a fixed relay, and then it tells me which relay. It is an inspection recorder, not a guide to find you."

Mariya turned it in her hand. "Then I'll tell you where I am."

Ypin nodded. Tobious saw he had chosen to explain its limits first. A gift became more useful when its receiver knew what it could not do.

As the others prepared, Mariya pulled Tobious into the narrow shade behind the granary. The old steps were still there, smelling of flour and fig leaves. She kissed him. He had wondered whether six weeks and a thousand unshared moments would make the gesture uncertain. It did not. Her hand found the back of his neck; his left hand found the repaired blue edge of her shawl. When they parted, he could feel how much of the life he had imagined was still possible, if the world gave them time to choose it.

"Don't decide what I can bear because you have a blade now," she said.

"I won't."

He meant it when he said it. The promise would be tested before the day was over.

* * *

The Receiver no longer looked like a place people had uncovered by accident. Darran's crew had cleared the mud, shored the corridor, and fitted pale baffles along the walls. The black threshold under the

lower steps remained shut, but the annex beyond it pulsed with a light so slight Tobious first noticed it in the water, not in the stone.

Mariya entered ahead of the team with a cart of food. Lios came with water for the outer hatch. Darran allowed them because the workers had complained of short rations and because a child carrying a cup did not look like part of a Warden inspection. Tobious disliked the calculation. He did not stop them. Ypin had already explained that counting the people where they actually stood required someone who could name them.

At the ninth step, Mariya touched his elbow. The water in the cracked bowl began to tremble. One high click, two low. The seam ahead opened. She waited through the guard's practiced count before crossing.

"The first time I tried this, I nearly lost a foot," she said.

"You wrote that."

"I wanted to know if you'd listened."

The statement carried affection and anger together. Tobious had listened; he had not been here to pull her back. He followed her across.

In the annex, Darran's marked load area filled two connected chambers. A central support divided them: the near chamber led to the safe stair, the far one to a recessed work floor with no ordinary exit. Thin bands of light crossed between the support and the floor at ankle height. Tobious had seen fields in Veyr. He had never seen them laid through a room full of people as if people were part of the fastening.

Sixty were inside the marked area by Ypin's count. Mariya had come into the far chamber to hand out bread and compare faces to her board; Lios had set his water at the outer hatch and followed her when a guard said the far workers could not leave their posts to fetch it. The two new load marks had appeared when they crossed the boundary. Tobious saw them both beside Nerissa and Pehl. In the near chamber, twelve people stood behind a movable rail by the stair. The other forty-eight occupied the far floor and its surrounding work recesses.

"Sixty," Ypin said into the team channel. "Includes the two delivery carriers. Twelve near, forty-eight far."

"Are the carriers entered as load?" Suss's voice came back from Veyr, thin with static.

Ypin checked the local readout. "Since they crossed the boundary, yes."

Tobious watched Mariya hand bread to Annet. She took a piece for herself only after Nerissa pushed one into her hand. The men at the central support were adjusting a stone weight. The fields brightened when a worker leaned against a marked wall, then dimmed when she moved. He understood enough to be afraid of what Ypin would say next.

Ypin opened the branch map on his portable board. Two routes left the central support. One carried the near chamber's load to the safe stair. The other passed beneath the far floor and returned by an unseen line toward the black frame. If the near route closed suddenly, the root would seek an equalizing path. The map drew that path through the forty-eight people standing on the far side.

"We need the physical supports mapped before any release," Panjios said. "Darran, stop the weight adjustment."

Darran held up a hand to his men. One obeyed; another kept turning a bronze handle in the wall. The click pattern changed. A field line crawled across the floor near the workers' feet.

"That is part of the inspection," Darran said. "They cannot all stand idle."

"They can for a few breaths," Panjios answered.

Pehl stepped back from the line. A guard shoved him toward his station. When Pehl resisted, the guard raised the shaft of his spear. Annet moved between them. The spear point dropped toward her shoulder. At the same time, a pale strut pressed from the wall above the far chamber. Mineral clicking answered the altered baffle rhythm.

"There's an Iwang in the seam," Jorra warned from the outer passage.

Tobious reached the central support. The near route was close enough for Severance to couple. He could cut it and free the twelve by the stair. He saw the far branch on Ypin's board in the same glance. Forty-eight people would carry the redistributed load until the root settled. How long that would take, he did not know.

“Wait,” Panjios said. “We can hold the guard. We need the second support.”

The guard struck Annet with the shaft. She fell beside the brightening seam. An Iwang limb came through the wall above her, gathering weight as it reached the chamber air. The twelve near the stair pushed against their rail. One called for a child on the far side. Darran shouted for his men to drive the workers back to their marks.

Tobious heard all the instructions and knew none would be obeyed quickly enough to stop the next blow. He remembered the granary jar slipping from his hands while seven soldiers stood around him. He had a blade now. The near route was in reach.

“Tobious,” Ypin said, seeing where he had placed the edge. “The load goes far.”

“I see it.”

He cut.

Three heartbeats. Jorra's shield rose between him and the guard. Severance passed through the marked line. The near chamber's fields collapsed, and the twelve by the stair stumbled free. Tobious shouted for them to move. Sennos at Salt relayed the opening; village helpers waiting above took the first two from the stair. The local guard's spear struck Jorra's field and skidded aside.

For an instant Tobious believed he could do it again.

Then the far chamber moved.

Light ran beneath its floor like water reaching a lower field. The central support contracted. Bands rose around the forty-eight, not ropes, but a pressure that made every attempt to step away pull at someone else. Pehl cried out as his ankles were drawn back to a painted mark. Mariya caught Annet and kept her from falling into the seam. Lios stood with his small cup in both hands, too frightened to put it down.

The Iwang pressed against the newly fed boundary. Its open torso filled with the light beyond it. Another answered from the recess. The twelve on the safe stair were out of its reach; the people Tobious had left on the far floor were not.

“Second cut,” Tobious said. “I can take the far line.”

Panjios seized his forearm before Severance reached it. "The far floor is carrying the frame. Cut that now and it falls on them."

"Then hold the frame."

"With what? We haven't mapped the supports."

Ypin's board showed a load rising through the forty-eight bodies. Tobious could understand the warning now because he had made it true. Suss came over the channel, his voice hard and distinct despite the static.

"Withdraw the reference. Seal the near stair. The freed group goes to local care."

"Mariya is in there," Tobious said.

"I know she is there. A second blind cut kills the group."

Tobious looked across the floor. Mariya was looking at him. Her face held fear; it also held the furious concentration with which she assigned people to work when a roof leaked or a child was hurt. She pointed at the near stair. The twelve had to get through before the Iwang reached their opening.

"Go," she called. "Get them out."

He wanted her to ask him to stay. He wanted her to let him save her first, because then he would not have to decide whether saving the twelve mattered. She gave him a task instead.

* * *

They brought the twelve into the yard in groups of three. Villagers took them down the lane to rooms already prepared by Mariya's coastal network. Jorra held the passage until the last person cleared it. Panjios closed the near stair field; it kept the Iwang from following but left the far chamber connected to the root. The black threshold beneath the old steps pulsed once, then settled into a dangerous stillness.

Tobious could see Mariya through a narrow inspection pane. She had gathered the people nearest her around the dry recess. Nerissa was checking Annet's shoulder. Lios sat with his back to the wall, cup between his knees. He raised it when Tobious looked in, a tiny sign that he was still himself. Mariya touched the wafer Ypin had given her. A brief mark appeared on its edge.

“It has a relay window,” Ypin said. “If she records something, we can get it.”

“How soon?”

“When the diagnostic line opens. I can't make it open while this branch is carrying them.”

Panjios ordered the external chamber locked against unauthorized labor. Darran argued that his workers needed to continue the survey. Panjios showed Therren the load map and the rising strain. The captain had lost one guard in the first opening; he was not eager to lose more. He permitted the site to be held until specialist instructions came, though his men remained at the outer door.

Suss repeated the withdrawal order. Tobious knew enough now to see why Panjios obeyed it. Staying with Severance in front of an unmapped field would give him another chance to make a cut that harmed people he could not see. He also knew that obedience did not erase the choice he had already made.

At Salt Gate, the freed twelve were counted into Mariya's local shelter register, not transported to Veyr. The team crossed without them. When the physical gate closed behind Tobious, he held the sword by its worn grip and remembered his own words to Mariya in the fig shade: *I won't decide what you can bear because I have a blade now.*

He had decided for forty-eight people. Twelve others were breathing free air because of it. Both facts belonged to him, and neither answered the other.

Inside the Hollow

Mariya counted forty-eight people before she counted the ways out.

The number took her three attempts. People moved when she approached, some because they feared another field would rise beneath their feet, some because the guard at the ration hatch ordered them back to the painted marks. Twice she counted the same man. Once she nearly missed Lios, who had tucked himself into the recess beneath a collapsed shelf, his cup between his knees.

“Say your name when I reach you,” she told them. “If you can’t, someone who knows it can.”

Nerissa stood by a dry patch of floor and repeated each name onto the back of a broken clay tile. Mariya kept the order on her board. Annet’s shoulder was swollen from the guard’s blow. Hessah had a cut across her palm from catching a slipping water skin. Pehl could walk but trembled whenever the wall clicked. There were bruises and burns that had no obvious cause, where the field had tightened around people who tried to move away.

They were still on the ancient side of the Receiver. Mariya could see the stair they had entered by through a line of pale pressure. Beyond it lay Aras, close enough that a person could hear a cart in the lane above. Between her and the stair, the floor held them as surely as a locked door. When Pehl stepped across one painted mark, light rose around Annet’s ankle. He stepped back, and it faded. The system treated their bodies as weights on a scale. It had no mark for the choice that made a person move.

Orran, a stoneworker with dust ground into the cracks of his hands, said they should send the strongest six through the service recess while the line was dim. “If some of us get out, we can bring help.”

“Some of us?” Annet asked. “Which six?”

“The ones who can pull a gate.”

Pehl looked toward the ration hatch. “My daughter is outside. I’m going if there is a path.”

“And my mother is outside,” Annet said. “That doesn't make your legs worth more than mine.”

Mariya had no answer that would satisfy them all. She had promised Tobious she would not let a blade decide what she could bear. She was now in a room where every decision seemed to press on someone else's ankles.

“We test the recess with a rope first,” she said. “No one crosses until we know what the baffle does.”

Orran frowned. “While we wait, those things gather.”

A pale strut touched the far wall, then withdrew when the field in its seam dimmed. Mariya could hear the mineral clicks from inside the stone. He was right that waiting had a cost. He was wrong that moving without a test made the cost smaller.

Aboveground people had begun calling the Iwang the Hollow Ones. The name made sense when one crossed a live seam: its open body showed the stone behind it, as though the wall had learned to walk. It did not tell Mariya how to move forty-eight people past it. She watched the seam dim and set the rope test for the next quiet interval.

Nerissa caught Mariya by the sleeve. “Assign the water. I can take the injured.”

“I know who needs it.”

“Then tell me. Don't make knowing into a reason to do it all.”

Mariya gave her the list of injuries. Pehl took the first water jars from the ration hatch. Thesia, whose feet were blistered from a torn sandal, offered to mark the sleeping places. Lios had seen the old red-marked service door; he described it but was not asked to enter it again. Orran and two others cleared a sanitation corner behind a low wall. It smelled bad almost at once. No one had planned the annex as a home for forty-eight bodies. Keeping it live for the root did not make it fit for human living.

Thesia marked sleeping places by household, then erased half the marks when Nerissa pointed out that the people nearest the active wall would need a clear route to the water. She did not defend the first arrangement. She moved the injured inward and asked two workers to sleep near the hatch because they could bear the guard's light. When Lios chose a place behind the shelf, she gave him a piece

of cloth to hang over the sharp edge without asking him to leave the only corner that felt protected. He showed her the repaired cup he kept there. She said the repair was ugly and useful, which was how her sister described every household tool.

At the sanitation wall Orran found an old drain too narrow to carry waste by itself. He asked Pehl to bring loose tiles, and the two men made a shallow runnel from broken pieces. They disagreed about its slope until water proved Pehl right. Orran took the correction with a grunt. Later he returned with a second tile to keep the runnel from crossing a sleeping place. Mariya noticed how quickly forty-eight people became a set of local problems whose solutions required people to know one another. The root's count had no room for those skills.

Darran's guards brought grain and a thin broth that evening. One guard counted portions by marks on a tablet. Mariya placed herself at the hatch with her own board. Forty-eight went in; forty-eight portions had to come through. The guard grew impatient, but Darran told him to finish. They needed the people alive. Mariya did not yet know why. She meant to make that need serve the people for as long as she could.

The portions arrived in bowls whose rims had been chipped by repeated washing. Pehl showed Lios how to hold one without putting a thumb in the hot broth. Annet traded a piece of her bread for Hessah's place near the wall, where a draft helped her swollen shoulder. Thesia brought Mariya a bowl after the count. "Eat before the guard decides we have too many," she said.

"I have already counted."

"That has never stopped a man with a tablet."

They ate sitting on the dry floor. Thesia described how her sister's younger child always stole the browned crust from the bottom of the cooking pot, then blamed a cat the family did not own. For a little while Lios tried to think of a name for the imaginary cat. When the wall clicked, conversation stopped, then resumed with a different rhythm. Thesia had given them something to speak about that the machine could not measure.

* * *

The ninth stair clicked through the night. Mariya could not see it from the sleeping recess, but the sound traveled along the old stone: one high note, two low. Every cycle made the water in their basin tremble. The pattern did not stop for people trying to sleep.

At first light, Thesia joined Mariya beside the service recess. The torn sandal had been tied with linen from Mariya's bundle. Thesia carried the clay tile on which Nerissa had written the names.

"My sister will come to the outer hatch," she said. "She won't know I'm still here until someone tells her."

"The twelve who escaped will tell the village."

"Tell her yourself when the wafer opens."

Mariya turned the wafer over. It held one brief recording from the night: forty-eight alive, ration status, no safe exit yet. The diagnostic window had not opened. She had not told anyone outside even that much.

"I will," she said.

Thesia gave her the tile. "Make her hear the two children are eating. She'll think I took their share with me."

Mariya began to answer, but Orran called from the recess. He had found a stone lip that might hold a rope. The group moved to watch. Mariya kept Thesia's request in mind as she checked the knot.

The test was simple enough to describe. They would send a weighted length of rope into the recess during the quiet interval. If it came back dry and unburned, one adult could examine the landing without crossing the tether line. Nobody would try to escape yet. Nerissa repeated the limit to the people gathering behind them. Orran repeated it too, reluctantly.

Thesia asked whether the rope could be fastened around a pillar before they sent it across. Orran said the pillar was cracked and might not hold if someone pulled hard. She suggested tying it around two stones instead. The test still would not carry a person; the knot would only keep the coil from whipping back across the floor. They did it her way.

Mariya tied the rope to a fragment of old masonry and pushed it across. The first baffle clicked. The stone slid onto the ledge and held. At the third click, the pale seam changed direction. The rope

quivered but did not burn. Orran pulled it back. The weight returned with dust on one face and a faint blue mark on the other.

"There's a landing," he said.

"And a field below it," Mariya answered. "We don't know when it takes weight."

They tried again, this time with less rope so the stone would strike the inner edge. Thesia held the spare coil behind Mariya. A guard at the ration hatch shouted for the workers to return to their marks. His voice made two people turn. The coil shifted. Mariya caught the rope, but the weighted stone had already begun to swing beyond the lip.

Thesia stepped toward her to steady the line. The ledge beneath Thesia's sandal gave way.

It was ordinary stone, fractured by years of damp and new field pressure. It broke before the next baffle interval. Thesia fell to her knees against the active boundary. Mariya seized her arm. Orran caught Mariya's belt. For one moment they held the living weight between them. Then the field tightened across the recess. Thesia cried out; her grip lost strength. Mariya tried to pull again and felt the tether around Orran's feet rise in answer.

"Let go," Thesia said.

Mariya did not. Nerissa reached them and put both hands on Mariya's wrist, not to force her away but to keep her from following. Thesia's head struck the lower stone. Her body lay still beyond the bright seam, visible for one terrible breath before the field closed across it. There was no way to draw her back onto the ledge, only the broken stone and the rope trailing into the dark.

Orran remained holding Mariya's belt after the danger passed. His hands were shaking. He had argued that the strong should try first; he had seen strength fail against a floor that would not bear it.

Pehl tried the rope once more without stepping over the line, hoping its weight might reach Thesia. The tether rose around Annet's ankle when he pulled. He stopped before someone else fell. Nerissa tested the edge with a pole and found no purchase beneath the broken lip. They did not leave Thesia because nobody thought to try. They left her because every attempt reached the living floor through another person's body.

The guard stopped shouting. Darran arrived at the hatch and ordered the baffle cycle stabilized. He asked how many had been lost before he asked for a name.

"Thesia," Mariya said. "One person. Write her name."

He looked at the severed rope. "The ledge was not an exit."

"We know that now."

He closed the hatch. Mariya thought he would reduce the ration count by one before dusk. She would make him say the name again if he did.

* * *

By evening, forty-seven people remained. Mariya made herself count them, then read Thesia's name from the tile even though everyone had heard her say it. Pehl asked whether they would try the recess again. Annet said no before Mariya could answer. Orran said they should wait until the fields were mapped. None of them used the phrase *strongest first*.

Lios kept Thesia's strip of cloth at the sharp edge of the shelf. He asked whether her sister would want it. Mariya said she did not know. He folded it and placed it beside the cup until the message could go. Thesia had marked sleeping places in a room designed to make people stay put. The marks were still there, and several people followed them that night because they had learned where the water could be reached without crossing a bright line.

"The test found a landing," Mariya said. "It also found a ledge that fails and a line that pulls at the rest of us. We won't send anyone across it as we are."

She could see disappointment gather. A failed route had been a hope for a day; taking it away meant asking forty-seven people to sleep inside a system that called them necessary weight. She would rather disappoint them with a reason than promise a path she could not keep.

Nerissa touched her shoulder. "Let Orran do the night count. I can watch Annet's arm. Eat."

Mariya meant to refuse. Then she heard Lios ask Pehl whether Thesia's sister would know. She sat down to eat because the group

needed someone capable of speaking when the relay opened, and exhaustion would not make her truer.

The wafer lit shortly after dark. Mariya recorded the count and the tested limits: forty-seven alive, one dead; drinking water low; rations delivered but poor; service recess usable as a landing, impassable under the current tether; ninth-step click pattern unchanged. She named Thesia and asked that her sister be told the children had been fed. She did not send Tobious a command to save her. He would already be trying.

A small mark crossed the wafer when the packet left. Ypin had warned her what it meant: the relay had accepted it. It was not proof that anyone had heard her voice.

She told the captives exactly that. Then, seeing their faces, she added, "We should hear something by the next interval."

Nerissa waited until the others had settled. "Should we?"

Mariya looked at the small mark, already fading. "I don't know."

"Then why did you tell them?"

"Because they needed a time they could endure to."

"And when it passes?"

Mariya had no answer. The wall clicked again, one high note and two low, counting a cycle that would continue whether she had promised anything or not.

The Price of Opening

Suss placed two figures beside one another on the debrief wall: twelve and forty-eight.

The first belonged to people who had walked out through the safe stair. The second belonged to people still breathing inside the annex, now held by the load Tobious had moved. Tobious could see the route he had cut, its bright line ending at Severance's recorded contact. He wanted to say the guard had struck Annet. He wanted to say the Iwang had come through the wall. Both things were true. Neither changed where the light had gone when he used the blade.

The twelve appeared as pale marks climbing the near stair. A delay in the record made them move again and again, always reaching the same point of safety. The far-floor marks did not move at all after the branch collapsed. Tobious asked Ypin to stop the replay. Suss let it run to the end first. He wanted the pattern visible; Tobious wanted to look away from it. Neither reason changed the tracing.

"Put the warning back," Tobious said when the display cleared.

Ypin did. The far-floor path had been marked before the cut, faint but legible. The symbol for unmeasured living load lay beside it. Tobious remembered seeing the mark and telling himself he would have time to fix whatever it meant after he freed the people nearest him. He had not forgotten a warning in the heat of battle. He had ranked it below his own chosen action because the people it described stood farther away.

"You ordered us to leave them there," he said.

"After the cut," Suss answered. "I ordered you not to make it."

Panjios stood at the far side of the room. He looked as tired as Tobious felt. "I asked for the support map. We did not have it."

Jorra was beside him, her shield arm in a sling for the morning. "I covered the cut," she said. "I saw the warning too late to pull him clear without leaving the twelve at the stair. I need that in the record."

Suss entered her statement. Tobious wanted to tell her she had not made the decision. She knew that; she had named what she could and could not see. He understood that her account would keep him from using the team's presence as a blur in which his choice vanished.

"Annet was down," Tobious said. "The guard had a spear."

"I saw her," Panjios said. "I did not say you imagined the danger."

Suss expanded the recording. A thin warning had flashed on Ypin's board before Tobious made the cut. It had marked the transfer to the far floor. Tobious remembered seeing it. At the time it had been a prediction beside an immediate blow. Now the far floor held forty-eight names.

"I thought the second line would take a few breaths," he said.

"You did not know," Suss replied. "That is why we map."

"The system shouldn't have put people there."

"Agreed," Panjios said. "You still cut while they were there."

Tobious looked at him. Panjios had spent weeks teaching him when to withdraw. His voice now held neither anger nor the comfort of absolution. Tobious could hate being measured by that standard; he could not claim it had been hidden from him.

Ypin arrived with a packet from the ancient diagnostic relay. He played Mariya's voice for them. The room went quiet at the first count: forty-seven alive, one dead. Mariya named Thesia. Tobious had seen her at the granary once holding bread for her sister's children; he had not known her well. He heard in Mariya's voice exactly how well she had.

The recording continued with water, rations, a broken ledge, and a landing that could not yet free anyone. It ended with the request to tell Thesia's sister that the children had eaten. Tobious listened a second time because the first had left him holding only the number. The second gave him the sentence Mariya had chosen to send across centuries.

The Salt porter would not reach Thesia's sister before evening. Tobious asked whether they could send her voice immediately through the relay. Ypin showed him the dead interval. The diagnostic pulse had already closed; the ancient side would not hear him until the next scheduled opening, and the sister lived above the

field in any case. The quickest truthful route was a person carrying the message along a road. Tobious had crossed twenty-six centuries in an hour, yet he could not make a grieving household hear one sentence before a porter walked there.

“We tell her sister through the village network,” he said.

“Yes,” Ypin answered. “The Salt porter can take a notice.”

“And we get the other forty-seven.”

“With a plan,” Panjios said.

Tobious turned away from the wall. Twelve people were safe because he had acted. He would not pretend they should have remained in danger to make his account cleaner. Forty-eight had been stranded because he had acted without knowing enough. He would not use the twelve to erase them.

* * *

Edda examined the wrist he had used to steady Severance. The swelling had returned under the support. She cleaned a field burn at his shoulder and asked exactly when it had begun hurting. He told her about the cut. He did not ask for a treatment that would make it possible to repeat one immediately.

She gave him a cup of water and made him drink before describing the burn. When he failed to hold the cup steadily, she set it on the table rather than holding it to his mouth. The courtesy hurt. He was accustomed to having hands that could move a beam or lift a sack. He had built a new kind of usefulness around Severance and now wanted to prove it had not ended with one terrible decision. Edda's examination left no room for proof. His skin was damaged; his wrist needed rest; the people under Aras needed a plan that would not depend on him ignoring either fact.

Two of the cooling-station workers he had helped on Day 28 waited outside her room for routine follow-up. One recognized him and thanked him again. Tobious had expected the gratitude to feel good. Today it made him want to leave before she finished speaking. Edda noticed and asked them for their account of the phase pressure, not for an account of his heroism. They described the

wall's narrowing and the heat after Suss dropped the gradient. Their observations were useful. Their survival was also true.

One worker had returned to a shift that required fine adjustments. She said she still sometimes felt the wall heat in a room whose power was off. Edda asked whether it happened at work, at home, or when she heard a service alarm. The worker said she did not know yet. Tobious waited for Edda to connect the account to the ancient floor. Edda recorded it as the woman's injury, not as an instrument for his argument. After the worker left, she showed Tobious the aggregate field temperature at the cooling station and the mark from his own shoulder. Those observations could be compared with Mariya's account without requiring the worker's fear to be treated as proof of something she had not witnessed.

Edda opened the current Storehouse report. "The public casualty notice names no ancient patients. That conflicts with what you saw and with the injuries your recorder measured."

"Can you order them released?" Tobious asked.

"I can certify harm, ask for an emergency review, and protect my patients' records. I cannot command the root by signing a page. I need a safe extraction plan, a place for the people to go, and enough evidence that a civil order can reach the staff who will carry it out."

"You have Mariya's voice."

"I have a voice and your field injuries. I want the names of the twelve who came out. They are on the ancient side, so someone has to bring their statements through a service route. I won't pretend they're in my waiting room."

Tobious was grateful for the correction. He had been ready to imagine an inquiry that would solve the problem by existing. Edda's work began with beds, water, authority, and people able to stand between an order and a commander who disliked it.

"If I brought you the plan," he asked, "would you act?"

"I would examine it, tell you where it fails, and act on what survives."

It was the answer of someone who meant to help more than to be thanked.

He left the clinic with a clean dressing and no permission to wield the sword that day. Across the hall a service crew was replacing a

failed water regulator. The old one had been set on a tray, split at a seam so small he would have missed it before he met Ypin. He watched the workers test the replacement twice before opening the line. The ward lost water for a little longer because they waited. Nobody thanked them for taking that time. The taps ran when they finished.

* * *

Suss asked Tobious to meet him without the larger team. Ypin came as the technician who could explain the field routing; Panjios was not invited. Tobious considered refusing. Mariya's packet had made refusal feel like something that would cost days he could not count for her.

On the table Suss placed a smaller plan than the one used for inspection. It isolated one person from the far floor, drew strain through a temporary sink, and returned that person by a watched Salt opening. The mechanism existed. The sink's capacity was limited; Suss showed the limit. He did not call it a general rescue.

Suss had also brought the roster of workers saved from the high platform when Tobious first came to Veyr. He laid it beside the ancient count. "I held that lift for one crew," he said. "The rest of the platform had to stay closed while we did. If I had tried to bring everyone through the same opening at once, the lift would have fallen. You saw me choose."

Tobious had seen it. He remembered Suss carrying an injured mechanic out while another team waited under cover. The comparison tempted him because it used a true rescue. It failed where the ledger changed people into an unnamed remainder with no visible turn to follow. He did not yet have a route for the forty-seven. Suss had a route for one.

"Mariya could come first," he said. "You could speak with her before the next cycle."

Tobious saw her on the wall of names, one among forty-seven. The thought of her walking out alive struck him with such force that he had to steady his hand on the table.

"Who takes her place?"

“The load spreads among the others. Each carries a measurable additional strain. We can keep it below the harm threshold for a single extraction.”

Suss slid the projection toward him. The line for Mariya went dark on the ancient side and brightened at Salt. It showed a person arriving, not merely a number removed. Tobious could almost feel her hand in his. The other lines stayed pale. He knew enough now to ask why none of them had names, and wanted badly to postpone the question until after she was safe.

Ypin moved toward the display. “Below which threshold?”

“The monitored one.”

“Those monitors call them unregistered biological load. They did not record Thesia's death as a protected casualty.”

Suss faced him. “I am showing you a real route. If you have a safer one with capacity today, put it on the table.”

Ypin did not. Tobious could hear the unfairness and the truth in Suss's challenge at once. The plan could save Mariya. It would ask the others to bear some cost they had not been asked about, measured by a system that had refused their names.

“She won't leave them,” Tobious said.

“Has she told you that since captivity?”

“I know her.”

“Then give her the choice. I can arrange the exception if you support continued anchor stabilization while we plan the rest.”

“For how long?” Tobious asked.

“Until we have a release sequence that holds.”

“Who decides it holds?”

Suss did not pretend the answer was a village council. “My operators, with the load data we can verify. You can remain in the room.”

“The people carrying the strain cannot.”

“They are in the room that matters to the machine. If you want them out, help me keep that machine intact.”

Tobious thought of the moment at the granary when Therren had counted seed while Mariya counted households. It was possible to care about survival and still choose a measure that made some lives disappear. Suss was offering him a way to bring Mariya to safety. He

was also asking him to help preserve the very arrangement that kept the others below.

Tobious had once promised Mariya he would tell her what a crossing cost before deciding for her. Suss's offer gave him the possibility of honoring the first half while making the second half almost impossible: to see a door open for her and accept a refusal if she made it.

He did not agree. He asked Suss to show how the high-gain setting would hold the sink during release, how its heat would be measured, and who would sign the load distributed among the forty-six left behind. Suss answered the first two with diagrams. The third he said would be included in the operation order.

When they left, Ypin followed Tobious into the corridor.

"He named one person he can save," Ypin said. "He made the others an amount of heat."

"I heard him."

"Did you?"

Tobious stopped. He wanted to tell Ypin that a man whose closest person was trapped had no need to be lectured about names. He wanted to tell him that if Mariya died while they sought a perfect list, the list would not hold her. Neither answer made Suss's count complete.

Ypin looked back toward the closed room. "Whose names are absent from his cost column?"

Tobious could not answer. That was why the question stayed with him.

The Line Beneath the Seal

Ypin could open the maintenance archive because the Storehouse fault still shared an index with older route failures. He could not open the command chamber beyond it. The distinction was written beside the door in letters Tobious could now recognize as a warning but still could not read fast enough to obey without help.

"If this page asks for a supervisor, I stop," Ypin said. "I will not make the record less useful by breaking into something I cannot explain later."

"You said you wanted enough proof for Edda."

"Enough. Not a story I make whole by guessing at locked parts."

The archive was cool, crowded with narrow racks of memory wafers. Maintenance logs opened on a table when Ypin set an access tag against its edge. Each route had a date, a service request, and a disposal code. Most were dull: worn seals, cooling faults, workers who left a job half-finished for the next shift. Tobious had spent enough days beside Ypin to know that dull records were what kept the city from falling. A strange code hidden among them was more frightening than an obvious warning.

Ypin made him take a second chair and read the public digest while Ypin checked the maintenance index. The digest showed bridges kept open, crews counted, strain reduced to a tolerable level. Tobious could now pick out some words before the translator caught up: *safe, completed, no protected loss*. He had used those words himself after the twelve came out. He had meant them to describe what happened. They described only the part of it he could bear to present.

At the next rack, a woman from the archive staff was repairing a bent reader pin. She asked whether they wanted the bridge display with the original sound. Ypin said they needed the service index instead. She directed them to a lower shelf where older formats were still kept because converting them would erase calibration marks. She had no reason to think the request unusual. Tobious watched

her return to the pin. A room could hold a hidden catastrophe and ordinary work at the same time.

They searched the date of the evacuation shown in the memorial gallery. Tobious remembered the bridge bearer's repeated turn of the head. Panjios had said the old inscription left out the maintenance crews. Ypin found their report, then followed a reference to an earlier closure in the same route family, twelve paired years before the current crisis.

The old route had been repaired twice after its closure. The first entry listed a cracked seal. The second listed a need to keep the ancient branch cold while the future service line remained useful. Neither repair reopened the isolated side. Ypin traced the work orders with his finger. A closure he had imagined as one terrible day had demanded workers, parts, and power long afterward. Someone had kept it stable because it still served the city.

"This isn't the bridge," Tobious said.

"No. Same service index. Look at the load line."

The screen showed ninety-seven unregistered biological loads on the ancient side. The official rescue report beneath it showed zero protected persons abandoned. The second number had been printed in the public memorial digest. It did not lie about the category. It erased what the category allowed the public to believe.

Tobious asked Ypin to show the life readings before the seal. They rose and fell in separate rhythms. A person shifting position sent a small wave across one line; another settled when the cooling flow changed. Ninety-seven was a count, not ninety-seven names, yet the lines resisted being made into one gray band. Tobious did not know who any of them had been. He knew that the report's zero was not a report of an empty room.

Ypin opened the isolation order. A seal had cut the route while the ninety-seven were still registered as active loads. The record did not show their names. It did show pressure afterward and the absence of further life readings on that branch.

"Were they people?" Tobious asked.

"The service flags describe respiration and neural response. So yes."

"Then the report says no one was left."

“It says no protected person was left. I don't want to make that distinction for them. I want to show where they made it.”

Ypin saved the maintenance entry under its original authentication. He could not alter its author without leaving a trace. He could carry an excerpt to Edda; the full command context remained behind another door. When Tobious asked whether they could publish it now, Ypin held up the copy.

The archive worker returned with a packet of fresh reader sleeves. She saw the figures on their table and asked whether they had found a calibration fault. Ypin covered the current manifest with his hand, then removed it. “We found a count filed under the wrong public category,” he said. “I need to preserve the access record.”

She showed him how to mark the timestamp and sign as custodian of the copy. She did not ask whom the old count belonged to. Her job gave them a reliable trail, and Tobious noticed how much the truth would depend on a worker who had not entered this room to take anyone's side.

“We can prove a route was closed on live loads and that the public count omitted them. We cannot yet prove who knew an alternative existed. If we claim more than this record shows, they will spend the inquiry tearing that claim apart.”

Tobious thought of the forty-seven current captives. They did not have years for an inquiry. Yet a rushed accusation might let a practiced commander call the whole case reckless, including the parts that were true. He wanted the evidence to strike like Severance. It was going to require more hands.

* * *

The name they were looking for was in the authorization block.

Tobious recognized its shape before the translator spoke: Panjios. The old signature had been pressed beneath a directive to isolate the route. Suss's field command counter-sign followed on the implementation page. Tobious read the two lines three times, waiting for a word that would make them mean something else.

“Panjios told us a bearer kept the bridge open,” he said.

“Different incident,” Ypin replied. “He has told us very little about this one.”

There was a note after the isolation order: review deferred under continuing emergency authority. It had been renewed, then filed closed. Tobious saw how a decision made in a crisis could become a category, and a category a habit. The old ninety-seven were not in the room with Mariya. They did not change the current forty-seven-person count. They had been removed from a count in a way that made removing the next people easier.

Ypin sat very still. He had opened a newer form attached to the same classification code. Its lower field bore his own signature.

He turned the form so Tobious could read the field he had signed. The route number was small. The supply quantities were large. A normal replacement order for a regulator that might have kept the tether stable, carried inside the same category that had hidden the older loss.

“When?” Tobious asked.

“Eighteen months ago. It was a routine manifest. I checked the weight and the cooling draw. I signed because the values matched.”

“Did you know?”

“I knew the name of the category. I thought it meant biological samples, waste cultures, whatever a station held that needed a stable environment.” He rubbed a hand across his face. “I didn’t ask what the people were moving.”

“You asked me for every reading before I made a cut,” Tobious said.

“Yes.”

“You knew to ask.”

Ypin looked at the old date, then at his own. “I learned to ask when a sword was in the room. I should have learned to ask when I signed for the power that let someone else use one.”

Tobious thought of Ypin teaching him to eat the soft grain cakes with a sharp relish, of the night they had repaired a small pump until the water ran clear. Those evenings had been real. So was this form. Friendship did not turn the signature into a harmless mistake; it made the work of looking at it together harder.

Tobious had wanted a guilty man to point at. Ypin had given him one, smaller than Suss, more reachable, and standing beside him now. He remembered his own hand on Severance at the Storehouse. Knowing the count had not kept him from moving a cost onto other people.

"We need your signature in the copy," Tobious said.

"I know."

Ypin attached the newer form. His name would travel with it to Edda. He did not ask Tobious to understand him first.

He put the copy in a sleeve that could be opened only by breaking the seal. Then he made a second copy for the review office and logged where both would go. Tobious helped him carry the packets. It was a smaller burden than the one under Aras, but he could feel the wish to leave Ypin alone with it. He kept walking beside him.

* * *

They crossed the memorial passage on the way to Panjios's workroom. The bridge bearer still turned her head toward whatever lay outside the image. Tobious stopped beneath the wall. Ypin's request to add the omitted maintenance crews had acquired a reply: denied until the committee could verify a complete roster. A precise reason. An indefinite wait.

Tobious watched the loop again. A child at the next display asked why the bearer kept looking away from the bridge. Her father said she was checking whether everyone had crossed. The answer was plausible; the public caption said as much. Tobious had no proof what she had actually seen outside the frame. He wondered how many visitors had left this hall carrying the same comforting account. He did not correct the father with a different guess. The missing crews could be named when Ypin found their roster. The ninety-seven needed an account from the man who had signed.

"She deserves to be remembered," Tobious said.

"So do they," Ypin answered.

Tobious carried the authenticated excerpts under his coat. He did not bring Severance. It remained in its controlled case after training,

where it belonged while he asked a man for an account of what he had done with authority.

Panjios's door stood half-open. Through it Tobious could see a bench of service tools, a brace for the older man's stiff knee, a bowl with the remains of a meal he had eaten at his desk. None of the ordinary things absolved him. They made it harder to arrange the question as though a monster sat inside the room.

On the bench lay the dark practice blade Panjios had used to show Tobious a shield at the village terrace. Its edge was blunt and its field inactive. Panjios had once said Tobious could not be strong enough to stand wherever he wished, and had taught him to choose a place someone else could cover. Tobious had accepted the lesson from a man whose own signature now lay under his coat. The skill had saved lives. The teacher had also helped conceal a loss. Tobious could not decide which fact he wanted to make the other disappear.

Panjios looked up when they entered. He saw the old date on the first page and set down his stylus. Tobious watched his face closely. Panjios did not feign surprise. He looked at the second page, saw Suss's counter-sign, and closed his eyes for the length of one breath.

"You found it," he said.

"We found the load count," Tobious answered. "Ninety-seven. The public report says zero."

"It says zero protected losses," Panjios replied.

"You know why that difference matters."

"I do."

There was no practiced denial in his voice. Tobious found he had prepared himself for one and had no better opening when it failed to come. Ypin set the sealed packets where Panjios could see the authentication marks without touching them.

Panjios looked at Ypin. "What else?"

"The route's life readings stopped after isolation. Your authorization. Suss's implementation. We have no testimony from the ancient side."

Panjios nodded. The accuracy of the answer seemed to hurt him more than an accusation would have.

Tobious laid the papers on the workbench, where the light was good enough for all three of them to see the signatures.

“Were they alive when you closed it?” he asked.

The Terms of Mercy

“Yes,” Panjios said. “They were alive.”

The answer came before Tobious had time to dread an evasion. It did not make him feel better.

Panjios stood by the workbench with the old order between his hands. Twelve years earlier, a paired route had begun to fail while pressure built toward a populated service ward in Veyr. The ancient enclosure held ninety-seven people. If the route remained open, Suss's field model predicted a breach into the ward. If it was sealed, the people in the enclosure would be left with the load they were carrying. Panjios had signed the closure.

He showed Tobious the line he had signed. The public record had called the action an isolation of damaged material. The private order used the same phrase. No one had forged his hand. It was his judgment, and he had allowed the words to conceal what he knew from the service view.

“How much time did you have?” Tobious asked.

“Less than one hour from the first ward alarm. We spent most of it confirming the direction of the breach. By the time the closure reached my desk, the forecast said minutes.”

“Could you have moved them?”

“Not through the route as it stood. I did not test whether another access could take them. I believed testing would endanger the ward.”

Tobious wanted him to say there had been no other access. Panjios refused to give him that comfort. The record proved what he had chosen, not that he had exhausted every possibility. It was the same distance between urgency and knowledge that Tobious had crossed with Severance at the Storehouse.

“Did you see them?” Tobious asked.

“Some. Through the service view. I had their number.”

“You had their number.”

Panjios accepted the repetition. “I had no names.”

“You could have asked.”

"I could have. I believed the time it took would put the ward at risk. I signed without them."

Ypin stood by the door, keeping the authenticated record in his hand. Tobious remembered Panjios standing between a spear and his body in the old chamber, insisting that another death would not bring back the guard's brother. That care had happened. So had this order. Tobious had wanted one fact to cancel the other because living with both was harder.

"And afterward?" he asked. "The report said zero people abandoned."

"It said zero protected people. I let it stand. I told myself the decision had saved more lives and that publishing the other count would make us hesitate next time."

"Did it?"

"It made the next time easier to conceal."

Panjios turned the workroom lamp toward the signed page. "Afterward I told myself that if the model had been wrong, we would have saved the ward for nothing. I could not bear that possibility. So I spoke of the lives I had protected and let the others become a load in the official account. Each time I repeated it, I made it harder for someone else to challenge the next order."

Tobious looked at Ypin. Ypin was reading the page, not Panjios's face. Neither man asked Tobious to call the admission courage. It had come twelve years late and only after he brought them the record.

The older man looked directly at him. The admission was not a request to be forgiven. Tobious was still angry that it had taken the finding of a record to draw it out.

"You knew this while you taught me to ask who pays for a cut."

"Yes."

"Why not tell me before I accepted Severance?"

Panjios's left knee shifted beneath him. "I feared you would refuse to work with us. I believed I could keep you from repeating what I did if I taught you the rule first."

"You let me trust you without knowing what you had chosen."

"I did."

Tobious stepped away from the bench. He wanted to leave the room and force Panjios to follow, to have the argument somewhere wide enough for anger. He stayed because Mariya and forty-six others were under a field that would not wait for him to finish being hurt.

"I'll use what you know," he said. "I won't give you the right to decide what I should be told."

"That is fair."

"It is not about fairness to you. If I have to stand at another cut, the people it reaches will not be protected by your hope that I ask the right question."

Panjios bowed his head once. It was not an oath Tobious had asked for. It was the only reply he trusted at that moment.

* * *

Ypin brought the current load traces to Edda's calibration station. For weeks the stress had risen in short peaks, with less quiet time between them. A second series came from clinic observations: patients in the lower service ward with headaches, balance failures, and shield interference whenever the root load climbed. Edda had recorded the symptoms before anyone had asked her to prove a route was failing.

The two series were not identical. They did not need to be. Their peaks matched often enough that Ypin could test a forecast against injuries that had not been entered by command staff.

Edda brought them to the next room before she accepted the forecast. A transit mechanic sat with his eyes closed, waiting for the nausea from the last root fluctuation to pass. He had been working in a tunnel whose lights remained on; the floor had tilted in his body before any instrument announced a fault. Edda asked his permission to repeat the questions she had asked at intake. Tobious listened to the mechanic describe the hour and the service level. Ypin marked them on his trace. The match was not perfect. It was close enough to make another cycle of delay a risk to a person Tobious had now met.

“Suss will show the city a ward like this,” Edda said after the mechanic left. “He will be right that the root protects it. We need to say what our plan does to him when the root goes dark.”

“He can move to a conventional line?” Tobious asked.

“If the line is made ready and if someone tells him which tunnel not to enter while the transfer happens. Those are separate jobs.”

“The last viable disconnection window ends on Day Eighty-four,” he said. “After that, a full overlap can begin before a safe isolation.”

He put the word from the old maintenance records beside the forecast: **SCHLELBERG**. Tobious remembered Ypin first saying it over a map of two shores. Then it had sounded like a name for a fault someone would fix. Here it crossed a timetable of injured people, failed cooling lines, and captives holding a floor in place. It named the process by which neither era could remain whole if the root kept borrowing from the other.

“That is not eighty-four days from today,” Tobious said.

“No. From the first opening at Aras. We have thirty-seven.”

He put down three stones for the ancient accesses and one for the root. The tethered captives sat, in the model, on the branch beneath the Storehouse stone. To transfer Tobious's reference to another person, all three accesses had to remain idle for seven uninterrupted days. The current Storehouse line could not be made idle while forty-seven people carried its field. Shutting it around them would crush the enclosure or abandon them to the Iwang.

Tobious lifted the Salt stone and set it farther from the others. “What if I stay on this side and someone carries a regulator through Salt?”

Ypin returned the stone. “Salt is an access, not a separate root. The idle condition is at the reference. Moving a part through a gate changes where the part is. It does not change what the captives are attached to.”

“What if we cut Quarry first?”

“We can isolate a damaged access. The root will still carry Storehouse. The seven days still do not begin.”

He asked because every stone looked movable on the table. Ypin answered without making the questions sound foolish. By the end the four stones were where they had begun, and Tobious understood

that a map made of small objects could be cruelly honest about distance.

"Then cut the root now," Tobious said. "Destroy what keeps them there."

"The same root holds their floor in its present state," Panjios answered. "A terminal cut before release would turn their room into a collapse."

Edda moved the future city layer over the model. Cooling and transit services had been built around the root's supply over generations. They could be separated, but not by a man swinging a sword without warning the households above. If the root went dark at once, some services would fail with people inside them.

Tobious looked at her. "You mean a permanent cut can be survived."

"If we prepare," Edda said. "And if the ancient people are out first. I have not yet seen a plan that does both by the window Ypin measured."

Panjios pointed out the troughs between load peaks. They were narrowing. No one could tell them yet whether one would be long enough to release every captive, but there was a pattern to measure. Mariya's baffle notes might help them find where the load moved within it. The calendar was made of stresses and repair times, not an omen. That made it less forgiving; it also meant they could test it.

"You knew the terminal mode existed," Tobious said to Panjios.

"Yes. We have not made the ancient release or the civic preparation possible."

"Suss wants to keep the root."

"He believes its loss would leave this city weaker than its enemies and its own shortages. He is right about the damage. He is wrong to decide the people under Aras can be kept there to avoid it."

Tobious let the words settle. He had once thought an epic blade would make a hard choice simple. It could cut a root. It could not build beds for a city or carry forty-seven people up a broken stair.

* * *

Suss arrived with a proposal already measured. He showed Tobious a controlled high-gain trial, two guarded cuts in quick succession on an isolated branch, followed by a limited extraction if the trial held. He named the risk to Tobious's hand and nerves. He named the temporary rise in network load. He did not name the bodies to which that load could be routed.

He placed a second forecast beside Ypin's. Both ended near Day Eighty-four. Suss's line was narrower because his command gauges did not include Edda's injury reports; Ypin's was rougher because he lacked the protected junction data. The agreement between them frightened Tobious more than either forecast alone. Suss had not come to dismiss the deadline. He had come with a way to use it.

"The public will move service wards if you ask them to," Suss said to Edda. "They will not dismantle a functioning root because you cannot promise the ancient floor will survive another week."

"I have not asked them to dismantle it today," Edda answered. "I am asking you to count the people on that floor as patients when you measure harm."

Suss looked at Tobious. "You know what happens when we let an unknown load remain unknown until the time to act is gone."

Tobious did. He had made a cut too soon. Suss was pressing the opposite fear: that asking one more question could become an excuse to do nothing. Both fears had a real history now. Neither named the people who would absorb this trial's heat.

"The first extraction can give us direct evidence of the far floor," Suss said. "We need it to plan the rest."

"You offered to take Mariya," Tobious replied. "She hasn't agreed."

"Then speak to her."

Tobious looked at the diagram. The gain setting was the one he had used in the isolated test after the cooling-station rescue. It had worked. Its heat had appeared on a gauge, not on a person. This branch was different. Ypin's records left part of its routing behind command permission.

"I want every measure shown to Ypin," he said. "And Edda sees my medical readings. I will not carry a setting whose only warning is that I fall over afterward."

Suss agreed to the operator readings. Panjios objected that the network route remained unverified. Suss answered that no extraction would be authorized until a trial had reduced that uncertainty. Tobious could see where Panjios was right. He could also hear the ninety-seven unnamed people inside every warning the older man now gave. Losing trust did not change the engineering; it made Tobious demand independent proof that was not yet available.

"A guarded trial," he said. "Not a live extraction until we hear from Mariya."

"Agreed," Suss said. "A supervised diagnostic window opens tomorrow. You can speak with her."

Tobious put his name on the trial authorization. He read the lines Ypin translated about injury to the operator. He asked for a measure of the network strain and accepted Suss's promise to provide it. He did not ask what *network* meant at the far floor, or whether a monitor that called its people loads could tell him when one of them was hurt.

Ypin watched him sign. He had put his own name on a form without looking behind a category. He could have stopped Tobious by refusing to operate the trial. He did not yet have evidence that the isolated branch reached the captives. He did say, "I want the full return path before you touch it."

"Suss said you'll have the readings."

"Readings after the cut are not the same as a route before it."

Tobious knew the difference. He had taught himself to know it at the debrief wall. He answered, "Then help me get the route," but left the signed form on Suss's table. He had not made Ypin a condition of consent. He had asked him to repair a decision already taken.

The omission was not made for him. He made it himself because a working method and a narrowing window had offered him something that felt like control.

A Table with Three Places

The relay opened with the sound of water in a stone channel.

Tobious leaned toward the speaking surface before a voice came through. A small indicator above it gave them a fixed interval. Ypin had explained that the Storehouse branch could spare no more power today. The contact would end when the mark reached the far side, whether or not they had finished saying what mattered.

“Tobi?”

Mariya's voice was thin and uneven, but it was hers. He closed his eyes for a moment. He could see her on the granary steps with flour at her temple. When he opened them, the relay light was already moving.

“I'm here. Are you hurt?”

“Tired. Forty-seven of us are alive. Thesia died. Did you tell her sister?”

“The porter carried the name. I asked him to have her told about the children too.”

There was a brief gap. A clicking sound crossed the line from the annex, one high note and two low. Mariya waited for it to pass before speaking.

“We need more clean water. The ration hatch opens, but not enough for washing. The landing is real. The tether won't let us use it.”

“I've seen the map. We are trying a faster release setting.”

“Who is *we*?”

“Suss has the route. Panjios and Ypin are checking it. Edda is watching the injuries.”

“And what is the route?”

He told her about the selective extraction. It could free one person early by distributing strain through the others and a temporary sink. He did not say her name until she asked whether Suss had chosen someone.

“He said you could come first.”

"Did he say who carries what leaves with me?"

"He says the added strain is below a monitored threshold."

"That isn't a name."

"I know."

"Then I can't agree."

He gripped the edge of the table. "You can get out of there. We can ask after you're safe."

"I want to get out," she said. Her voice sharpened. "Do you think I don't? I want to sleep where the wall doesn't creak. I want to eat bread without watching whether Lios has had his. I want to see you standing in a doorway without wondering if the floor will move between us. I will not buy that by making the others hold a cost no one has explained to them."

He had prepared for noble refusal. Her anger made him hear the desire inside it. She was not choosing danger because she loved suffering. She was choosing not to make another person unknowingly bear her escape.

"I thought if I could show you a door," he said, "you would let me open it."

"Show me what it does to the room. Then we can decide."

The indicator crossed its midpoint. Tobious wanted to spend the rest of the interval calculating. Mariya had already sent measurements. He could not give her a safe date today. He could tell her something else without pretending it solved the count.

"I missed you at supper," he said.

She was quiet. He heard movement around her, someone asking for a jar, then her answer to them. She returned to the relay.

"What did you eat?"

"A cake Ypin made. I had to fry it again."

"Of course you did."

"He says the fruit they put inside it is meant to be sour."

"You bought a second one anyway, didn't you?"

He looked through the booth glass at Ypin, who had turned discreetly away. "I did."

"Tell me something else that isn't a machine," she said.

He looked past Ypin to the evening beyond the booth. "There is a woman in the lower ward who grows bitter greens on her window

rail. She trades them for broken cups because her grandson makes the handles into little boats.”

“Does she know you?”

“She says I use too much water to wash a pan.”

“Then I believe she knows you.”

He wanted to describe the floating gardens and the luminous streets, all the things that had made Veyr seem beyond any place she could imagine. Instead he told her how the woman guarded her greens from gulls and how Ypin's kitchen plants leaned toward a warm service pipe. Those details could belong to a life she might choose, if they reached one. He would not use them to sell the city to her now.

Mariya laughed. The sound was small, frayed by the line, and more welcome than any reassurance he had received since leaving her.

He remembered a flood in the year they were both old enough to be trusted with tools and too young to be trusted with a gate. Samon had sent them to watch the upper channel. Rain turned the path to clay before they reached it. Tobious had insisted he could force the swollen sluice wheel; Mariya found the silted outlet that made the wheel resist. They came home wet, carrying half a basket of mud and no heroic story to tell. At supper she had eaten his portion of figs because he was busy explaining how close the wall had come to failing. He had thought of her first whenever a channel ran wrong after that. The habit had lasted longer than any flood.

“What are you smiling at?” she asked.

“The year you stole my figs after the upper gate flooded.”

“You gave them to me while you talked. Your memory is unreliable.”

“Then we will need a witness when we finally have that week.”

The line carried her breathing for a moment. Neither treated the imagined week as a contract the world had signed for them. It was something they still wanted.

“I keep thinking of the sluice,” she said. “After rain, when the stone has warmed by noon. It makes that hollow noise before the east gate opens.”

“Samon says the mason's brother still turns it too early.”

“Samon says that about everyone.”

“He said it about me, and he was right.”

“I want a meal without counting portions,” she said. “I want to sit long enough to finish it. With you.”

The ordinary wish filled the booth more completely than a promise of rescue. Tobious had imagined being strong enough to offer her a future. He had not imagined she would tell him what kind of future she wanted and that he might simply listen.

“I love you,” he said.

She breathed in. For one fearful heartbeat he thought the line had failed.

He had imagined saying it on the shore path in Aras, with no one listening and no fixed interval. He had waited for a day in which the words would not sound like another promise he could not keep. The dial was still moving. He said them because they were true inside this day, with its broken plan and narrow line.

“I love you too, Tobi. It isn't why I stay with them. It is why I need you to understand me while I do.”

The indicator approached its end. Tobious told her what he could promise: he would work for all forty-seven, ask who carried each proposed cost, and send an honest timetable when one existed. He could not promise success. She asked for water, a release sequence, and the truth if the window narrowed. She did not ask him to become fearless. He did not ask her to wait for him as proof of love.

“The relay closes in ten breaths,” Ypin said from behind the glass.

Mariya heard him. “Tell him I can hear him counting.”

Ypin lifted a hand. Tobious saw Mariya in the gesture: her insistence on making another person visible even from a sealed room.

They used the remaining breaths to say the names of two people who needed care. Then the line quieted. The indicator reached its end exactly. No necessary confession was stolen by a convenient failure. Everything they had said remained unfinished because their lives were.

* * *

Ypin's kitchen had three chairs because a colleague sometimes came to share a meal after a late shift. Tonight the third held Tobious's coat and the record copy from the archive. He moved both to the floor before sitting. It was a small act; he felt foolish noticing it.

Ypin warmed bread in a shallow pan. "You argued with her."

"She argued with me."

"Did she change your mind?"

"She made me say what my mind was. I hadn't done that."

"What was it?"

"I wanted her out even if I couldn't explain the cost. I thought because I loved her the answer would be obvious to her too."

Ypin turned the bread before it burned. "It was obvious. She wants to live. She also wants the others asked."

"I heard her."

"Then that was a useful argument."

Ypin put the bread between them. The plants by the warm pipe had grown since Tobious last ate here. One leaf had turned brown at the edge, but the rest leaned toward the window. Ypin checked the water in its dish before taking his own food.

"You keep offering yourself for every dangerous part," he said. "Then you get angry when someone else wants a say in the danger."

"The root chose my body."

"The root acquired your signal. It doesn't make you responsible for every hand in the room."

Tobious tore a piece of bread. "If I let someone else take the risk and they die, I will still have to live with it."

"Yes," Ypin said. "So will they if you take it and die. The point of asking is not to make the cost disappear."

They ate for a while. Tobious looked at the record beside his coat. Ypin's signature on the newer biological-load form had traveled with the copy to Edda. The technician had not asked for it to be hidden.

"What happened to the forms you signed?" Tobious asked.

"I traced some of them. Most were routine loads. Some had the same neural flags as the people under Aras. I don't know how many were people. I should have asked eighteen months ago."

"You told me you hadn't proved it."

“At the time I hadn't. I also knew enough to be worried. I liked the idea that if I collected a perfect record, someone else would decide what to do with it.”

Tobious thought of his own signed trial authorization. He had demanded measurements of injury to his hand. He had not demanded the names behind *network load*. Each man had found a way to make a missing answer belong to a later day.

“We'll ask now,” Tobious said.

“And if they refuse?”

“Then the refusal becomes part of the record.”

Ypin took the third chair and pulled it closer to the table. He set the authenticated copy on it so they could compare its dates with the current trial plan. It was a practical surface. For an instant Tobious imagined Mariya sitting there, objecting to how late they were eating and taking the crisp edge from his bread. He let the image be pleasant without using it to decide for her.

The copy listed when the network had taken power, not whose nerves had steadied it. Ypin showed Tobious the missing column, then showed the form bearing his own signature. He did not push it aside when their hands reached the same page. “I am going to ask for the full path again,” he said. “This time I will let Edda know if they refuse.”

“And Suss?”

“He will know when Edda files the refusal.”

Tobious thought of the trial he had signed. He could withdraw his name from it before dawn. He wanted to wait for one more reading. Ypin could see the delay in his face. He did not argue Tobious out of it over bread; he left the form where they would both have to look at it when the meal was done.

The Unbarred Edge

The first thing the higher gain gave Tobious was speed. The second was pain he could not describe without sounding as if he had swallowed a live wire.

On the first day he mistook the speed for control. He completed one guarded cut and lifted Severance before Ypin called the measured reset. The blade accepted a second contact sooner than it should have. The artificial sink took the draw, but the handle jerked in his grip. His next step carried him across the painted cover line. Jorra pulled him back by the collar before the practice barrier discharged. No one had been hurt; the trial had worked as designed in the narrow sense and failed in the wider one.

“You were watching the blade,” she said.

“It was ready.”

“I wasn’t.”

He had used the shorter interval to outrun the person assigned to keep him alive. In the next trial, Jorra called her position before Ypin permitted contact. Suss did not object. He wanted the setting to be usable, not merely impressive on a display.

Edda made him stop after every measured trial. She checked his pulse, his hand, the small changes in balance he tried to hide by standing still. Suss kept the gain low at first, increasing it only when the monitoring display showed that the artificial sink could take another load. Panjios stood beyond the practice barrier and watched every setting. Ypin ran the service trace. No one called the method forbidden in the room; they called it an emergency setting, which was both more accurate and easier to consent to.

With Severance's ordinary guarded cut, Tobious waited thirty seconds before the core could settle. With the gain raised, the second cut became available while he could still feel the first in his arm. That change was real. It also left his fingers trembling when he tried to lift a cup afterward.

The cup mattered more to Edda than his claim that he could still hold the blade. She asked him to trace a line on a slate with the same fingers. It wandered twice. He could force a grip around a large handle; he could not make the small corrections that told a healer his hand had recovered. She wrote the difference in the record while he watched.

“Stop for today,” Edda said on the third session.

“The hand is steady enough.”

“You have spilled water twice while telling me that.”

He looked at the damp rim of the table. She had not exaggerated.

Panjios asked Suss whether the root's temporary draw had been kept entirely on the artificial sink. Suss showed the rated capacity. Panjios asked for the live route behind the rating. Suss said the trial had not required that permission level. Tobious listened from the medical chair.

Suss did not dismiss the question. He offered a view of the sealed sink and the heat it had taken, enough to show that the local test load had not failed. Panjios insisted that the return path beyond the sink could still matter during a live cut. Tobious could hear the two men arguing from measurements neither possessed in full. Earlier he would have trusted Panjios to be the cautious one and Suss to be the capable one. Since the archive, he found it harder to let either role settle the argument for him.

“You didn't tell me about the ninety-seven until I found your signature,” he said to Panjios. “If the trace is missing, tell me what measurement would prove you right.”

Panjios's face closed, then opened with an effort. “A full routing trace of the return load. I have asked for it.”

“And when they give it?”

“We will examine it together.”

Tobious wanted to believe the promise. It had arrived after the years when it would have been easiest to trust.

* * *

On Day Fifty-three, a trial at a cooling branch became a rescue before Suss could shut it down.

Ypin and a crew member had entered a service bay to verify that the practice load remained isolated. The cooling shutter dropped behind them when its guide failed. Tobious heard the impact through the floor. A warning light on Ypin's board changed from green to a color he had learned to fear. The temperature inside the bay began climbing; if the return water stopped altogether, the pressure would push into nearby homes.

A service dispatcher appeared at the outer pane with a list of those homes. One housed a night school whose children were still inside; another had patients waiting for a cooling cabinet to be repaired. The dispatcher was already calling the ward to move them. She did not ask Tobious to save the whole district. She asked how many minutes she could tell the residents they had. Suss gave her a number with a margin wide enough for retreat. Tobious listened to the dispatcher repeat it without rounding down. The people beyond the wall were not an abstract consequence of a failed return line.

Suss mapped the two shutter points. The first cut would open the worker side, the second would free the service return before its heat rose too far. Under ordinary recovery, Severance would wait between them. The trapped crew did not have thirty seconds for the second while the guide was still bending.

"High gain," Suss said. "Two cuts. No pursuit beyond the bay."

Jorra put her shield between Tobious and the failing guide. Sennos held a line at the door. Tobious set the blade to the first seam. He made the three-heartbeat contact cleanly, feeling his own protection drop. The shutter opened enough for Ypin to push the crew member toward the gap. A metal fragment struck Jorra's field and drove her shoulder against the wall. She held.

"Return's next," Ypin called. "Don't let it back into the housing."

The core had not settled. Suss raised the gain. Tobious felt heat gather in the grip, then set the edge to the second seam. He counted three beats, though the last seemed to stretch. The channel opened. The return water found its proper course with a sound like a river forced into a narrow bed.

The strain ran through his elbow after he lifted the blade. For a moment he could not tell whether his shield had returned. He waited for Jorra to call cover before stepping back. She did, sharply,

as though she knew he might move without her. The saved minutes were real; so was how close the technique brought him to trusting his own sensation more than the team's signal.

Ypin pulled the crew member through. She was conscious but burned at one forearm. Tobious caught Ypin's sleeve when he stumbled, and the four of them retreated behind Jorra's line. The bay cooled. In the rooms beyond the wall, people who had been close to losing water would only notice a brief interruption.

Suss checked the injured worker before looking at the instrument. "Both out?"

"Both," Sennos said.

"Then the method did its job."

Tobious wanted to agree. Ypin was breathing beside him. The worker was on a stretcher, in pain and alive. The usefulness of the faster cut had never been more obvious.

The dispatcher returned to say the school and clinic had moved people clear. The warning in those homes would be lifted after the line held through another cycle. They had not needed to see Severance to benefit from the cut. Tobious liked that more than he wanted to admit. He had wanted a power that could protect people he did not know. Now it had, and the evidence of that good made the thin spike on his monitor harder to face.

On Tobious's private monitor, a narrow spike appeared beneath the artificial-load trace. It had the Storehouse branch's signature. He asked Suss about it while Edda sealed the worker's burn.

"Settling from the shared root," Suss said. "The return jumped when the shutter moved. It should be temporary."

"Was the ancient branch carrying it?"

"The local sink took the trial draw. I will have command confirm the route."

Tobious looked for Ypin. He was helping the stretcher team make the turn. By the time he returned, the spike had faded from the live screen. The private monitor had stored it.

"I need the full routing trace," Ypin said after Tobious described the line. Tobious kept the saved file closed in his hand.

"Suss asked command to confirm it."

"I need it before another high-gain cut."

Tobious did not disagree. He also knew what would happen if he filed the anomaly as a possible live-load injury without proof: the practice would stop, the Day-57 operation might be cancelled, and Mariya would spend more time in the annex while the Day-84 window drew closer.

Ypin held out his hand for the device. Tobious could have given it to him. A dated file and Ypin's independent reading would have made it harder for Suss to call the spike settling noise. Instead Tobious turned the screen dark and said he needed to compare the calibration on the next trial. Ypin let his hand fall. Their friendship did not give him authority to seize it; it had made him expect Tobious to offer it.

"Let me compare it with the next measured trial," he said.

Ypin's mouth tightened. "That's an answer for later."

"I know."

He did not show Ypin the stored spike. He told himself a second reading would make the first useful. The choice gave him one more day of the method he wanted to work.

* * *

On Day Fifty-five, Tobious signed the Day-57 operation plan. Its stated goal was a live survey and staged release preparation for all forty-seven captives. The first step would cut a rated support line under supervision. Suss's command team held the full routing map. Panjios had attached an objection to the high-gain setting. Edda's medical restrictions were listed beside Tobious's name.

Panjios came to the signing room with his objection on a separate page. He did not ask Tobious to trust him because he had warned him about ninety-seven people. "My signature on the old order is a reason to demand better proof from me," he said. "It is also a reason I will not call a return route safe because its first column looks clean."

"You asked for the trace," Tobious said.

"Yes. If it comes before the operation, read it with Ypin. If it does not, make the delay part of your decision."

Tobious resented the phrasing. He had wanted Panjios to tell him whether to sign, then hated himself for wanting to put the choice back in the older man's hands. The page stayed beside the plan. Panjios left it there without touching Tobious's pen.

Ypin asked again for the trace. Command provided a summary showing temporary network draw below its stated limit. It did not show who or what received the draw. Ypin filed a request for the underlying route. The response time was longer than the time left before the operation.

Edda examined Tobious before signing the medical line. He could sustain one standard guarded cut with support. The high-gain setting still left tremor after repetition. She approved his presence at the survey, not unlimited use of the setting. Tobious asked whether the plan would be canceled if he refused high gain. She said she could not know what Suss would do with a refusal. She wrote that answer on the margin, where it could not later become a doctor's consent to the whole route.

Tobious placed his private device beneath the paper while she wrote. He could feel its thin edge against his wrist. The saved spike was a dated reason to stop and ask who bore the extra draw. He did not put it on the table. He knew by then that he was not waiting for better evidence; he was protecting a method that might bring Mariya out before the window closed.

Tobious could have told Edda about the Storehouse spike. He could have demanded the underlying trace before signing. He pictured Mariya in the annex, the clicking wall, the counted water jars. He also remembered the two people pulled from the cooling shutter while the core was still warm. The technique had saved them.

He signed.

That night his right hand trembled when he untied his wrist support. He held it under cool water and watched the movement subside. On the private device by his bed, the old spike remained. It had no name beside it. He let the display go dark without sending it to anyone.

A Name for the Missing

Pehl asked for the last clean cup because his daughter would be waiting at the outer hatch.

Mariya gave it to him. The cup had belonged to Lios's broken jug, and the boy had spent the morning carrying it between the water jars and the injured. Pehl wanted to fill it with the freshest water they had. The guard would probably make his daughter take it back empty, but he said the girl would know he had thought of her.

He had made a mark on the clay near the base, the shape his daughter used when she pressed a thumb into new pots. He had taught her to test a fired vessel with a small stone. The clear note meant it might hold water; the dull one meant a hidden crack. He tapped the cup now. Its repaired rim gave a note neither of them liked.

"It holds," Lios said. He had watched the cup survive too many trips across the room to hear it judged by sound alone.

"You are right," Pehl told him. "A potter can learn from a boy who carries the thing."

Lios took the compliment seriously. He went to refill the other vessels, careful not to strike the repaired rim against the stone.

"Tell her you need new boots too," Annet said. "She's been asking how to help."

"I need a new stone wheel," Pehl answered. "And a world where she has time to play instead of bringing food through a gate."

Annet gave him a tired smile. Her shoulder from the guard's blow had healed badly. She could still tie the water skins, though she no longer carried full ones. She and Hessah had spent the night mending the worst seams with strips from their hems.

They had argued over whether the knot should be doubled. Annet liked the tighter join; Hessah said it wasted cloth and made the mouth hard to clean. At dawn Annet had tested both with a full skin. Hessah's held. Annet had used the other one anyway for the trip between jars, because its opening suited her sore shoulder. They

were still debating it when Pehl asked for the cup. Mariya had been glad to hear two people quarrel about a repair instead of about who would be allowed to leave first.

Mariya watched them in the dry recess. Forty-seven people. She had begun to know the count by gaps in their work, not by the tile on which Nerissa wrote their names. Pehl always kept a small stone in his pocket to test the sound of a pot before firing it. Annet complained when the water was stale and then drank last. If either failed to answer, the room would change shape around the absence.

The pulse came while Pehl was lifting the cup.

The argument stopped in the middle of a word. Mariya saw Annet look up, recognizing a changed sound before she did. The basin water drew one way and then held, a slanted surface that should have fallen. Mariya shouted for everyone to leave the painted line. She had time to see Lios back away from it. Then the pressure took her balance.

Water rose against the side of the basin without a hand touching it. The baffle clicked twice too quickly, then made a low sound Mariya had never heard. People staggered. A line of cold pressure ran along the floor and tightened around their ankles. Mariya lost control of her own left hand for a moment; the cup she had been carrying fell and rolled beneath a shelf.

Pehl went down first. He struck the stone on his side, still trying to keep Lios's cup upright. Annet reached for him and could not coordinate her fingers. Hessah braced her against the wall. Nerissa called for everyone to stay off the painted seam until the pressure eased.

Mariya crawled to Pehl. His breath came in small, uneven pulls. He looked past her toward the outer hatch.

"The cup," he said.

"It's here."

She held it where he could see it. He seemed to want to say more, but the next breath did not complete. Nerissa reached them, checked for a pulse, then rested a hand on Mariya's wrist. Pehl's daughter would receive a cup of water and a name spoken by people who had watched him die. Mariya wanted the gift to be larger. It would not be.

The field released a little at a time. Annet could speak again. She asked whether Pehl had gone through the hatch. When Mariya told her, she turned her face to the wall and asked Hessah to leave the water skin beside her.

The surge left Annet unable to keep down the thin broth Darran's guards supplied. Nerissa treated her as best she could with water, rest, and the medicine they had saved. Annet could still complain about the stale taste on her tongue. She asked Hessah to show the others how to retie the skins so no one would have to drink from a leaking mouth again.

Before the last light went, she asked Mariya whether Pehl's daughter had been told. Mariya said she could send a message at the next window. Annet shook her head. The next window was a machine's chance, not a child's. She asked the guard at the hatch to pass a word to the girl when she came with the morning water. The guard refused to carry messages. Hessah told him the girl might bring food his shift needed; he could at least tell her whether to wait. The guard said he would speak if he saw her. No one knew whether he meant it.

Nerissa tried small sips rather than another bowl of broth. Annet kept one down and said the water still tasted stale. Hessah opened the skin she had mended with the looser knot and brought a fresh measure from the last clean jar. Annet noticed the knot and tried to argue. She could not finish the sentence. Hessah sat beside her and did not tell her to save her breath. Annet died before the next ration. Mariya heard Nerissa stop counting her pulse and begin the slower work of covering her body.

Mariya wrote both names on the tile. Pehl had died during the pulse. Annet had lived through it and died under the strain afterward. Collapsing the two into a single loss would make it easier for Darran to say the surge had ended when its warning lights went out.

* * *

Darran called it a stabilization event.

He spoke through the ration hatch while his guard set down fewer portions than the forty-five living people required. Mariya counted them twice. Darran said the root had drawn heavily and deliveries would resume after the line recovered. The food was being kept for a later shift, he said, not withheld from her group.

"There are only forty-five of us now," she answered. "You brought food for thirty-eight."

"Then divide it."

She felt herself preparing to do exactly that, to choose who could bear hunger and then explain the choice after everyone had eaten. Nerissa stood beside her, waiting. Orran asked for a moment to speak with her in the sleeping recess.

"If we use the landing," he said quietly, "we move the ones who can climb first. We don't tell the others until we know the route holds. Some will slow us before we have proof."

"The tether stops us," Mariya said.

"If Tobious cuts it. When he does. We should already know the order."

"We should. We won't make that order in secret."

"They'll refuse to be last."

"They may. They live with the result."

Orran looked away. She did not call him cruel. He had caught her belt when Thesia fell. He knew a weak ledge could take anyone. His proposal came from fear and a stoneworker's habit of putting the strongest support first. The weakness was treating people as timber that could be positioned without a word.

Nerissa called everyone who could move to the center of the dry floor. Those who could not were represented by the people caring for them, and Mariya made sure they could hear the discussion. She told them the actual ration number and said she could not promise the next delivery. She showed the storage vessels and asked how much water they should keep for the injured. Others offered answers she had not considered.

Hessah wanted water kept near the warm wall because the cold floor made her mother's joints seize when she stood to fetch it at night. A younger worker said the warm wall was closer to the active seam and the jars might break in another pulse. They moved the

vessels one pace back and put two smaller skins within reach of those who could not walk. It was a compromise measured in arm lengths, not a principle that solved hunger. One man said he would forgo his portion. Nerissa refused to build the plan on people competing to be the most self-denying. She asked who had eaten last, who was ill, and who would need strength to carry water in the morning.

Then Nerissa said, "There is something else you owe them."

Mariya knew. The protected seed jar sat above them in Aras, its broken seal a private mark she had made fifty days ago.

"Before we were trapped, I took grain from one of the two seed jars," she said. "I fed households that had run out, including children here. I recorded how much. I did not ask every household that had a share in the jar."

Annet's sister was not there; Pehl's daughter was outside. Among the captives, Hessah's mother said she had eaten that bread and would have asked for it herself. Another woman said the sowing would need every grain left and that Mariya had hidden the cost until it could no longer be challenged. Both were right about parts of what had happened.

"I would feed them again," Mariya said. "I should have told you what I used and let you argue with me while there was time."

"Will you ask next time?" Orran asked.

"Yes."

He studied her, perhaps measuring whether the answer would survive urgency. She could not prove it with a speech. They formed a small distribution council: Nerissa for care, Hessah for water, Orran for the route and physical work, Mariya for the current stores and outside messages, and two people chosen by the other households. The council divided the thirty-eight portions and recorded who needed more the next day. The process did not create seven missing meals. It made the loss a shared decision instead of Mariya's private burden.

The first division took longer than Mariya would have taken alone. Two of the people who could walk objected to being given less than a full portion when they were assigned to lift jars. Hessah agreed they needed enough for that work, but asked why her mother

had been left off the carrying list when she had been hauling water since before they were trapped. Orran changed the list. Nerissa found an ill man who had been counted as able to walk because he had done so once in the morning. They adjusted his portion and his task. No one applauded the council. The people ate, knowing who had made each choice and where to argue tomorrow.

* * *

At the next diagnostic window, the wafer refused to send.

Mariya had recorded the surge's timing, the two deaths, the current count of forty-five, and Darran's reduced rations. She added that the wall had made a new double click and that the pressure had reached bodies before the usual baffle opened. When she pressed the marked edge, the wafer showed a waiting light, then a broken one. It kept the message in memory. It had not handed it to the relay.

Lios watched from the dry recess. "Will Tobi hear it tomorrow?"

"I don't know."

She disliked the answer less than she had in the first days. It left room for them to plan a second way to carry the warning when a window returned.

The baffle clicked once. Mariya took the tile with the forty-five names to Nerissa and Orran. She showed them where the newest marks were and which people needed help to stand. If another pulse took her balance or her breath, someone else could make the count. Nerissa corrected one mark. Orran asked whether the wider service recess would fit a stretcher. Mariya did not know. He offered to test it when the fields quieted.

They were still trapped. They had lost Thesia, Pehl, and Annet. Mariya could no longer promise that every person would leave. She could tell the truth to the people who remained, and let them help decide what the truth required next.

What Power Takes

The operation began with forty-seven names the public board refused to show.

Ypin had written them on a private strip beside the control desk. Mariya's latest packet had not come through, so the list still held Pehl and Annet. Tobious knew they might be alive. He also knew the last field surge had registered from the Storehouse branch without a clinical report. He told himself the missing packet was another delay of the old kind, not a sign that the people beneath Aras had been hurt while Veyr prepared its machines.

Suss brought the team to an active branch control room beneath Root Hall. Behind a transparent wall, the root's light moved through a narrow seam in ancient stone. From here Tobious could see the city above through layered service walks: the High Concourse, its skyway, and the transit lines carrying people to work. The root had been enclosed by generations of repair. It was old; the need for it was current.

A repair shift was finishing when they arrived. Its supervisor had a child's drawing folded into the pocket of her work coat, the paper soft at the creases. She asked Suss whether the corridor would remain open after the test; her crew had a damaged cooling joint to replace before night. Suss gave her a time and asked her to move the two workers nearest the branch to reserve cover. She obeyed because he had kept such promises before. Tobious had seen him protect crews under pressure. That history made this room harder to reduce to a struggle between an obvious villain and everyone who could see through him.

The plan called for one high-gain cut at a rated support line. The Storehouse captives would remain tethered while engineers tested a release sequence. Panjios insisted on a manual isolation door standing ready. Suss granted it but placed command staff at its controls.

Ypin sat at the trace station with the full routing view finally opened for live operation. He checked the artificial sink first, then the return path. His face changed. Tobious had learned to notice the moment a maintenance person stopped seeing numbers and started seeing what a number could do.

"The return isn't isolated," Ypin said. "It goes through biological stabilization."

"Rated below injury," Suss replied. "Keep the sequence."

Ypin expanded the line. There were identifiers beside the draw, not just a total. He cross-matched the first with Mariya's roster. Nerissa. The second with Hessah. Others followed, people whose names Tobious had heard over the relay. The label *artificial load* sat above them. Beneath it, the root would take the cost from living bodies.

Ypin called the numbers aloud to the supervisor. She went to the wall display and found the same return path under her crew's permit, but without the biological identifiers. Her hands were still dirty from the joint repair. "My people were told it was isolated," she said.

"The local sink is," Suss answered. "The stabilizing return is not."

"Then they were told half the route."

Suss did not deny it. He ordered her crew back from the control line, arguing that an interrupted root surge would kill people in the ward above. The supervisor moved her workers to cover but remained where she could see the tracing. She was not joining Tobious. She would be able to tell someone what the room had shown.

Tobious took out his private device. The spike from Day Fifty-three matched the return signature. He had seen this shape before and left it in the dark because the method had saved Ypin. Now a line from the earlier day ran into the same group of names.

"I had a spike," he said. "After the cooling shutter. I didn't file it."

Ypin turned toward him. He was not surprised that the anomaly existed. He was surprised that Tobious had held it.

Suss pointed at the rising load. "If you stop now, the future service line loses its support. We finish the mapped cut, then compensate."

"You called it an artificial sink."

"That chamber has one. The return path uses the network. We have kept it under the tolerances."

"Thesia died. Two more may have died after the last surge. Your tolerance doesn't have their names."

"You don't know what happened to the two." Suss's answer was exact and cold. "I know what happens to the service ward if you release this line halfway through."

Panjios moved toward the manual door. "We can isolate, take the city load on reserve, and stop until the names are checked."

"Reserve will not hold the full corridor," Suss said. "You signed the operational risk."

"I signed a rated artificial return."

The root's tone rose. Tobious felt it in his right hand where he held Severance. The first contact point waited ahead of him. He could make the cut Suss wanted, and another few people in Veyr might keep water and transit today. In Aras, people with names would take a cost they had never accepted. He set the blade down on the insulated stand.

The metal met the stand with a sound smaller than the root's rising tone. Tobious had imagined refusal would feel like a door closing against Suss. Instead he saw the repair supervisor still checking her crew, Ypin trying to preserve the names, Jorra watching the exposed seam. The choice to stop had left them all inside the danger. He would have to help them leave it without using another blind cut.

"I won't make the next cut," he said.

Suss crossed the room without a threat or a speech. He reached for the sword and Tobious's wrist at once. He could not sustain the reference contact by forcing Tobious's hand, but he could hold him in place while command drove the gain and the root continued to draw. Tobious pulled free. The control rail shuddered. A lens above the seam cracked and fell.

His shield had thinned during the aborted contact. A shard cut below his left eye. Blood entered the corner of his vision. He raised the injured hand too late to stop the next piece. Jorra's field caught it; she was forced backward into the door frame.

“Isolation,” Panjios called.

He seized the manual control. The heavy door began to descend between the active branch and the service walk. Two future workers were still on the far side, trapped after the rail shifted. Ypin went for them while Sennos covered the passage. The root made a sound like water forced through a pipe too narrow to hold it.

* * *

Panjios held the isolation control with both hands. The mechanism required pressure from someone present; if he released it before the workers crossed, the door would drop into their path. His old knee shook under the load. Tobious could see the service descent beyond him, a set of narrow steps cut between the newer machinery and the ancient wall. Ypin had shown him the route on ordinary maintenance visits. It was the way out if the powered lifts failed. Today they had.

The supervisor with the drawing reached the near side of the door. She called the trapped workers by name. One answered; the other was trying to free his boot. Panjios asked her to take the first down the service steps and keep the landing clear. She wanted to stay for both. He said the door could only hold while people moved through it. She looked at his knee, then took the first worker's arm and led her away. The drawing showed at her pocket as she went.

“Come with us,” Tobious said.

“When the last one is through.”

The first worker reached the gap. Sennos pulled her clear. The second had caught a boot beneath a bent coupling rail. Ypin braced the rail and tried to lift it. Tobious moved to help. His right hand trembled; blood from beneath his eye spotted the stone. He set Severance's inert flat under the rail as a lever. It shifted enough for the worker to drag his foot free.

“Now,” Tobious said to Panjios.

The older man looked at the door. He would have to release the control and cross before its weight came down. Tobious reached for his arm, believing he could pull him in one motion. Panjios tried.

The rail sprang against the worker's path. He pushed the control down again and the gap held.

"Get them out first," he said.

It was the same choice he had denied ninety-seven others twelve years ago. Tobious saw it and refused to let the resemblance make this death righteous. Panjios could have told the truth earlier. He could have helped stop the current loading before the room shook. He was helping now, and help was not a way to erase the record.

Suss reached the control from the command side. "Release it. We can reroute the corridor."

"Through the ancient branch?" Panjios asked.

"Through the rated network."

"The network has names."

Suss drew his field blade. Tobious saw the beginning of its coupling at Panjios's shoulder. Jorra was still holding cover over the workers. Sennos was on the descent with the first. Tobious took one step toward Suss, but the bent rail dropped in front of him. He had no clean path through it and no shield strong enough to force one.

Panjios could have let the control go and defended himself. He held the door long enough for Ypin to push the second worker through. Suss's blade passed the shoulder sector of his field. The older man fell against the manual lever. The door stayed open a little longer under his weight.

Tobious had seen Panjios use that same shoulder to demonstrate a shield turn on the village terrace. The motion now was smaller, the body unable to keep pace with the blade. There was no noble posture to make the blow easier to watch. Suss had chosen a place the defender could not guard without letting the door fall. The second worker stumbled across the line and Sennos caught him. Only then could Sennos clear the last boot from the path.

"Panji!" Tobious called.

Panjios turned his head. Tobious did not know whether he heard the familiar name or merely the sound. Then Suss pulled the lever clear. The door came down between them.

For a moment Tobious saw only the dark metal panel. It was thick enough to keep a surge from the escape passage. It was not thick enough to make the man on the other side less dead.

Ypin grabbed Tobious's coat. "The descent. Now."

"The archive—"

"We have partial copies. We don't have another door."

He had connected a recorder to the live trace. It held the complete routing view, including the names. He went back for it when the panel began to spark. The coupling rail fell across Tobious's leg. Tobious cried out and tried to pull free. Ypin looked once from the recorder to him, then abandoned the device.

He lifted the hot rail with a service bar. The heat burned his left forearm through the sleeve. Tobious dragged his leg clear. The recorder disappeared beneath a spray of glass as the active branch overloaded. The authenticated excerpts Ypin had copied earlier remained in his case; the strongest proof had been left because a living person was under metal.

They descended the service stair. Jorra and Sennos held the first landing while the two workers moved down. Tobious limped between them with Severance sheathed, unable to go back through the closed isolation door. Behind the wall, Suss ordered the Quarry access shut to prevent another surge. It answered with a series of violent pulses; its service channel would not carry a safe crossing now.

At the lower ward, emergency notices appeared on public surfaces. The Concord field commander reported that an unauthorized interruption by the new reference had threatened essential services. It was a partial account with enough truth to travel quickly. Tobious had delayed a warning, violated the Day-42 inspection limit, and refused the current cut. The notice omitted the names routed beneath the artificial-load label and Panjios's death at Suss's hand.

Ypin read it while Edda's clinic staff took the injured workers inside. His forearm was blistering. Tobious pressed a cloth beneath his left eye and found blood still coming through.

"How many are still there?" he asked.

"I don't know," Ypin answered. "They're still there."

"And Panjios—"

He could not finish. He had wanted the older man to answer for the ninety-seven, then to live long enough to help the people under

Aras. Suss had taken the second possibility from him. That did not give Tobious back the first.

Edda opened a side entrance to the clinic. She looked at their wounds, then at the notices spreading above the street.

“Inside,” she said. “We can argue about who did what while I stop you bleeding.”

No More Names

On the first night after Panjios died, Tobious laid Severance on the floor between himself and Ypin.

The room belonged to a family in the lower service ward who knew Ypin from repairs. They had given them the narrow sleeping space behind their kitchen, two blankets, and a warning that Suss's search teams had already come through the adjacent street. Edda had sealed the cut beneath Tobious's left eye and dressed Ypin's forearm before sending them there by a side route. She had said the wound would scar. Tobious had not asked whether it matched the face he had once seen in the impossible opening.

At supper the family's youngest child asked why the visitors slept behind a curtain if they were not sick. Her father said some people were looking for them. The child considered the answer and asked whether those people would look in her room. Tobious wanted to tell her no. He could not. Her father said they had a rule for visitors: when someone knocked after dark, the children stayed with their grandmother and the adults answered together. It was not a guarantee. It was a household choosing how much of the danger it could bear, with its own children in the room.

Tobious thanked them and offered to leave. The grandmother pointed to the bowl she had set for him. "Eat first," she said. "Then ask me again in the morning when neither of us is trying to decide while hungry." He ate. They let him stay. No one called it safe.

"Take it," he said.

Ypin looked at the blade. Its pale edge caught a thin line of light from the kitchen. The opaque core remained whole. It could still do the work for which generations had kept it.

"Where?" Ypin asked.

"To Suss. Tell him I'll stand down if he gets Mariya and the others out."

"He has offered to take Mariya. He hasn't offered the others a safe route."

"He needs the reference. He might bargain."

"He needs you to agree to a cut. He cannot get that from me carrying a case into his office."

Tobious had known the answer. He wanted Ypin to refuse it aloud so he could hate the refusal instead of the hope that had made him ask.

"If I hold it again," he said, "someone else will pay."

"They may. You also left a spike unreported. Those are not the same sentence."

Tobious turned his head. The skin beneath his eye pulled against Edda's dressing. "You knew I was afraid of losing the release window."

"I did not know you had proof of a Storehouse draw in your own hand."

Ypin's voice had gone quiet. It was worse than shouting. He had abandoned the best routing trace to free Tobious under a falling rail, and now he sat across from a man who had kept an earlier trace because looking at it might interrupt a plan.

"You were with me after the shutter," Ypin said. "I asked whether the line returned to the artificial sink. You said Suss had requested confirmation. I thought you had shown me all you had."

"I let you think that."

Ypin turned the burned side of his arm away from the stove. "I cannot work with another version of that answer."

Tobious wanted to promise he would never hide anything again. The promise would be too large and too easy. "You can see the file now," he said. "Edda can copy it. Put my date beside it."

"I will."

Ypin did not move toward the sword. Tobious understood that letting the file be copied was the beginning of repair, not its reward.

"I should have told you," Tobious said.

"Yes."

"You still came back for me."

"You were under metal."

Neither of them used the act as payment for the other one's failure. Ypin wrapped his burned arm more tightly and went to the kitchen for water. Tobious left the blade where it lay until morning.

The next days did not have the shape of a decision. Tobious slept in short pieces. He woke reaching for the manual lever Panjios had held, then remembered the door had come down. Once he set out a third cup while the family shared their evening broth. He had brought a third cup to Ypin's table for weeks, expecting some colleague might visit. Now the empty cup made him think of the older man's habit of asking one more practical question before letting a lesson end.

The grandmother moved the extra cup to the drying shelf without asking whose place it marked. Later she brought it back filled with water when Ypin's dressing needed changing. Tobious watched her use the thing he had turned into a symbol. Panjios had been more than the man at the door and more than the man who signed the old closure. The cup could be used. It could not hold an answer from him.

He was angry at Panjios for dying before he could answer more of them. The anger did not keep him from missing him.

Edda visited through the back entrance. She examined the scar and made him follow her finger with his eyes. The left side of his vision remained clear. His right wrist had begun to shake when he held a tool too long; she could not yet say how much came from the bypass, exhaustion, or injury. She gave Ypin a different dressing for the forearm and told him the burn would slow fine work while it healed.

Outside, the Concord notices continued to name Tobious as the cause of the Day-57 failure. Some residents believed them. Others had been rescued at the cooling station and asked why the report said nothing about the people whose bodies had carried the root. Edda collected their statements. A statement was not a shield against a search team; it might become one part of an order the city could enforce.

The host came in one evening with a notice copied onto his work slate. A neighbor had asked whether keeping Tobious in the ward put the water line at risk. The neighbor had lost a brother to the skyway repairs years earlier and trusted Suss's command more than

a stranger from Aras. Tobious offered to speak to him. The host refused for now. The neighbor had asked a fair question about his family's exposure, and a confrontation on the doorstep would make the host answer it in public before he had chosen what to say.

"I told him you helped at the cooling shutter," Ypin said.

"Did you tell him about the spike?"

"I told him the investigation is incomplete. The dated file should be in Edda's hands, and when you testify, that part has to be yours to say."

Tobious could have asked Ypin to speak for him. He had already made the technician carry too much of his concealment. Some neighbors accepted the explanation. Others did not. The family kept the curtain closed at night.

On the third day, Tobious asked whether she knew how many captives remained.

"No verified count since Mariya's last delivered packet," she said. "Forty-seven then. We have a sign of a failed transmission after that, not its contents."

He had seen the Storehouse spike. He thought of Mariya recording an injury and receiving only a broken light. He did not say that she must be alive. He wanted to believe it without making Edda certify the wish.

"What would Suss do if I surrendered?"

"He would use your reference if he could persuade you. He would keep the ancient load until his infrastructure plan was secure. I have seen nothing that changes that."

"He can pull one person out."

"Possibly. Ask yourself whether you are offering him your cooperation or offering Mariya a choice she has already refused."

Edda did not tell him what he felt. She returned to the clinic. Tobious sat with the question until he could no longer make surrender sound like an act of mercy performed for someone else.

* * *

On Day Sixty-one, Ypin's host came home with a water pressure map. The manual reservoir above the service ward was losing flow

into a closed maintenance basin. Normal crews had been reassigned to root security, and searches made the access roads unreliable. Households at the lower end of the ward had begun saving drinking water in cooking pans.

Ypin spread the map on the kitchen table. "I can't lift the manual collar with this arm," he said. "You know what water does when a lower channel silts."

Tobious looked at Severance in its case. "The sword won't help."

"I didn't ask for it."

They went with the host and a reservoir worker who knew the basin's valves. The path was hot beside the service vents. People had set containers outside their doors; one child had written a name on each, so the neighbors would know whose water had been fetched. Tobious followed the pipe marks to the basin and found where a gate had not seated against its lower lip. The map showed an open return. The water was taking the easier path into the closed basin.

"Stop the upper feed," he said. "We'll clear the lip and reset the collar."

The reservoir worker held up a hand. "The upper feed cools two blocks. We can slow it. We cannot stop it long enough for you to climb inside."

Tobious had known a village sluice that tolerated a complete halt. This city did not. He asked for a diversion board. They found one in the service store, fitted it over part of the channel, and let water continue through the cooling line while the remaining flow dropped below the lip.

Ypin checked the powered indicators with his unburned hand. Tobious used his left to scrape packed mineral dust from the seating groove. The right hand shook when he tried to hold the collar. He had enough strength to lift it an inch, not enough to keep it there while the worker reached the latch.

"Set it down," she said. "Let me take that side."

He did. She took the load with a short bar, and he guided its angle from the water's movement. Ypin called the moment when the gauge matched the physical flow. The worker seated the latch. Water began to fill the lower ward line.

No one applauded. The host thanked the worker for making the access safe and went home to check the household containers. Tobious washed grit from his hands. At the first downstream tap, a boy filled a kettle without waiting for the pipe to cough air. He did not know Tobious had been there.

The water reached the houses before anyone thought to thank him. Tobious was glad it did not have to pass through his name.

* * *

On Day Sixty-two, Edda admitted Tobious and Ypin through the clinic's side door again. She had kept the medical records and the partial archive copies safe. She had also asked three service supervisors whether they would back a civil emergency review. One would testify to the interrupted loads. Another wanted a complete trace first. The third feared Suss's field authority and would say nothing.

"I can treat you here," Edda said. "I can preserve what you witnessed. I cannot ask marshals to seize a root hall while I have no release sequence for the captives and no backup for the ward's water and transit."

"We can build one," Tobious said.

"Then bring me the living count, a path a stretcher can take, and the load each cut moves. Tell me where these residents go while the root is severed. If any of those answers is missing, I will say so."

He looked at Ypin. The technician's burned arm rested across his lap. They had enough evidence to know the current arrangement was wrong. They did not yet have enough capacity to replace it without hurting people.

"Tomorrow," Tobious said. "I'll be at the planning room."

It was a small promise. He could keep it even if the next answer frightened him. Severance remained in its case at the shelter. He had not surrendered it to Suss, and he had not drawn it to make the room agree with him.

The Forty-Fifth Name

Nerissa read the roll while Mariya listened.

The first people answered quickly, relieved that they could. Farther down the list, voices came from the dry recess, the water line, the resting mats. One man lifted a hand because his throat had been raw since the last surge. Another answered for a woman who could not wake fully until he touched her shoulder. Nerissa waited for her own sign from each person instead of accepting the louder neighbor's word.

Mariya had made the list. For weeks she had read it herself, believing she could hear every omission before anyone else. Nerissa found two names whose marks had been transposed. Both people were alive. The correction felt like a rebuke and a relief.

When they came to the blank left where Pehl's name had been, his former work partner asked them not to close the space yet. "His daughter has not heard it from us," he said. Nerissa said the blank would stay on the casualty tablet, but the living roll needed its own clear order. The man agreed after Mariya promised that the next carrier would take a spoken account as well as the written mark. He did not ask them to pretend Pehl might answer. He wanted the record to reach the person who would most need it.

Hessah was near the end. She raised her hand from the rest area, then asked if that counted as an answer. Her voice still carried its dry humor, but standing made the skin around her mouth go white. She had spent many days repairing water skins with a strip torn from her hem. Now she could barely hold the needle.

"We need to test how you will be carried," Nerissa said. "May I examine your legs?"

Hessah nodded. She wanted her mother beside her, but she did not want her mother bearing the weight. She asked for the repaired water skin to stay with them. Its mouth had a red knot she could find by touch in the dark.

"It leaks less than the new ones," she said.

“I believe you,” Mariya answered.

They had forty-five people, including Mariya. The number did not tell them that only thirty-one could walk the passage without help, or that four of those needed a hand at every turn. It did not tell them which children would freeze when the Iwang clicked or who could lift a stretcher after two nights without sleep. They began putting those answers beside the names, with each person's knowledge and consent where they could get it.

The first proposed order put Hessah near the front. A man whose ankle had been injured during the surge objected that he could still walk with a stick and would be easier to move while the passage was clear. The carriers wanted to take both in the first group. Nerissa showed them the turn: two supported people could not pass the wide recess at once while a third waited under the active baffle. The man suggested he go later, but Hessah said he should not make a noble offer while his ankle was swelling. They tested his pace. He could manage a short distance, rest, then go again. He chose the second walking group with someone beside him. Hessah kept the stretcher place, not because her life weighed more, but because this route could bear her best there.

Hessah's mother wanted to carry her daughter herself. She was broad-shouldered and had carried water for their household all her life. Hessah watched her demonstrate a lift with an empty basket and then shook her head.

“You know how to carry me from bed to the wash place,” she said. “That stair is not our house. You'll have to watch the field for both of us.”

Her mother looked wounded by the refusal. Mariya knew the feeling. To help a loved person could seem like the one right that disaster should not take away. She asked Hessah whom she would trust under a stretcher. Hessah chose two of the younger carriers who had practiced together. She asked her mother to walk where she could speak to her, not where she would have to bear her weight.

Nerissa recorded the choice. When Hessah grew tired and could not answer a question, her mother would not be asked to guess whether she had changed her mind without a reason. Mariya

realized how often her earlier plans had said simply *move the weak* and left no place for a person to say who would touch them.

They tried the same question with others. One older man wanted his nephew beside him but said the nephew must not leave his wife alone at the far floor; a neighbor took that place. A woman who could walk if allowed to pause refused a stretcher that would keep her flat, where the old ceiling seemed to press down on her. They marked rest points for her instead. Each answer made the route more complicated. It also made it a route for these people rather than for forty-five interchangeable bodies.

Orran wanted to test the service recess. He had argued for sending strong people first. After Pehl and Annet died, he had stopped calling anyone weak when he meant frightened or ill. He came to Mariya with an offer that had a task attached.

"The lower brace can take a load if we wedge it before a release," he said. "I'll hold it while the stretchers turn."

"It may be the first place the field shifts," she said.

"I know. Show me where I'd stand. I want to know whether I can get away if it fails."

She did not praise him for volunteering. She showed him the sketch from the broken rope test and asked who would take over after one interval. Orran named two other stoneworkers. They tried the stance with an empty frame and found one could brace without blocking the path. If the field rose through the floor, they would abandon the brace and move back, even if that meant stopping a stretcher. Mariya wrote the limit down. He agreed to it.

The first route failed when they tried to turn the empty stretcher through a narrow passage. Its far handle struck the wall. A person lying on it would have scraped the active seam. Orran tried to angle it, then stopped before he forced it. They measured the wider recess again. It took longer to reach the safe stair and exposed the bearers to one extra baffle cycle, but it let a stretcher turn without bending the patient.

One of the proposed bearers objected to the wider route. The old wall there had held Thesia's broken ledge, and he had watched her fall. Orran made him put a hand on the new brace and feel which stones carried its weight. It was not a guarantee. The cracked lip that

had failed Thesia was beyond this turn. Mariya asked the bearer whether he would work the route after seeing it, not after being ordered to trust Orran. He agreed to one rehearsal. If the brace moved under his hand, he would call a stop and leave the stretcher on stable floor until it could be reassessed.

They rehearsed a full turn without a patient. Lios called the baffle count from the recess, too softly for the bearers to hear. He tried again, louder, and the guard at the hatch turned his head. Mariya stopped the exercise before they drew attention to it. They changed the signal to the raised cup they had already practiced. Nerissa would repeat it from the near side; nobody would shout across the active field. A small failure in a harmless rehearsal had saved them from making that mistake while carrying Hessah.

Afterward Lios asked whether they could paint the cup rim so a bearer would see it when the light shifted. They had no paint the guard would ignore. Annet had left a strip of dark cloth among the water skins. Hessah tied a short piece to the handle, where it moved when Lios lifted the cup but did not obscure its shape. They tried the signal from both ends of the recess. The adult backup could see it. Lios touched the knot once, remembering whose cloth it had been, and put the cup beneath the shelf until the next bell.

“Longer, then,” Mariya said.

“Longer with a person still on it,” Orran replied.

He returned the frame to Hessah's resting place. She asked the two proposed bearers to lift it while she lay on it for a single turn, so she could tell them where the jolts hurt. Nerissa objected that the test would exhaust her. Hessah said she would rather find the painful corner now, before a field was rising at their feet. They agreed to one lift. Hessah was right about the second corner. Mariya marked it on the route.

* * *

Darran's ration schedule gave them a gap they could predict. On the fourth bell of each cycle, his guard left the inner hatch to collect a new tray. The hatch itself remained locked. The interval would not

free anyone, but it would let them inspect the service panel's lower vent without a guard's eyes on their hands.

Mariya brought the idea to the distribution council before she asked Lios to watch the bell. One household representative said tampering with the panel would give Darran a reason to cut rations again if he found it disturbed. Orran said learning nothing about it would cost them a possible route for a stretcher. Both were making a claim about people who could not move quickly enough to hide from the consequences. Nerissa asked what they could learn through the vent now that could not wait until the outside team came.

"We can find the latch shape and sound the space behind it with a cord," Orran said. "We cannot open it without a tool. I do not want to discover on the day of release that the opening is narrower than the frame."

The representative asked that the cord be withdrawn and the vent left unmarked, and that a guard's approach end the test even if the work was unfinished. Mariya added a second person at the hatch to hear footsteps while Orran worked. They agreed. The decision did not make Darran harmless. It made the risk belong to the people who might pay for it.

Lios could hear the bell from the dry recess. Mariya offered him a task no adult needed to pretend was a heroic mission: raise his cup when the fourth bell sounded, then move away from the panel. Nerissa would watch the same bell from a second position if he was asleep, afraid, or unable to hear it. Lios practiced once and then asked whether he could refuse if the Iwang came close.

"Yes," Mariya said. "The signal matters. You matter more."

He considered this. "If I go to my aunt, tell her I didn't break this cup."

"You helped make it useful."

He turned it over in his hands, inspecting the smooth repaired rim.

On the following fourth bell Orran slipped a cord through the vent. He counted the knots that passed before its weighted end struck the inner wall. The space was deep enough for the stretcher's length but he could not tell how the door swung. He drew the cord back without scraping the edge. Mariya marked the unknown

direction on her sketch. The test had answered one question and left another that mattered just as much: a room could be wide enough and still useless if its door opened into the patient. They would need a way to study the latch before the rescue.

At the next powered diagnostic poll, the wafer lit. Mariya recorded the forty-five names in the order Nerissa had read them. She named Thesia, Pehl, and Annet as the three dead since the entrapment. She added Hessah's condition, the number who needed carrying, the width of the stretcher route, the baffle intervals, and the ration gap. The stored Day-56 surge warning followed. She described the double click and the pressure across bodies before the ordinary seam opened.

She sent the packet. A mark showed the relay had received it. A later, smaller mark showed it had reached the Veyr dispatch side. There was no reply explaining what Tobious would do or when. She told the others exactly what the two marks meant.

Nerissa stayed beside her after they returned to the rest area. "You have stopped giving them a day you cannot know," she said.

"I wanted the day to be true."

"So did they."

Mariya looked at the empty stretcher. The wider route was ready enough to describe. It was not safe until someone could release the field and keep the Iwang from using the seam. The outside team would need to hear how much of the plan belonged to people inside, and how much they still had to invent.

"I'm frightened," she said.

Nerissa did not give her an assignment to cover the confession. She sat beside her and shared the last of a cup of water. Mariya accepted it. For the first time in days, she let someone else read the roll at night while she slept.

What Remains of an Oath

Mariya's packet arrived with forty-five living names.

Tobious read the three deaths after the names of the living, as she had arranged them. Thesia had died in the first test, Pehl during the surge, Annet after it. He did not look at Ypin when the Day-56 warning played. Its double click and field pressure matched the Storehouse signature he had kept on his private device. He had spent days calling that trace incomplete. Mariya had been recording what it did to bodies while he waited for a second test.

He listened again to the count, this time without the recording. Ypin set the wafer down and read each name aloud. Tobious stopped him at Hessah, whose condition required a stretcher, and at Orran, who had offered to hold a failing brace. They were no longer a number at the bottom of a rescue calculation. He wrote their tasks in the margin of the route sketch. Beside three other names there were no tasks to write. He had seen the warning that might have spared them, and he had hidden it because reporting it would have ended his place beside the door.

"If I take this to Edda," Ypin said, "she has to know when you first saw it."

"She will."

"I am not asking for a brave answer. I am asking because I put my hand on that coupling after you told me the trace was unresolved."

Tobious remembered how readily Ypin had trusted him with the bench. He had been grateful for that trust while keeping the one piece of evidence most likely to change Ypin's judgment. "I should have told you before you touched it," he said.

Ypin did not forgive him. He copied the dated trace and sealed it beside his own calibration log, where neither of them could alter the sequence without leaving a mark. Then they went to the clinic.

At Edda's clinic meeting room, he placed the device beside the authenticated archive copies.

“I saw the spike after the cooling shutter rescue,” he said. “I didn't report it. I signed the next operation anyway.”

Edda asked him to give the exact date and who had seen the line. Ypin confirmed he had asked for the full route and Tobious had delayed filing it. The two cooling-station workers who had survived the shutter failure had already given statements about field heat and Suss's command decisions. A third worker from the Day-57 escape described Panjios holding the isolation door and Suss striking him. Edda collected each account separately. She did not ask them to agree on details they could not all have seen.

One of the cooling-station workers had lost two fingers when the shutter dropped. He used his good hand to turn the route display toward Tobious. “You can say the pressure was here. I can say I felt it before the field rose. Neither of us saw who moved that gate.”

“Suss gave the command,” Tobious said.

“Did you hear him?” Edda asked.

“No. I saw the authorization on the console afterward.”

She separated those two facts in her notes. Tobious had wanted the injured man to strengthen his case. Instead the man was making the case strong enough to survive someone trying to break it. Panjios's death did not become more true when Tobious claimed knowledge he did not have.

Edda replayed a portion of the testimony from the Day-57 worker. The worker knew the sound of Suss's strike, because he had been at the isolation door. He did not know whether Panjios was still conscious after it. Tobious closed his eyes. There were hours of that day he had wanted to fill with certainty, as if certainty could give Panjios a better ending. Edda let the recording finish without asking him to make one.

“This supports a casualty review and an order to preserve service access,” she said. “It does not give me a power to convict a field commander in this room.”

“If we wait for a tribunal, the root fails on Day Eighty-four,” Tobious said.

“Then give the review an emergency plan that can be acted on now.”

She issued a request to the civil marshals for independent access at the Root Hall, medical records held outside Concord command, and protection for essential service crews. Three marshals agreed to take the order. One operations supervisor refused to sign without a complete routing trace. Another would corroborate the local load data but would not confront Suss at his post. Jorra and Sennos agreed to support a rescue after reviewing the names and the route; they remained Wardens responsible for everyone at the sites, not soldiers belonging to Tobious.

The first marshal to arrive carried a narrow slate of emergency powers. He read it to Edda before he read her request. He could keep a corridor open for inspection; he could not disarm a commander without an active threat witnessed at the site. He could secure clinic records; he could not promise that the Root Hall would obey a finding issued after the root had already failed.

“Then come while there is still a root,” Edda said.

He signed for the corridor. The second and third signed for the records and the service crews. None signed for Tobious. When they left, Edda made three copies of their orders and sent one by a route Suss did not control. She had seen too many emergency permissions vanish into an office where the emergency had been caused.

Jorra studied the ancient stretcher sketch before accepting her part. “If the cut happens here, who covers the patient while the blade settles?”

“Sennos,” Tobious said.

“He cannot cover the patient and the person making the cut. We need a second stand or a different waiting place.”

“Then help us find one.”

“I will. But I am not putting my name on a plan that assumes my shield can be in two places.”

She wrote *conditional* beside her signature. It was the first honest word on the page.

The coalition did not become a crowd chanting for justice. It became a list of people who had agreed to particular work, and of people who had not.

* * *

On Ypin's bench, they built a model with three stones for the ancient accesses and a fourth for the root in Veyr. Tobious brought Mariya's sketch of the ninth step and the stretcher turn. The difference between the narrow passage and the wider recess was the width of a person's shoulders when lying down. It decided whether the weak could leave with everyone else.

Ypin laid the load traces beside Edda's independent injury record. Since the Day-57 breach, the root had oscillated in broad surges. Every trough between them was shorter than the one before. They tested the known baffle clicks against those troughs. A low-load interval would reach the Storehouse on Days Eighty-two and Eighty-three. Before then, cutting more than one tether would push the strain through the people still inside. After that interval, the next rise would become terminal on Day Eighty-four.

"This is Schlelberg in the inhabited volumes now," Ypin said. "Not only a seam in one chamber. The pressure peaks under their floor and under our service ward. Each side has begun to feel the other's failing support."

Edda drew a line from the future clinic injuries to Mariya's baffle times. It did not turn the two places into one place. It showed that a person could be harmed in either without knowing whose demand had reached them through the root.

Ypin made them watch the traces at the speed the machine had recorded them. At first Tobious saw only two lines swelling and falling. Then Ypin placed Mariya's account beneath the display: the double click, the pause in which voices disappeared, the moment Pehl fell. On the next rise the root line climbed a fraction before the Storehouse line did. The people under the village had felt the future's demand before anyone in Veyr saw an alarm.

Edda asked Ypin to run a single-release projection. A white mark left the ancient branch. For a breath the other marks stayed level. Then each remaining mark rose. The effect was small enough on the screen that Tobious could imagine someone calling it tolerable. Edda put the injury record beside it. Annet's pulse had failed during a smaller rise.

“That model doesn't tell us which person carries the extra strain,” she said. “It tells us we cannot choose a number and call the rest a rounding error.”

Ypin reset the projection. He was too careful with his hands for Tobious to miss how angry he was.

“Why can't we take five a day?” Tobious asked.

“We can take an individual if we place the rest of the load somewhere,” Ypin said. “Suss's offer to take Mariya was physically possible. The remaining people would pay for each early release. Five a day would keep raising that cost.”

He marked the already tested limited extraction. Its sink could buffer one person briefly; it was not a shelter for forty-five. Tobious had wanted to call it a lie because it was cruel. Seeing its real capacity made the cruelty clearer.

“If Mariya had come out when Suss offered,” Tobious said, “would the surge have killed someone?”

“I can't name the person or promise death,” Ypin said. “I can say the pressure would have risen in every remaining tether, and Suss knew he had not built a sink for them.”

There was a kind of mercy in a precise answer, even when it withheld absolution. Mariya had refused without possessing the model. She had trusted what the floor told her about the bodies beside her. Tobious had possessed a model and once used its uncertainty as a place to hide.

Edda moved the future-city layer over the root. “If we destroy this now, the captives' floor collapses and these service blocks lose cooling before they can be transferred to independent supply.”

Tobious touched the map near the old west drain. “The wider recess will flood if the Storehouse branch redirects water when the tethers release. We can divert the old channel first.”

“Can you do it from Veyr?” Ypin asked.

“No. Samon and the village crew know that stone better than my diagram.”

The plan acquired people as it grew. Ancient workers would brace the recess and clear the drain. Mariya's group would stage stretchers, signal baffle intervals, and name who could move. Jorra and Sennos would protect the corridor. Tobious would cut

sequentially under cover, waiting for the core to settle instead of using the higher gain. Ypin would manage the future-side load and relay. Edda would prepare clinics, water reserves, and housing for the city if its root services went dark. None of those pieces could stand alone.

They found a shorter route on the model. It would have sent the return load through the occupied lower service ward in Veyr for one hour. Tobious knew the residents there: Ypin's host, the child who had written names on water containers, the families who had waited beside a broken reservoir. The shortcut would make the ancient release easier by treating those homes as a sink.

Edda called the ward's water steward on an open line. She asked which lines could be isolated and which could not. The steward went room by room. A clinic's cold store would lose its medicines first. Two upper floors could be moved if given a day's notice. In the lower rooms, people had brought their containers back after the reservoir repair and begun filling them because they had been told the danger was over. The steward did not know why Edda was asking.

"Are you shutting us down again?" he said.

"We are considering a route that would put heat into your block. I am checking what it would touch."

"You can check from there. We would have to live inside the answer."

Edda thanked him and ended the call. Tobious did not ask her to soften what the steward had said.

"No," he said. "We don't do that."

Ypin turned the model to show the longer path. It required one more holding interval and additional manual cover. Edda asked how many residents the shorter line would have exposed. Ypin gave the estimate. She wrote the rejected option into the meeting record so that no one could later pretend it had never been considered.

* * *

The terminal function had been listed in Severance's calibration record since Day Eighteen. Tobious knew it could destroy the root

reference. He had not known what a complete evacuation would leave him time to do.

Ypin put seven tokens on the bench for the uninterrupted idle days needed to transfer the living reference. The captives would remain tethered until the low-load interval. The last stretcher could leave late on Day Eighty-three. The root would need to be cut by Day Eighty-four. There was no week between those events, and no fourth access hidden in a map. When the root's mineral reference was consumed, Storehouse, Salt, and Quarry would all go dark.

Tobious tried moving the first token to a day before the rescue. Ypin removed it. A living receiver would still be under Aras. Tobious tried transferring the reference during the two quiet hours they expected after each baffle cycle. Ypin slid all seven tokens back to the beginning; the idle count restarted whenever the field took a body into its load. They repeated the exercise until Tobious stopped searching for an arrangement of stones that would let him keep both sides of the door.

"Let me see the terminal record," Edda said.

Ypin projected the old calibration. It recorded a complete cut only at the root seam. The operator had to keep contact while the reference consumed the core. The warning did not say *death*. It listed field burns, loss of hand function, and failure of the cut if contact broke early. Tobious read the failure line twice. Dying would not make the fifteen heartbeats count if his grip slipped at the ninth.

Jorra asked whether another person could brace him. Ypin said a second body at the seam would become another path for the load. A shield could cover the approach, but the final contact had to be his. Edda wrote that distinction into the medical plan. They could prepare for an injured survivor; they could not pretend his fear was irrelevant to the procedure.

"I have to be at the seam in Veyr," Tobious said.

"Yes," Ypin answered. "Fifteen continuous heartbeats. Your live contact. The core is spent with the root."

He looked at the ancient side of the map. He could cross back to Aras for the rescue, but to finish it he would have to return to Veyr. After the cut he would still be here, if he lived. Mariya could cross before closure if she chose. There was no rule making her remain in

Aras. That decision would belong to her, not to the sword or to an official count.

"Tell her every part," he said. "The risk to the city, the last crossing, the fact that she can come here."

"We'll send the complete proposal on the next diagnostic window," Ypin said.

Tobious dictated his section of the message without looking at Ypin's script. He named the three accesses and the time by which they would fail. He named the seven idle days they did not have. When he reached Mariya's crossing, he began, *If you can bear leaving Aras*— and stopped. It turned her choice into a test of what she could endure for him. He started again.

"You can cross before the closure. There is room for you here. I want you here. If you choose to stay, I will still make the cut."

He asked Ypin to keep the first recording only as a discarded draft. The corrected one belonged in the packet. His own desire could be plain without becoming another tether.

Edda studied him. "Are you agreeing to stay because you think guilt gives us your life?"

"I'm agreeing because I am the current reference and we don't have seven days to move it. I don't want to die. I want the people out first."

She nodded, not as a blessing but as confirmation that he had heard the terms.

Tobious assigned the first tasks aloud. Jorra challenged the distance between the shield stand and the stretcher turn. He let her move it. Edda demanded a second medical team. Ypin asked who could stop a cut if the ancient count failed. Tobious said Mariya and Nerissa could, from inside, and Jorra from the cover line. He put their names beside that authority.

He had once thought leadership meant being the person no one could stop. The plan became safer when he gave several people the right to tell him to wait.

Edda copied the stop signals onto three separate slates. One would go with the future cover team, one to the ancient receiver, and one to the clinic. They did not know whether any single line would survive the final surge. Outside the meeting room the city continued

its shift change. A food porter asked when the lower ward would have its cooling restored; a patient asked whether the new shelter would take her father. Edda answered both before returning to the map. The rescue had not yet begun, and already it belonged to people beyond the room.

The People in the Plan

The first rescue failed in a room with no captives.

Ypin had marked the floor with tape for the annex walls, the ninth stair, and the wider service recess. Weighted frames stood in for those who could not walk. Jorra and Sennos brought shield stands; Edda brought two stretcher teams who knew what a body did when frightened, weak, or unconscious. Tobious set Severance's inert practice counterpart beside the painted branch line and waited for Mariya's recorded three-click interval.

Before they began, Edda asked one of the carriers to lie on a frame. He had carried patients through a tower fire and thought he knew how to remain still. When the bearers lifted him, he caught the edge with his hand at the first sway. Their plan had no place for that hand. It would be inside the active field.

"Again," he said, embarrassed.

"After we change the hold," Edda told him. "In the annex, frightened people will reach for what they can touch. We design for the hand."

They wrapped a second strap where a patient could grip it. Tobious thought of Hessah, who had asked for the water skin with the red knot. He had written *personal item* in the margin. Now he moved it into the center of her carry plan. It could give her hands somewhere to go; if she could not hold it, her mother could walk where she could hear her voice.

The first release went well. The second started before the blade's core would have settled in a live operation. In the simulation, Sennos had to keep an exposed passage covered while the first stretcher turned. When Jorra moved to protect the cut, the stretcher lost its shield. The people assigned as bearers stopped rather than pretending the error could be survived by moving faster.

"I'll take the next cut alone," Tobious said. "Then Jorra can stay with them."

Ypin shook his head. "The blade still needs thirty seconds. Taking it alone removes your cover without changing the clock."

"I can use the high gain once."

"No. We built this plan because that setting moved the cost to people under Aras. We don't call it safe because the danger makes waiting unpleasant."

Tobious felt the room turn toward him. He had made the failed intervention, hidden the spike, and then come here to lead an evacuation. He could defend his suggestion until everyone was weary enough to agree. He put down the practice grip.

"Ypin is right," he said. "The first sequence fails. Show me the holding space."

Jorra moved the first stretcher into a dry recess wide enough for two bearers to wait. Sennos shifted a shield stand so its field reached both the exit and the recess for a short interval. The new route asked one group to pause while the core settled, then move on Jorra's signal. It also required someone inside the annex to tell them whether the corridor was actually clear. Lios's proposed cup signal would be backed by Nerissa. A child would not be the only point at which forty-five lives depended.

They ran it again. One weighted frame would not turn. Edda's bearer said the person on it would be scraped along the wall. Tobious had used Mariya's measured width correctly and forgotten that a stretcher needed room for the hands carrying it. They changed the grip, not the person. In the third run, both frames cleared without a shield-down interval on the exit.

They did not call the third run a success until the carrier on the frame tried to rise halfway through it. The bearers lowered him at the marked recess. Sennos held cover while Jorra used the stop signal, palm open beside her shield. Tobious kept the practice blade still. Ypin's timer counted thirty seconds before allowing another cut. By then the carrier had sat up and apologized.

"Don't," Jorra said. "That is the first thing someone there will do when they see daylight."

The carrier lay down again, but he left one leg outside the strap to imitate a patient who could not bear pressure on a wound. It changed the turn once more. They shifted the inner bearer half a

pace back and tested whether the frame still cleared. In the real passage, half a pace would put a boot close to the ninth step. Sennos marked the floor and made Tobious walk it with the shielding hum at his shoulder. A mistake had become a distance his body could remember.

At the end, Edda asked who could halt a cut. Tobious named Jorra, Mariya, Nerissa, and the person nearest the branch if the floor moved unexpectedly. Ypin added the future-side load monitor. The right to stop became an actual signal each would recognize. Without it, consent would be a sentence in a meeting note.

They recorded water, carriers, counts, and exits beside each stage. The list made the rescue look less like a heroic charge. It made it possible to practice.

* * *

Future residents had to leave their homes before they knew whether Tobious could save the ancient ones.

Edda's civil order moved the households nearest the root's exposed service blocks into temporary rooms above the lower ward. Reservoir workers transferred cooling to conventional power; food-tower crews prepared for harvest loss if the root supply failed. Nothing about the move was effortless. A woman who sold greens from her window asked who would pay for the days she could not open. An older man refused to leave a room whose stairs he could manage because the temporary shelter's lift failed too often. Edda's team found him another place instead of calling him unreasonable.

Tobious carried crates with the evacuation workers. His right hand was not steady enough for the full weight, so he took the light end and let someone else guide the heavy one. The woman with the greens recognized him from the Concord notice.

The temporary rooms had clear walls that could turn opaque when a family wanted privacy. A boy kept pressing the control until his grandmother asked him to leave one side transparent. She wanted to see the harbor. From this height, the water appeared to pass beneath the suspended gardens, though Tobious had learned that the gardens rode on service ribs strong enough to hold entire

markets. Their beauty depended on a great deal of hidden labor. A kitchen worker was carrying hot grain cakes down the hall. He had been sent to a shelter where half the arriving families would not know how to reach a food station; he handed out the first cakes before he unfolded his official list.

Tobious took one when the worker offered it. It tasted of pepper and a leaf he could not name. For a moment he was simply hungry in a city where someone had cooked too much on purpose. He wondered whether Mariya would have liked the sharpness. Then he saw a young woman at the next door measuring her mother's medicine against the light. The cooling delay could spoil it. Edda's clinic had promised a powered container, but the delivery had not reached this floor. Tobious carried the request down to the service team and waited until a worker brought the container up. When he returned, the grain cake had gone cold in his hand.

"You brought this trouble from your village," she said.

"The root was here before I was."

"You're the one asking me to go."

"Yes."

She waited for the rest of his defense. He had one he could have given: the names under Aras, the false counts, Suss's purge. They were true. They would not make her shelf of cut greens keep fresh in a borrowed room.

"The shutdown will interrupt this tier," he said. "Edda's team will record the loss and arrange food access. I can't promise it will be repaid quickly."

"Then carry the boxes without pretending that is payment."

He did. Before they left, she showed a younger worker which plants would survive the move and which should be given away now. Tobious took two bundles to a neighbor. The woman did not thank him. She did not owe him gratitude for asking her to bear a real cost.

At the access checkpoint, three civic marshals arrived under Edda's issued review order. Their warrant preserved passage for medical and inspection crews. It did not give Tobious command of Root Hall or dissolve the Warden chain. Suss's staff challenged the order at the gate; the marshals held their ground while Edda's registrar produced the casualty certificates. Each person on either

side could see whose authority they were invoking. The city had begun to divide openly over a policy that had once been hidden in a column.

The senior marshal did not wave them through. She asked Edda to name every person who needed access and the work each would perform. Tobious's name drew the longest pause. Suss's notice called him a compromised operator; Edda's certificate called him the only current reference. Both descriptions could be true. The marshal entered them together and issued a guarded passage permit, valid only while an independent witness watched the coupling. Tobious signed beneath it.

"If Suss challenges this in court?" he asked.

"Then he challenges the order in public," she said. "That is one of the things it is for."

* * *

Ypin's legitimate maintenance feed showed a new pattern on Day Seventy-two. Suss had moved energy toward the terminal control junction while ordering ancient receiver rations restricted to approved crews. The reduced food to Aras would weaken the captives before the release window. The same route could arm a one-sided purge of the ancient volume while preserving the future root.

Edda took the ration order to the civil supply office. Its clerk had never seen the inside of the ancient annex. He could see, however, that the order removed food from a registered service site without naming an alternative delivery. He refused to suspend a Warden command on Tobious's account alone. He asked for the captive roll.

Mariya's packet was there, with forty-five names and the injured marked for carrying. The clerk read the first page without speaking. Then he compared it with Suss's supply ledger, which still called the same people *unprotected load*. He stamped a limited continuation of water and food under emergency care rules. It would last until the review, not until everyone was safe. Edda thanked him for exactly what he had done, and sent a copy of his stamped order to the carrier network before the route could close.

Outside, Tobious asked whether Suss would obey.

“He may obey the paper and starve them by delay,” Edda said. “That is why we still need the workers who move the food.”

They found two dispatchers willing to mark departures and arrivals separately. One would not sign a public statement. The other said he would, if his shift partner's family could be moved out of the exposed ward first. Tobious had once imagined that evidence would unlock a door. It was beginning to look more like carrying water: necessary, heavy, and lost if no one stayed to watch the vessel.

“He knows we are preparing to sever it,” Ypin said.

“Can he fire the purge now?” Tobious asked.

“Not cleanly. He still needs your coupling for precise work, or he must let the field build until an uncontrolled stabilization takes its place. Either way he risks the root he wants to keep.”

Suss had not become careless because his opponents had found witnesses. He was preparing a second choice for the city to accept if the rescue failed: destroy the ancient site, keep the useful infrastructure, call the loss an emergency. The calculation would include Aras as terrain, not as households.

Jorra listened to the feed with her jaw set. She had served under Suss long enough to know when an order contained a fallback he had not yet named. “He will call the purge mercy,” she said. “He'll say a clean end was kinder than a failing floor.”

“Would it be?” Tobious asked. He did not mean to provoke her. He needed to know whether some part of that claim still held her.

“For someone watching a graph, perhaps. Not for a person still asking for water beneath it.” She pointed to the ration restriction. “This is how you make your graph look desperate enough to justify what you already want.”

She gave Edda her copy of the order. It bore the command mark that she had once used without question. Her hand stayed on the edge until Edda took it. Sennos did not tell her the choice erased the years she had served. He took over her watch at the gate so she could go to the families moved from the lower ward and explain what their protective barrier could actually do.

The coalition could not enter the Storehouse safely before the low-load trough on Days Eighty-two and Eighty-three. They used the intervening days to position stretchers, verify shelter with Mariya's carriers, rehearse baffle signals, and enforce the civil access order. Ypin sent the complete proposal on the next diagnostic window: the cut sequence, the medical limit, the Day-84 closure, and the fact that Mariya could cross to Veyr if she chose before the root was consumed.

Tobious listened to the packet once before it left. He had asked that her options be named plainly. He heard no request that she prove she loved him by selecting one. The relay accepted the message. Whether she would accept any part of the plan remained for her to say.

The Road to Aras

The message from Veyr took nearly the whole diagnostic window to play.

Mariya listened once with Nerissa, Orran, and two other council members beside her. Ypin's voice named the low-load interval on Days Eighty-two and Eighty-three. Jorra's voice described cover at the wider service recess. Edda gave the number of people a stretcher team could carry before changing bearers. Tobious spoke last. He said the final cut would destroy the root, every ancient access with it, and the material in Severance's core. He would have to make that cut in Veyr on Day Eighty-four. Once it was done, he could not come back.

Mariya asked the wafer to replay that part. It did. The last words were no softer the second time.

"Can he change the reference before then?" she asked into the relay.

Ypin's recorded answer followed, anticipating the question: seven uninterrupted idle days with all receivers quiet. The captives could not safely be released before the trough. Once they were out, only hours remained. There would be no time to transfer the reference.

"Can I cross?" she asked during the brief live return channel.

Ypin answered at once. "Yes. You can come to Veyr through Salt before the closure if you choose. It is not the machine that keeps you in Aras."

The line went quiet as the window ended. Mariya looked at the people waiting around her. The release sequence mattered to all of them; her future residence did not need to be decided in front of forty-five frightened people. She told the council she accepted the proposed rescue in principle and wanted one day to consider her own crossing. Nerissa took the wafer and began repeating the practical sections for those who had missed a word.

Orran asked why the cut began at the far branch instead of the one nearest the door. Nerissa found the passage in Ypin's recording:

beginning near the door would leave the stretchers farther in carrying the released load. Hessah asked where a person would wait if the first shield failed. Jorra had marked the dry recess; Mariya showed it on the sketch and admitted that no shield would make the passage harmless. A woman whose brother had been one of the twelve already freed asked whether the outside team had told those twelve to remain beyond the old watercourse. They had. Their safety was one reason the returning workers could not use the fastest approach.

The council did not vote as if fear could be made unanimous. They named the people who could not be moved without a stretcher, the volunteers who wanted to remain last, and the conditions under which Mariya or Nerissa would halt the cut. One young carrier wanted the group to wait for a route with no Iwang at all. Mariya let him finish. Then she showed him the narrowing trough and asked him to help choose a real waiting place for the first stretcher. He did, still afraid. She was relieved he had not pretended otherwise.

Later, in the dry recess, Mariya sat beside Nerissa with Hessah's repaired water skin between them. She tried to imagine Veyr without making it only Tobious's city. He had described towers where food grew in controlled beds, streets hanging above the bay, a clinic that could see bones without cutting skin. There would be work there. She might learn to read the fast-changing signs; she might use what she knew of stores to help people whose systems had different names for hunger. She might walk beside Tobious at dusk and not hear the baffle click through a wall.

She imagined a morning in a room no neighbor knew. Tobious would go to work and she would buy food under a roof that had never held a harvest. She could ask questions without someone saying what her mother would have done. She could be foolish in public and not be measured against the girl who once miscounted a wedding store. That freedom drew her almost as much as the thought of sleeping beside him. It frightened her because it was hers. No one had ordered her to want it.

Then she imagined the shore road after rain, the brown runnels meeting the tide. She had argued with Orran at that road over whose stones held the wall; she had once carried a sick child along it while

Nerissa came from the other direction. She wanted a life in which those memories were neither a chain nor a relic. The village could change while she remained in it. If she left, it would change without her, and she might still be happy elsewhere. Both lives had a cost. She would not tell herself that only one of them was honest.

“I could want that life,” she said.

“Of course you could,” Nerissa answered.

“If I stay, people will say I was needed here.”

“You are. So are other people. We have begun to prove that.”

Mariya looked toward the narrow line of daylight at the far stair. Beyond it lay the sea she had known since childhood, a mill that annoyed her, houses whose people remembered her mistakes as clearly as her help. Staying would not restore the old Aras. She did not want the old Aras back in full; it had been possible for a widow to vanish from its food list before any Telassari scribe arrived. She wanted to help make a different home on the same shore.

“Then I will choose it because I want to live there,” she said, “not because you would all fail without me.”

Nerissa adjusted the water skin's red knot. “Tell Tobious that part yourself.”

“He might offer me a place again.”

“He probably will.”

“I want him to.” Mariya stared at the knot. “I want to know the offer is real, even if I refuse it.”

Nerissa gave the water skin back to Hessah's mother when she came to fetch it. Neither woman asked Mariya to decide faster. At the ration bell, Mariya went with the others and took her share. She had made choices while hungry before. This one deserved to be made after she ate.

* * *

Darran's new ration order reached the annex the next morning. Food would enter only with approved technicians. The weak would receive it last because, he said, the walking workers had to remain productive. Mariya showed the guard the last recorded meal tally and the discrepancies Darran had not corrected. If the count he

submitted to Therren was examined, the missing portions would point to his supervision. He could keep the ration hatch narrow; he could not make the figures disappear.

He had brought a clerk to witness the new order. The clerk looked from Darran's seal to Mariya's tally and tried to hold both slates without touching the damp wall. "The living count is forty-five?" he asked.

"Yes," Mariya said.

"The delivery list is thirty-eight."

Darran took back his slate. "Some are not assigned to work."

"People who cannot lift stone still drink," Nerissa said. She stood behind Mariya with a water vessel that was empty enough for the clerk to hear it.

The clerk did not endorse Mariya's larger claim. He wrote the discrepancy and made Darran initial it. That small mark changed Darran's face. He could threaten the annex in private; he could not now claim he had never been shown how many mouths his order had omitted.

"What do you want?" Darran asked.

"A supervised water transfer. We have people who cannot carry it from the inner hatch. Let Orran and two others bring it through the service panel."

"The panel isn't for laborers."

"Then send your guard to watch them. The people you need alive will drink."

He allowed one transfer, intending to keep the workers visible. During it, Orran pressed wax against the ordinary latch beneath the panel. Mariya stood between him and the guard, arguing over the volume of water, a dispute both men expected from her. Orran withdrew the wax impression under his thumb. Later a stoneworker outside would copy the simple shape into a service tool. It would open one panel. It would not undo the temporal tethers or replace Severance.

The first vessel struck the frame as Orran lifted it through. A bead of wax slid toward the guard's boot. Orran caught it with the wet edge of his thumb before it fell. Mariya raised the empty vessel and demanded the rest of the allotted water. The guard turned to Darran

for the number; Darran had to consult the clerk's altered slate. In that brief quarrel Orran pressed the impression into a fold of cloth and passed it to a bearer on the near side. No one opened the panel again. Their advantage depended on a single use, and Mariya could already feel how easily it might have been lost for the sake of one careless lift.

Lios watched the ration bell from the dry recess. He raised his cup on the fourth strike, then lowered it when Nerissa raised a hand beside him. The adult backup heard the same bell. They had given him a part that mattered and an exit from it if fear or noise made him miss the cue.

Darran counted the empty water vessels before leaving. He noticed nothing changed in the panel. Mariya knew he would tighten inspections if the copied latch appeared. The advantage would need to be used once, at the trough, not practiced until he learned it.

* * *

The carrier network answered through a fisherman who had permission to bring salt to the outer store. He could not pass a letter to the captives, so he repeated what the neighboring households had agreed. Several villages would withhold harbor transport and grain carts unless Therren reduced the seasonal levy, released ordinary labor detainees, and withdrew his men from Aras's houses to the ridge. They would not attack the citadel. Their leverage was the work his soldiers needed to keep a district fed and supplied.

The fisherman had no promise that all the carriers would hold. One headman had a son in a Telassari work camp and feared what a transport stoppage would do to him. Another had agreed to stop grain carts only after the current loads reached a hospital. Mariya asked the fisherman to repeat those limits as carefully as the demands. A coalition that lied about its own edges would fail the first time Therren pressed on one.

"Do they know about the people below?" she asked.

"They know some. They ask whether your list can be copied."

She gave him the roll with the living named first and the dead afterward. She included the twelve freed earlier, in a separate

column, so the number of captives could not be inflated by treating them as still trapped. A household whose daughter was among the twelve would know the difference. The fisherman read the marks once and tucked the roll under the false bottom of his salt basket. He had carried news before. This time he asked Mariya to say the names aloud so he would remember them if the paper were found.

Mariya sent back a count that could be checked: the captives still alive, the dead named separately, and the households whose workers had been taken. She asked the carriers to speak to Therren with those households present if the negotiation could be arranged. A victory announced by one courier would be another count no one else could inspect.

She also sent a message to Tobious. She supported the rescue and wanted a private moment with him after the last person was safe, if time allowed. She intended to remain in her own era. She would not ask him to leave the root unfinished, and she did not want him to describe her choice as a duty that proved her love.

Nerissa took the store list from her hands when the wafer confirmed delivery. "I will manage tomorrow's portions," she said. "You can help. You do not have to be the only one who knows where everything is."

Mariya let her take it. The surrender felt strange. It made space for a choice she could claim as a person rather than as the last support of a failing room.

A Gate for Everyone

On Day Eighty-two, the Salt Gate opened onto sea air Tobious knew.

He stepped through after Jorra and before Sennos. Ypin remained at the future controls. His voice reached them through a narrow paired relay, its window measured in minutes. Edda's emergency crew held the Veyr side under the civil access order; the marshals there could keep a corridor open, not win a battle on the ancient shore. The three of them carried shields and blades. Tobious also carried the old knowledge of where the path flooded when the tide turned.

From the salt cave to Aras, the fields looked smaller than he remembered and the ridges steeper. It was the same landscape. He had been living among its future bones long enough to misjudge the distance between an olive tree and a wall. Jorra kept her shield faint around the group, ready but not wasting charge. Sennos checked the stretcher straps brought through in bundles.

On the first terrace a boy was gathering fallen olives into a reed tray. He froze at the sight of the shields. Tobious recognized him only after the boy turned; his father had shared a wall with Tobious's family. Eighty-two days had sharpened his face. The boy set down the tray and ran toward the village, not to announce a hero but to warn the households that armed strangers had come from the cave.

The harvest had been taken in measures too small to empty the fields, enough to leave the trees tended and the people short. Tobious saw the occupation in the cleared threshing place where carts waited under a Telassari seal, in the repairs made to the well with a kind of stone Aras had never chosen, and in the road kept smooth for a tax wagon while the footpath to the houses washed away. He had wanted to return with a sword powerful enough to make the village whole. The village had spent his absence surviving in particular ways he had not been there to learn.

Therren's soldiers met them above the shore path. The captain stood behind six spears and a hide shield, his red cloak dusty at the hem. One of his men pointed at Severance's case.

"No armed party enters Aras," Therren said.

"Your surveyor has forty-five people under the old storehouse," Tobious answered. "We have a route to bring them out."

"Darran says moving them destroys the works."

"It will end his commission."

The captain's eyes narrowed. Tobious did not ask him to become kind. He had another kind of pressure behind him: coastal carriers waiting at the harbor with loaded carts, unwilling to move them until the village laborers were released. The captain's own soldiers needed the road kept open. Some had been sent to work the Receiver and knew Darran had concealed what was below.

One of those soldiers said, "My cousin was sent down there with a water crew. Darran says he was transferred."

Therren turned to him. "You will speak when asked."

The soldier lowered his gaze but did not withdraw the question. Tobious did not know whether the cousin was among the forty-five. He would not claim the man was alive to buy passage. "Mariya has a roll," he said. "If you let the crews out, you can ask her."

Behind the spears, a second soldier shifted his feet. The line Therren commanded was not one mind. Some feared the field shields, some feared losing their posts, and at least one wanted a name more than he wanted an order. Tobious kept Severance in its case. Drawing it would tell all six men that their only choice was to fight or yield.

One soldier advanced to block the path. Tobious lifted his field, and the spear point met a force it could not pierce. He did not draw Severance. He stepped sideways, leaving the man room to retreat without being thrown. Jorra and Sennos held position behind him, shielding the medical supplies.

"I can hurt your men," Tobious told Therren. "I don't need to, and you need them to keep the ridge. Let us pass for the people Darran calls his workers."

The captain looked toward the harbor. A carrier woman spoke from beside her cart: "If he stops them, we unload here. The ridge can feed itself."

Therren knew the threat was imperfect; the villages needed trade too. It was still costly enough that he let the three pass under escort. He ordered his men to stay outside the Receiver unless called to carry a patient. It was a concession under pressure, not a treaty. Tobious took it and moved uphill.

At the last cart, the carrier woman caught his sleeve. Her palm smelled of rope and salt. "If you bring them through," she said, "we can take the wounded down the west road. The ridge patrol hasn't barred it."

"Can the carts turn at the ancestor terrace?"

"One at a time. No more. We'll keep the others below."

He passed that constraint to Sennos. One cart at a time would slow the outside transfer, but the carriers had already chosen where to wait and how to move. They were part of the rescue before anyone in Veyr had entered their names on a plan.

* * *

Samon waited at the ancestor terrace with a cane and his left leg secured in its brace. He had laid out wedges, stretcher boards, and lengths of rope with the mason, two millers, and Lios's aunt. He did not ask Tobious what Veyr had made of him. He pointed to the old drain.

Lios's aunt had brought a second cup, its rim unglazed and uneven. "He said you'd know the first," she told Tobious. "He asked me to keep a spare in case he dropped it."

The first cup had already become a signal under the storehouse. Tobious took the second and set it beside the stretcher boards. A child's preparation could not hold back the Iwang. It could keep the adults from depending on a single fragile thing.

"If you open the far branch, that channel takes the water," he said. "It will reach the holding recess first."

Tobious crouched at the grate. The flow was already heavier than the plan's model had predicted. A wall repair since his departure had

diverted runoff into the old passage. On Ypin's future map the channel was dry; in Aras, the last rain had changed it.

"We can shift it west before the first cut," Tobious said.

Samon nodded at the mason. She brought two wedges and a board. The workers opened a narrow side channel, directing the water toward a basin that had once caught overflow from the granary. Tobious helped hold the board while the mason set the wedges. The wet edge slipped against his palm; Samon saw it and put a younger worker at that end without making it a comment on his courage.

The basin filled. The holding recess remained dry. A diagram from Veyr had given them the route; people who lived above it had made the route real.

Samon tapped the retaining board with his cane. "It will hold while the basin stays lower than this seam. When the tide comes in, someone must watch the level."

The mason volunteered, then named a miller to relieve her. Tobious began to offer Sennos's monitor, but the monitor measured field load, not water. He let the mason mark the safe depth with a strip of charcoal and put a pot beneath the overflow to make the rising water audible. They had built a warning a tired person could hear without staring at a line.

"Your leg?" Tobious asked Samon while the crew reset the board.

"Attached."

"That was not what I meant."

"I know." Samon shifted weight onto the cane. "It hurts when I make the mistake of being twenty again. Today I intend to be my actual age and tell other people where the stones go."

Tobious had carried a memory of Samon crushed beneath the beam. The man before him was neither restored nor finished. He was giving orders to a mason who disagreed with him, and both of them were keeping a passage dry.

Jorra checked the outer passage for field pressure. Sennos set a shield stand where a stretcher could turn. Through the inspection pane, Tobious saw Mariya with Nerissa and Orran. Her hair was tied back with cloth worn thin at the ends. She raised her hand when she saw him. He did not ask her to leave her station and come to him.

The plan was alive because she was standing where she had chosen to stand.

For the length of that raised hand he saw the woman from the night before he left, measuring seed by a lamp and refusing to say she trusted a promise she could not verify. Now she stood inside the danger he had made worse. He wanted to put his forehead against the pane. Instead he raised his own hand, then pointed to the dry recess and waited until she nodded. The gesture carried no apology large enough for the weeks between them. It carried the place where the first stretcher could be set down.

Ypin's voice came through the relay. "Low-load interval beginning. I can hold the first branch reading. After each cut, confirm the far floor before you touch the next."

Mariya gave the signal from inside. Lios's cup rose once from the dry recess, with Nerissa's hand visible behind it. The fourth ration bell had sounded. Orran used the copied latch tool to open the ordinary service panel. It yielded without stirring the temporal field. Darran's guard was still at the ration hatch, surprised that a panel he had ignored could matter.

Tobious drew Severance. The blade's pale metal remained dull until it met the near tether. Jorra took position at his exposed side. He waited for Mariya's second signal that the first stretcher and its bearers were clear of the seam. When it came, he set the edge and counted three heartbeats.

The first beat drew the tether tight enough that the stone under his boot seemed to pull away. On the second he felt the shield fall from his own shoulder, leaving the skin of his neck aware of every grain of dust in the passage. Jorra's field held at his side. On the third the blade did not flash. A line that had been too thin to see became visible by ceasing to bend the air. He had once imagined a heroic sword announcing itself in light. Severance made room for a person to move, and demanded that he know who moved first.

The line parted. His own shield dropped; Jorra's field took a spray of stone from the wall. Inside, the first group could move. Orran and another worker guided a stretcher toward the wide recess. Nerissa read the names aloud. Tobious did not start the next

cut. The core had to settle, and the people already freed needed to reach cover before a different branch could take their load.

On the future-side readout, Ypin saw a temporary rise. "Within the plan," he said. "Wait."

Waiting had never felt so much like work. Annet had died while he trusted a faster setting to make time for everyone. He could hear the baffle clicks and the feet of people turning a stretcher. The thirty seconds passed without any new cut. He asked Mariya whether the holding recess was clear.

"Not yet," she said. "Hessah's bearers need one more turn."

Sennos looked at the charge left in the corridor shield. They could speed the second group by leaving the slowest section behind for one interval. The choice appeared on the map without being named. Tobious touched the relay.

"We hold," he told Ypin. "No bypass."

Mariya heard him. "Move the second board toward the recess," she said. "The bearers can rest there without blocking the first exit."

Samon's crew shifted it from the outer stair. The adjustment came from the people who could see both the old passage and the bodies inside it. Tobious let them change his sequence. The core was ready before the people were; he waited for them.

At the far wall, dust began to cross a seam against the direction of the draft. A mineral click sounded beneath the baffle cycle. Jorra lifted her shield toward it. The first stretchers were moving, the rescue was real, and an Iwang had found the fresh current that made the passage possible.

"Hold the next group," Jorra said.

Mariya repeated the order inside. The bearers lowered the stretcher in the dry recess they had measured. Nobody tried to run the turn while Jorra's field hid it from view. The Iwang pressed a pale limb along the active wall. It widened where the seam narrowed, then gathered weight at the collar. Sennos met it with his shield from the side, forcing its solid body away from the patient rather than driving it toward the other branch. The impact sent dust into the water basin Samon's crew had placed beneath the overflow. The basin rang. The channel still held.

Tobious waited for the creature to enter Severance's reach. Jorra did not call him forward. The blade had settled, but a cut here would open another line before the people in the recess could move. He remembered the guard's spear at the first opening and how its bronze point had found the collar only when the Iwang was solid. Jorra knew that limit too. She used an ordinary field blade to keep the creature from pressing past the shield, then withdrew when it thinned into the boundary. She had not killed it. She had made the passage unavailable for that interval.

Outside, the carrier woman placed one cart at the west-road turn where the first people to reach open air could be loaded. The second waited below, empty enough to turn when called. Samon's mason relieved the watcher at the drain. In the annex Nerissa read the living roll again, not because it had changed but because people needed to know whose movement the next cut depended on. Ypin's relay gave them the low trough that would continue into morning. The team agreed to hold the staged group under cover while the branch settled into that quieter state. No one left the far floor without Mariya's signal.

Tobious set the sword across his knees on the outer stair, where he could see the dry recess and hear the old watercourse. Sennos took the first watch. Jorra checked her heated shield unit and made the reserve ready. The Iwang clicked somewhere beyond the wall whenever the current rose. Dawn would bring the longer opening they needed. Waiting through the night was part of using it without asking the slowest people to pay for everyone else's haste.

The Hollow Ones

At dawn the annex held forty-five living people in different stages of leaving it.

Some had passed the first tether and waited in the dry holding recess. Others still stood on the far floor, tied to a branch that brightened whenever someone shifted weight. Mariya moved between the two as the baffle allowed, her board pressed against her chest. Nerissa read each name at the point of release and again when that person reached the outer stair. A person was not safe because a line had been cut. They were safe when someone saw them beyond the next danger and had a place for them to rest.

The first man who reached the recess refused the blanket the outside bearers offered. He had watched the passage behind him and insisted his sister had not yet crossed. Mariya found her on the far floor, conscious but too weak to walk without a hand. She showed him the name beside hers on the board and did not ask him to trust ink over his own eyes. One of the carriers moved him to a place where he could see the stair. He took the blanket when his sister came through. A second woman wanted to go back for a clay figure her daughter had made while they were confined. The figure was behind an active line. Nerissa kept the woman at the recess while Mariya marked where it lay. If the field cleared, someone might retrieve it. No one would cross the line for a promise that could not keep them alive.

They had used the night to teach the route to people who had not heard the first briefing. Now the instructions came in fragments that a frightened person could use: *Wait at the cup. Hands on the strap. Stop when Jorra's palm opens.* Mariya heard those phrases pass from bearer to bearer. There were no speeches. Every repetition made it more likely that the next body would reach daylight.

Lios gave the agreed cup signal on the fourth bell. Nerissa watched the same sound from the opposite side of the recess. On one cycle he missed it; the Iwang clicking inside the wall had drawn his

attention. Nerissa signaled in his place. He apologized. She told him the backup had worked as it was meant to.

Mariya heard the creatures before she saw them. Air passing through their open torsos made a low, empty note unlike a human breath. Pale struts pressed against the active seam. One body flattened so thin that the wall's old pattern showed through it, then gathered hard weight as its collar came through the field. Jorra's shield met the strike. The impact drove her toward the wall, and Sennos shifted the stretcher team away from the line of force.

The creature left no blood on the shield. Its pressure remained after it withdrew, a set of fine cracks climbing the plaster beside Jorra's arm. Mariya had seen one Iwang at the first opening months ago, when it was solid enough for a bronze point to wound at the collar. She had forgotten the sound of its weight returning. It was not a ghost slipping through stone; it had to borrow the thinness of an active boundary, then become a body again to strike. That rule gave the defenders a moment. It did not make the moment generous.

Jorra counted the next contraction aloud. Sennos moved with her rather than following the creature. Their shields overlapped only at the corner where the stretcher would turn. A second Iwang pressed at a farther seam but found no active passage and recoiled into its own narrow dark. Mariya could see only parts of the fight through the bearers and the stone. She did not need to see a victory. She needed the turn to stay open for the length of one patient.

"It has to take shape to reach us," he called. "Watch the collar."

Tobious was at the cut point, too far from Mariya for her to see the expression beneath the scar at his left eye. She could see the limit of his action. He had to hold Severance against a tether for three beats, lose his own protection, and wait afterward. Jorra and Sennos kept the Iwang from him while he did that work. The ancient workers moved people when the field let them. No single person commanded the whole passage.

The next group included Hessah on a stretcher. She had asked to keep the repaired water skin against her chest. Its red knot was still there. Her mother walked beside the bearers, carrying a second vessel in case the first leaked. At the wide turn, the bearer on the

wall side adjusted his grip exactly as Hessah had shown him in their test. She closed her eyes through the jolt but did not cry out. They reached the holding recess.

The bearer was the young man who had objected to the wider route because of Thesia's death. His palm came away from the brace white with dust. He checked whether the lower wedge had shifted before he stepped across. It had not. Hessah saw him checking and said, without opening her eyes, "You can tell me when you're frightened. I already am."

"I'm frightened," he said.

"Good. Keep looking."

Mariya almost smiled. Hessah had been making jokes about broken water skins when the rest of them could scarcely stand. This was not a last speech. It was how she had learned to keep people useful to one another in a room that gave them very little else.

"Water," she said.

Her mother gave her a measured sip. Mariya noted the stop and the time on her board. They had planned rest places because courage could not stand in for a body that needed one.

* * *

Darran came to the baffle control with two guards after the second morning group cleared.

He had changed his cloak since Mariya saw him at the ration hatch. It was clean at the shoulder and muddy at the hem. He had come quickly from the surface, but not so quickly that he had forgotten the seal of his office. One guard wore a worker's cloth over his mouth. The other held a spear with both hands and kept glancing at the men carrying his own village's wounded.

"You've changed the sequence," he said. He saw the service panel open and the copied latch in Orran's hand. "Close that. The root has to remain balanced."

"The people are coming out," Mariya answered. "You can see them."

"I can see what happens to the site when the load falls."

"You can see who has been holding it," Mariya said. She pointed to the people waiting in the recess. "You have had their names for weeks."

"I have had figures that changed every time you sent a packet."

"People died. The count changed because they died."

For a moment Darran looked toward the stretcher. Hessah's mother stood between him and her daughter without raising a weapon. The guard with the spear lowered its point a hand's breadth. Mariya hoped Darran might hear the difference between a falling load and a life being carried out. He was already turning to the control.

He had spent the summer keeping them fed just enough to work, then calling the result a salvage operation. If the Receiver failed now, his commission would be measured by an empty ruin and the names he had hidden. He pushed past his guard and tried to restore the baffle's old pattern.

"Stop," Orran said. "There are bearers in that turn."

Darran threw the control. The seam changed color. The Iwang that had been striking Jorra's field lost its old line of approach and followed the newly energized baffle toward the control station. Its limbs flattened along the wall, passed a thinned boundary, and became solid where Darran stood. He had time to look at the dark nexus beneath its collar. He put up one arm. The creature struck him and drew back into the current. The control fell from his hand.

The spear guard lunged too late. His bronze point struck the creature's collar as it turned and came away with a dark flake on the tip. The Iwang had already folded back into the boundary. He stared at the spear, then at Darran on the floor. Mariya told him to help carry the living. He looked at the second guard; neither had received an order from Darran to permit it. The second guard went to the nearest stretcher. The first followed.

Mariya did not feel victory. Darran's attempt had shifted the load while people were still on the old passage. His death gave them no safe interval; it left a baffle in the wrong position.

"Hold the brace," Orran called to the stoneworkers. "Get the stretcher past me."

The wooden support beneath the wide turn had cracked when the field changed. Orran set his shoulder to it and took the weight while the bearers carried the next person across. He had agreed to that position after hearing the risk, with two others to relieve him. The first reached him. The second could not get through the narrowing gap while a stretcher was on it.

Orran had carved a shallow mark in the brace at the place where he wanted the relief worker to put a hand. The first worker found it and pushed. For one breath Orran could ease his shoulder. Then the far edge slipped and the weight returned, more heavily. He called the changed pressure to Mariya, not to frighten the bearers but because a plan could not be corrected if the person at its most dangerous point hid what he felt.

The patient on the stretcher asked them to set him down. There was no stable floor under the middle of the turn. Mariya told him where the next stone was and asked whether he could keep his hands inside the frame. He nodded. She could not see whether he believed they would reach it. She made the bearers wait for the shield overlap, then sent them the remaining steps.

“Leave the board,” Mariya said. “Move back.”

“The board is under them.”

The person on the stretcher was awake, gripping the sides. Tobious moved from the cut point with his blade sheathed. Another worker brought a wedge. They tried to shift the weight off Orran's shoulder so he could step clear. The first attempt lifted the brace a fraction. Orran turned to take the offered hand.

The field surged through the damaged support. Stone broke above the wedge. Tobious's shield caught the first fragments, but the main beam struck the place where Orran stood. He disappeared from Mariya's view behind dust and the falling edge of the board.

The bearer nearest him tried to go back. Jorra caught the bearer by the strap and stopped him before his foot crossed the live seam. Tobious and the worker had the safer angle from the outer side. The bearer shouted Orran's name once, furious at being held. Mariya could not tell him to be calm. She told him to keep the stretcher level while the people who could reach Orran tried.

Tobious and the worker pulled the board clear. They reached for Orran. Nerissa came from the holding recess and stopped beside them; her face gave Mariya the answer before she spoke. The stretcher had passed. Orran had not.

“Forty-four,” Nerissa said when she could make herself count. She did not say the number as praise for the rescue. She said it so the next group would be carried by the people who remained.

Mariya wrote Orran's name beneath the others. She remembered him arguing that the strong should leave first. He had changed his mind in the work itself, not in a speech designed to make his death useful. His life did not become worth less because he had been afraid before.

The baffle could not be restored from Darran's control without exposing the corridor again. Ypin's relay offered a safer route through a slower interval. Mariya and Tobious chose it in front of the bearers. No one cut another tether until every person still on the damaged turn had been moved to stable stone.

* * *

By afternoon the outer drainage slope was full of villagers carrying water, stretchers, and names. Samon sat where the old channel met the yard, telling each group which stones would take a wheel and which would collapse beneath one. Therren's soldiers kept the road clear after the captain saw Darran's body carried out; none tried to reclaim the workers at the stair. The coastal carriers had shelter ready beyond the slope.

The soldier with Darran's spear came out bearing a water vessel for a woman he did not know. Nobody praised him. At the cart turn, a carrier asked him to put down the spear before he took hold of a patient. He did. The weapon stayed against the wall until someone claimed it for the ridge patrol. Mariya watched the exchange because it was smaller than peace and larger than an order.

Nerissa had made the outside workers leave a space between the two carts where a person could be examined out of the crush. She sent one child there whose breathing had turned shallow. The child recovered after sitting and drinking slowly. Another man with a

bruised ankle insisted he could help unload a stretcher. She gave him a roll of cloth to sort while seated. The work mattered. So did the fact that she would not let him prove usefulness by injuring himself further.

Mariya came through with the last group. She had counted forty-four after Orran. Nerissa counted again at the outer gate, matching each person to a household or a named carer. Lios reached his aunt and handed her the repaired cup. She put a hand around its rim as if testing whether it was real, then drew him against her.

Hessah reached open air on the final stretcher. Her mother asked for the planned rest place, and Mariya made the bearers stop beneath a cloth shade. Edda's instructions had come through the relay; Nerissa followed what she could use with the water and medicines they had. They warmed Hessah, eased the bindings that pressed on her chest, and gave her a sip when she asked. The skin with the red knot lay beside her hand.

Her mother wanted the sea wind brought to her. A carrier loosened the shade on the side facing the shore, then held it when the cloth snapped too hard. The breeze was still coming over the fields. Hessah reached for the red knot, found it, and ran a finger along the seam she had repaired herself. The skin had survived the passage. Mariya wished she could count that as evidence her maker would, too.

Nerissa listened at Hessah's chest and asked her where the pain was strongest. Hessah answered once. When she could no longer give a full answer, Nerissa did not turn her into an object of whispered estimates. She told her mother what she was doing and why. She told Hessah as well. Mariya helped hold the shade while they eased her breathing. The work was small and exact, and it was all they had.

"I thought the air would smell of salt," Hessah said.

"The wind is inland," her mother answered. "It will turn."

Mariya wanted to say the city beyond the sea could heal her. There was not enough time to take her through Salt and back, and no assurance that advanced care could undo weeks of injury to a body already failing. She helped Nerissa keep Hessah comfortable while they waited for a stronger breath. It did not come.

Hessah died where she could see the sky. Her mother held the repaired water skin. Mariya wrote the fifth captive loss beneath Thesia, Pehl, Annet, and Orran. Forty-three of the original forty-eight lived, including Mariya. Darran had never belonged on the captives' roll. The twelve freed on the first day had their own record, kept by the shelter households.

Her mother asked Mariya to write that Hessah had reached the open air. Then she shook her head. "No. Write where she died. I will remember what she saw."

Mariya wrote the place. She had learned to give the dead truthful records instead of kinder inventions. The mother kept the red knot in her hand while the living were counted again.

The roll took time. A man had gone to a neighboring shelter and had to be found there before his name was marked safe. One child had fallen asleep under a cart. Mariya did not close the list until each survivor had someone who knew where they would wake.

At last she stood on the slope. Aras spread above her, damaged and still inhabited. People were arguing over how to move a stretcher through a narrow lane; someone else was bringing more water. The open sky was not a reward for all the dead. It was room for the living to work in, and she could feel both truths as the wind finally turned from the sea.

What Love Cannot Keep

After the count, Tobious and Mariya found a place to sit where no one needed either of them for a few minutes.

It took them an hour to believe the count would hold. Tobious helped carry one man to a cart and found the man's sister already arguing with a carrier about the safest road. Mariya followed Nerissa through the shelter, matching a child's name to the aunt who had come for him. When she returned, she looked at the list again. Forty-three marks. Forty-three voices, sleeping or calling for water or speaking to people who had waited above. She had lived with the possibility of one name disappearing whenever she closed her eyes. Even now, each time someone moved behind a curtain she expected to turn the page and find a new absence.

"Nerissa has it," Tobious said when Mariya reached for the list a third time.

"I know."

He did not take the board from her. He waited while she handed it to Nerissa herself. On the far side of the yard, Samon was telling a carrier exactly where a cart wheel would sink. The work continued without either of them. Mariya let Tobious lead her inside.

The shelter belonged to the fisherman who had opened his net yard to the coastal carriers. His family had moved the hooks from the wall, and the room smelled of rope, salt, and the barley soup being made for the survivors. Forty-three people from the annex were alive. All had a carer or a place to sleep. The wider village was still moving, and the root remained open. For this interval, no one asked Tobious to hold a blade or Mariya to read a name.

They shared a bowl. Mariya's hands shook when she lifted the spoon. Tobious's fingers, stiff from the sword and the stretcher boards, fumbled the handle, so they passed it back and forth with their lefts and laughed once at the poor coordination. The laugh ended without turning into tears. Neither of them had the strength for a perfect account of the day.

Mariya told him about the five who had not come out. She began with Thesia, whose sister's children had eaten because Thesia had asked for them by name. Pehl had kept a stone in his pocket to test the sound of clay before firing it. Annet had complained about water and then taught Hessah to mend the skins. Orran had held a brace after learning what could fail. Hessah had asked for salt air and died before the wind turned. Tobious listened. The names were not a count he could use to make his loss look proportionate to the forty-three who had survived.

"I cut without asking what happened to the far floor," he said. "I saw the warning. I did it anyway."

"I know. I was there."

"I'm sorry."

"I believe you." She set down the spoon. "That doesn't make Thesia alive. It matters that you can say what you did without telling me the twelve saved make it right."

He nodded. He had feared she would offer forgiveness before he could bear it, or refuse him entirely. She gave him an account he could live beside without owning her judgment.

"I told people help would come by a certain interval," she said. "I didn't know it. I wanted them to keep sleeping and drinking and waiting. When the interval passed, I had made their fear worse. I also spent seed without asking."

"You fed them."

"Yes. Don't use that to make the secrecy good."

He smiled faintly. "You sound like Ypin."

"Then he must be tired of you too."

Tobious told her Panjios had died at the manual door. He described the two workers who crossed because the older man held it, and Suss's blade. He told her about the ninety-seven Panjios had abandoned years before and the false account he had left in the records.

"Ypin signed one of the later forms," Tobious added. "He told me before he knew I would find it. He has been trying to put that signature beside the real count."

Mariya wiped the edge of the bowl with a piece of bread. "Will they let him?"

“Edda has copies outside the command archive. He knows where the rest were kept.”

“Then don't let Panjios become only the man who died well, or Ypin only the one who helped you afterward.”

Tobious heard the care and the anger in her voice. She was asking him to remember whole lives, including what they had cost other people. He had learned the shape of that request in a room where Panjios could no longer answer it.

Mariya had met Panjios while he delivered grain and the brace for Samon. She remembered how he asked Samon before lifting the injured leg. “A person can be gentle with one man and cruel with a hundred whose faces he won't have to see,” she said. “And he can change what he does at the next door without undoing the first.”

Tobious touched the scar beneath his left eye. “I wanted him to live long enough for both things to be heard.”

“You can make sure they are.”

He reached for her hand. She turned hers to meet it, and they sat with the bowl cooling between them.

* * *

The shelter quieted after midnight. Mariya lay beside Tobious beneath a wool blanket. They had slept near each other before as children at harvest gatherings, with other households crowded around. They had never had this much silence together as adults. He could hear her breathing when it slowed, then her turning when a cart passed on the road outside.

Between the carts came the small sounds of a village trying to make a night: a ladle striking the bottom of a pot, an infant unwilling to sleep in a strange room, a man outside singing one line of a work song and losing the words. Mariya knew the line. She sang the next one quietly. Tobious joined where he could, badly. They stopped before anyone in the yard heard them and began to request more. When she turned toward him, her face was warm from the blanket and still hollow with fatigue. He wanted every ordinary night they had never been given.

“Come with me,” he said.

He had promised himself he would offer the choice without trying to sell it. The words came out bare because he wanted the answer too much to decorate them.

"I know I can," she said.

"There is a room in Ypin's ward. Edda could help with work. You would hate some of the food."

"You would fry it again."

"Until it tasted like something."

"Would I be allowed to work?" she asked. "Not as proof that I deserve the room. Work I choose."

"Yes. Edda would insist on rest first, and you'd argue with her."

"She sounds like Nerissa."

"She is less patient."

Mariya laughed, then grew serious. "Would people know what I came from?"

"Some would. You could tell the others what you wanted."

"And when they learned I didn't save everyone?"

He could not promise a city without judgment. He had seen how quickly Suss's notice had turned a living operator into a public danger. "They would hear the true count if we kept it," he said. "I would stand beside you while they did."

She touched his cheek, near the scar but not on it. "That is a life I can imagine."

She took time to answer. He did not fill it with arguments. In the dark he imagined her in Veyr: learning the signs, finding the households a register had missed, telling him when he had mistaken strength for help. It was not only his fantasy. She had wanted to see the hanging streets, to learn whether the sea looked the same beneath them, to live where a clinic could set a crushed leg more gently than Nerissa had been able to set Samon's.

"I could make a life there," she said. "I don't think I would vanish. Part of me wants to find out who I would be."

"Then come."

"Another part wants to remain where the water from our hills reaches the bay. I want to see what we can make of Aras with the soldiers drawn back. I want to argue with the neighbors about the

seed and hear them argue back. I want to be old enough to know whether Lios learns to carry a cup without being ordered to."

"Therren has not agreed to the charter yet," he said.

"I know. He may agree and break it. Some of the people who oppose him will still disagree with me about whose grain should be planted first." She turned the blanket back from her shoulders. "I am not choosing a peaceful village that doesn't exist. I am choosing to be here while they make one, or fail and try again."

He understood then why telling her she was free of duty would not move her. She had already let other people take parts of the work. What remained was a desire, not a sentence she had imposed on herself. He wished it led toward him. He loved that she could say where it led without asking him to approve.

"You don't have to stay to keep them alive."

"I know. Nerissa took the store list. The carriers know the roads. The village will live without me if I go. That is why I can choose it honestly."

He lay awake beside her. He could ask again. He could describe Veyr's light, the soft floor in Edda's clinic, their possible dinners. She already knew enough to desire some of it. There was no extra fact that would turn her choice into a mistake.

"I wanted a week with you when all we counted was figs," he said.

"So did I."

"I still do."

She pressed his hand to her chest. "I love you. I am going to stay."

The two sentences hurt because neither cancelled the other. He drew her close, careful of her bruises and of the cut at his own eye. They remained awake for a while, learning the shape of a life they would not have. No one made that life less lovely so leaving it would be easier.

Before they slept, they named the constraints once. He had to return to the root seam in Veyr. The cut needed his living contact for fifteen heartbeats. All three ancient accesses shared the mineral reference. The seven idle days for transfer could not fit between the final release and the measured Day-84 rise. She could cross now, or remain. After the cut, neither could use a spare door to undo the decision.

"I don't want you to think I stayed because you were less than home," she said.

"I won't."

"And you aren't leaving because you love me less."

"I know."

"You wanted to come back," she said. "I saw it when you stood at the pane."

"I did. I still do."

"Then let that be true without making the cut a punishment for wanting it."

He looked at the bandage on his hand. He had thought guilt might make the final action easier to accept, as though a man who had harmed others should be grateful for a task that could consume him. It did not. He wanted to live. He wanted her. He also knew who would stand beneath a new surge if he turned away from the root. The choice was harder because he expected to survive it and keep wanting what he could not have.

They did not promise to understand every day that followed. Tonight they understood enough.

* * *

The walk to Salt Gate began while the sky was still dark. Jorra and Sennos carried their field gear. Their work covering the ancient rescue was complete; they had to reach the future Root Hall before Tobious for the final operation. Mariya walked beside him without asking them to slow.

At the cave mouth, Tobious checked the binding around his right wrist. It had loosened while he carried a stretcher, and the strain from the old injury and the blade had made the joint swell again. Mariya took the cloth and tied it the way she had behind the granary on the morning he first left: firm enough to hold, loose where the swelling hurt. Her hands remembered the knot.

"There," she said.

"You could have taught me."

"I tried."

He had no answer to that. He held her face with his left hand and kissed her. Neither tried to make the touch last as long as the years it would have to replace.

Jorra crossed first, then Sennos. The Salt opening showed the receiving room in Veyr with unmistakable moving air. Tobious looked at Mariya. Behind her, the coastal path ran back to the forty-two other survivors and to a village negotiating what it would become. He wanted to know whether he would live through the final cut. He could not ask her to carry his uncertainty as a reason to change her choice.

“Go finish it,” she said.

He stepped into Veyr. Before the field narrowed, he turned once. She stood on the salt-white stone, not waving, seeing him leave. The opening remained physical and open for one more breath. Then the receiving schedule closed it, and the air of Aras no longer moved across his face.

The King's Second Measure

Suss had set the purge to fire toward the ancient side.

The captives were out of the annex. That did not put them beyond the volume his command had marked for destruction. Aras, its fields, the salt shore, and the neighboring roads remained inside it. On the control wall, the region appeared as a pale shape without houses. Tobious thought of Therren's altered grain measure in the first days of occupation: a rim moved by one band could make a whole harvest vanish from the count. Suss's second measure was larger. It did not make the people beneath it less real.

Edda's three marshals held the access order at the Civic Spine checkpoint. Suss's field officers contested their right to enter the purge junction. Some had already read the names from Mariya's packet and the signed maintenance forms; one stepped aside after Tobious admitted his own concealed spike to the room. Another held his post, saying the ancient deaths were a command matter and the future city's services came first. The split did not end with a speech. It became a corridor with people on either side deciding whether to open a door.

Tobious had crossed Salt before dawn and come straight to the checkpoint. Mariya's wrist binding was still on his right arm. He could feel where she had tucked the loose end beneath the cloth. Across the barrier, a Warden officer kept his hand near the control that would seal the Root Hall approach. He was young enough that Suss might have trained him. Tobious recognized the stance even without knowing the man.

The first marshal read Edda's order aloud. It granted passage for a casualty review and protection of the service crews moving residents off root power. The officer answered with Suss's emergency field authority. Both seals were valid. Neither contained an instruction for what a person should do when two valid authorities demanded opposite things.

Edda presented Mariya's list beside the manifest's zero. A rescued worker from the cooling station confirmed the root's field effects and Suss's earlier rescue of her team. She did not invent an accusation about a man who had saved her. She said what she had seen and what she had since learned had been left out of the load record. Ypin showed his own signature on a classification form. Tobious supplied the trace he had concealed and said how long he had kept it.

The worker carried a small case that kept medicine cold for her mother. It had come from the lower ward's emergency power line. She set it on the checkpoint rail while she spoke. "I know the backup is imperfect," she told the officer. "My mother's medicine is inside it. I helped test the line this morning. If it fails, I will be among the people hurt. I still will not sign a report saying the people under Aras were equipment."

The officer asked Edda whether every exposed household had been moved. Edda said no. The ones nearest the root had; farther households were on independent cooling with manual checks, and some would lose food if the towers failed. She gave him the failure plan with its unanswered entries left visible. Suss had been right to name costs the city would carry. He had not gained the right to erase Aras by being right about them.

"So the reference admits he broke procedure," the officer said.

"Yes," Tobious answered. "Write that too."

The man did not become a friend. He moved aside far enough for the marshals to pass. Another operator stayed at the door, refusing to join them. A third asked for the names to be sent to his own record before he would decide. Edda did it. The delay cost minutes they could see on Ypin's load gauge. It was still faster than asking people to abandon their judgment because Tobious held a famous sword.

"The purge preserves the root," Suss said over the command channel. "If you sever it now, you take water and transit from people who never voted on your rescue."

"They have been moved from the exposed tier," Edda answered. "You were given the backup plan."

“A backup that feeds a city for days. The root has kept it fed for generations.”

The argument deserved to be heard by the inquiry that would follow. It did not give Suss the authority to destroy Aras before that hearing. Ypin identified the purge path: an auxiliary surge route ran under the junction, feeding the ancient receiver volume while keeping the future root intact. If they cut that route before Suss could complete the command, the purge would fail. The root itself would remain overloaded and still need Tobious's final cut.

Jorra and Sennos took positions by the service rail. Ypin, his left arm still bandaged, timed the control pulses from a maintenance station he was authorized to read. Tobious waited with Severance behind their cover. He could hear the skyway traffic above them, a regular hum that would become dangerous if the root failed before evacuation finished.

Ypin put a second clock beside the load gauge. It measured the distance to the Day-84 peak, not the time until Tobious could safely use Severance again. Edda's last transit warning had slowed the skyway carriages but had not stopped every route; hospitals and service crews were still moving. Tobious understood why the city would resent what he was about to do even if he succeeded. No one had been able to evacuate an entire way of life in a few weeks.

“Three beats to couple,” Ypin said. “One route. Afterward, back to cover.”

Suss came through the far access with two loyal operators. He had never been a man to leave a difficult job entirely to others. His shield held steady as he approached; his blade traced Tobious's opening before Tobious made it. The first exchange proved what weeks of training had not changed: Suss knew distance better. Tobious would not win by matching his hands.

One operator called for Tobious to put down the relic. The other looked toward Ypin's station, measuring a path to the controls. Sennos gave them no clean angle. Jorra did not ask Tobious to defend her side while his own field fell. They had rehearsed the division: she would hold the center, Sennos the station, and Tobious would reach only the auxiliary line. The plan left Suss free to be the better fighter in a space where fighting was not the only objective.

Jorra shifted between them. Sennos blocked the operators from reaching Ypin. Tobious moved toward the auxiliary control as agreed. Suss anticipated it and used the junction's narrow rail to close the angle. Their blades met near contact. Tobious felt the pressure of Suss's field against Severance and kept his feet, but his own shield dropped as the relic sought a coupling line.

The floor was divided by maintenance channels covered in grating. Ypin had chosen this approach because it let a shield operator stand on either side of Tobious. Suss used the same channels to keep Tobious from stepping away when their blades touched. He feinted high, then pressed into the narrow sector near Tobious's right elbow. Tobious knew the correction Suss had taught him: move the foot, not the whole shoulder. He made the movement. It was just enough to keep the first edge from reaching him.

"You learned," Suss said.

"You taught me."

"Then listen now. If you cut that route, you leave this city dependent on a few temporary reservoirs."

"We prepared them."

"For days. The need lasts years."

Tobious had no reply that could turn a damaged harvest into a small thing. He held his blade against Suss's and waited for Jorra's cover to cross his exposed side. She could not keep it there long; the loyal operator facing Sennos was pressing toward Ypin's station, where a broken control would end their timing.

Suss turned his edge beneath Tobious's guard. It passed his protection at the right side. Pain drove the air from his lungs. Tobious stepped back with blood warming his ribs, exactly where the man in the opening had held a hand. He had no time to study the resemblance. Jorra covered his retreat while Sennos moved the loyal operators away from the service route.

He pressed the wound and felt blood soak his tunic. Suss came after him one step, then stopped when Jorra's shield narrowed the passage. The commander did not need to finish him to win. He needed Tobious too hurt to complete a cut while the purge reached the ancient volume. Tobious could see the calculation in Suss's

restraint, and hated how much it resembled the field lessons he had once admired.

"He is wounded," Ypin said over the channel.

"I can stand," Tobious answered.

"That is a different measurement."

Jorra drew him into cover. Her shield unit warned of heat. Sennos could not replace her while the loyal operators held the other approach. Tobious tasted iron when he breathed and wondered whether Suss's blade had broken a rib or only laid the flesh open. Edda's medical team waited beyond the checkpoint; reaching them would mean leaving the surge route armed.

Ypin sent him a simple map rather than another speech. A maintenance pulse would take the auxiliary control out of Suss's direct reach for a short interval. Jorra could hold the middle. Sennos could keep the operators to the right. Tobious would have one path to the marked line and no cover if he chased Suss afterward. The plan assumed Suss would notice. It did not require him to forget how to fight.

"I can give you an earlier pulse," Ypin said. "It risks the service station."

"Use the measured one."

Tobious felt the wrist binding Mariya had tied and steadied Severance in his left hand. He could still want Suss dead. He could still choose the route first.

Ypin gave him the next pulse window. Tobious pressed a hand to his ribs and counted the seconds until Severance's core had settled. The auxiliary route began to glow. Suss moved to intercept again; Jorra held him for one exchange, not long enough to defeat him but long enough to let Tobious reach the junction.

There was a moment when Suss's field thinned. Tobious could have turned after him. The blade was in reach of a human body that had killed Panjios and hidden the costs borne by Mariya's group. He felt the desire to make the story end with that cut.

Below them, the auxiliary route surged toward Aras. The forty-three survivors were in shelters along the shore and terraces. The shortest path to Suss would leave the control uncut for another pulse.

Tobious turned away from him.

The movement cost him the one line of protection Jorra could extend without exposing Ypin. She saw it and shifted her stance, risking the edge of Suss's field against her own shoulder. Sennos called that his operator had broken contact at the service rail. For three heartbeats all three of them accepted the openings the others had made. Tobious could not feel heroic inside it. His ribs made each breath smaller than the last, and his blade had to stay where the route lay.

He set Severance against the marked route. One heartbeat. His shield faded, and Jorra's field stretched between him and the commander. Two. The wounded ribs made it hard to keep the edge still. Three. The auxiliary line separated. Its light died before it reached the ancient volume.

Suss struck at his exposed side. Sennos met the attack, holding just long enough for Tobious to withdraw and his shield to return. Tobious could not have repeated the cut at once. He did not need to. The purge control went dark, and the command link that had protected Suss's access with it.

The loyal operators saw the line they had been ordered to preserve fail. One lowered his blade. The other hesitated until a marshal called the civil order through the open channel, then stepped back from the control. Two marshals entered with Sennos covering the doorway. Suss resisted the first attempt to take his weapon; Jorra caught his blade arm at the moment its field reset, and the marshals bound his wrists. The third secured the purge console and checked that no secondary sequence remained armed.

The senior marshal read the detainment basis into her recorder: active threat to an inhabited ancient volume, concealment of casualty evidence, and refusal of the independent access order. She did not call the charges a verdict. Suss asked whether she had verified the root would survive Tobious's planned cut. She said it would not, and ordered him held anyway. Her authority was narrow, but the threat in front of her fell within it. Suss's officers could challenge her account later with the same record she was making now.

No one in the room knew whether a second order had already been sent to the ancient side. Ypin checked the outgoing record against the line they had cut. The purge instruction had reached the auxiliary control but not passed the severed junction. A Salt diagnostic pulse returned from a standing receiver. It told them the route still existed; it could not show every house in Aras. The marshals kept the console sealed while a technician independent of Suss verified the remaining switches. Tobious did not leave until Ypin said the purge sequence was disarmed. The root load continued rising on the adjacent display.

Tobious stood apart, breathing shallowly. He had wanted to stop Suss since Panjios fell. When the man was taken past him alive, he felt no clean triumph.

"The city will count the days without the root," Suss said. "Then it will know what you chose for it."

"It should," Tobious answered. "It should count the people you chose for Aras too."

Edda's staff brought a pressure dressing for his side. They could keep him on his feet long enough to reach the seam; they could not make the wound harmless. The purge was stopped. The ancient shelters still stood. Above them, the skyway's hum faltered as accumulated overlap bent the high concourse. Ypin looked at the load gauge and did not ask Tobious whether he was ready. The measured deadline had arrived.

"Take me to the root," Tobious said.

The Other Side of His Voice

Tobious recognized the skyway before it failed.

From the service lip beneath the High Concourse, he could see a pale strip of sky between buildings taller than the hills of Aras. Roads joined their upper reaches without pillars beneath them. A long silver carriage passed along one. He had seen it all through ankle-deep water on the ninth day of the occupation, before he understood what a city could build above empty air.

The root seam lay below his feet, behind a narrow guard rail. Ypin checked the line from the service station. Jorra and Sennos held the approach with their shields, already warm from the purge junction. Edda had cleared the nearest concourse and warned people away from the skyway. Most had left. A few were still crossing when the overlap reached the support beneath it.

The road bowed downward.

Tobious saw figures falling from it. In the moment, they were people too far away for his hand to catch. He gripped his wounded right ribs, felt blood pass between his fingers, and stepped onto the maintenance lip.

An opening appeared in the air across the root's light. It was not a gate. The breeze on Tobious's face came from Veyr's failing concourse; beyond the opening, the water around another man's ankles remained still. An oil lamp burned behind him. Darran held his shoulder. The soldier stood on the stairs. A younger Tobious looked out from beneath the ancestor terrace, his right wrist swollen, his hair tied back, his eyes fixed on the impossible city.

Tobious looked first at Darran. The overseer was standing near the broken frame with the drawing that had begun the excavation. Then Tobious looked at himself.

He knew the forty-one seconds had already been lived from the other side. He could not send a new history through them. He could speak the words he had once heard, and they were still worth saying to the frightened man before him.

“Don't go with him.”

The younger man's face changed. He knew the voice before he knew the scar. Tobious reached toward him. The skyway gave way behind Tobious, the fall drawing his attention for a fraction of a breath. The small shapes dropped between the towers.

“Tobi. Listen. They aren't looking for stores.”

A crash came from the passage on the other side. Lios's jug broke on the ancient stone. The soldier turned to shout at the boy. Tobious stepped close enough for the light to show the scar beneath his left eye. He felt how short his hair had become against his collar and how much blood was gathering at his right side.

“That door is what they came for. And now they know you can open it.”

The opening went black when the forty-first second ended. He had no chance to add a warning about Suss, Panjios, or the forty-eight. There had never been one. The young man would still have to decide with the knowledge available to him, as Tobious had.

The root's pressure rose. Jorra called for him to come back from the edge. Tobious turned toward the seam. The people beneath Aras were out; Mariya had chosen to remain there. Suss's purge had been disarmed. The last task could now be done without making either group the hidden support for the other.

Across the concourse, emergency crews reached the skyway's near end. One lowered a line toward a broken ledge where a passenger still moved. Another waved those on the intact section back from its edge. Tobious took a step toward them. Jorra caught his arm.

The passenger on the ledge wore a bright work sash. She had caught a rail with one hand and was trying to pull a smaller person close enough to reach the line. A rescuer crawled out under a tether whose anchor Tobious could see fixed to the solid span. The scene was not a blur of falling shapes now. These were people making choices in the remaining seconds, and the crews had a route toward them. Tobious wanted to run there because the danger was visible. The root's rising note came through his boots from a danger that would soon reach streets he could not see.

“They have the road,” she said. “We have the seam.”

He could see the crew working; they were not waiting for a sword. The root load rose another mark. If he left the seam until everyone on the skyway had been found, a larger part of the city might follow the first span down. He had once mistaken going toward the nearest visible danger for taking responsibility for everyone. Now he allowed people with lines and training to do their work while he did his.

Ypin held up the final reading. The maintenance lip would remain accessible for one more load interval. Sennos checked the reserve charge in his shield. Jorra set her feet by the rail and told Tobious where to lean if his wounded ribs gave way. They spoke as workers checking a dangerous task, each admitting the point where their part could fail.

* * *

Severance met the root seam without a flash.

The blade's dark channel filled from hilt to tip. Tobious set his feet on the maintenance lip and gave the core the living feedback it needed. The contact would have to last fifteen heartbeats without interruption. If he let go early, the reference would rebound through the damaged root. Ypin had shown him the measurement. His own body now had to make it true.

On the first beat, the seam pressed back against the blade. On the second, his shield disappeared. Jorra raised cover between him and a line of stone fragments falling from the concourse. The third beat traveled up his injured right arm like a blow delivered through bone.

At four, the root drew the three ancient access lines bright on Ypin's board. Storehouse, Salt, Quarry: three doors fed by one material. At five, Sennos held an Iwang away from the service lip. It had come toward the active gradient, its hollow torso sounding under the rush of air. He did not need to kill it. He needed to keep it from Tobious while the current remained.

Six. Tobious felt the blade's grip heat beneath his fingers. Seven. A part of the city went dark beyond the concourse, and the backup lights in Edda's evacuated ward came on. The preparations had not

prevented damage. They had put people somewhere it could be survived.

Eight. The load shifted from the root into the physical seam. His right forearm seized. He could still feel his hand on the grip but could no longer close it harder. Nine. Ypin called the reading: the reference mineral was breaking, as the model had predicted. Ten. The skyway's far end stopped moving. People on the safe side ran back toward solid floor.

At eleven, Tobious nearly let go. Pain had made the cut smaller than the words *save two eras*. It was a hand failing on a tool. Jorra said she could take his weight; she did not claim she could finish the contact. Tobious leaned against the rail she held for him and kept his left hand on the blade.

Twelve. The Storehouse line vanished from Ypin's board. Thirteen. Salt followed. Fourteen. The Quarry's damaged signal went silent.

On the fifteenth beat, Severance's opaque core cracked without a sound he could hear. Light ran through the root seam and ended there. The blade became ordinary metal in his hand, its active channel dark. The mineral reference had been consumed. No temporal access remained on either shore.

On Ypin's board, the two inhabited volumes ceased pulling at one another. The Schellberg trace fell out of the danger band and then went blank with the root. Tobious could not see Mariya's shore. He could see that the line by which the ages had been made to bear one another was gone.

The Iwang at the service lip lost its clear shape. It thinned along a boundary no longer fed by a gradient and withdrew into the failing gap. Another collapsed beneath Sennos's field. Ordinary shield units still shone around the operators; the root had never been the source of every light in Veyr. Beyond them, some city services faltered, and others continued on backup power.

A public route display above them went dark. The emergency lamps took several breaths to come on. During those breaths Tobious heard the unmasked city: people calling from the concourse, a stretcher wheel striking a joint in the floor, water still moving in a pipe that had been given independent power. Then a

clinic signal answered from the lower ward. It told Ypin that the first backup reservoir had held.

On the far side of the maintenance lip, the city did not become still when the root ended. A tram slowed under its own reserve power and stopped before a gap. People climbed out through a service hatch and followed a worker with a lamp down the safe stairs. Somewhere above, a food tower lost its bright growing lamps; smaller emergency strips came on along the handrails. The cut had changed their world irreversibly. It had not turned every skill or tool they had built into dust.

Tobious's grip opened. He fell toward the maintenance floor, not over the lip. Ypin and Jorra reached him before the wounded ribs struck the stone. Ypin's burned forearm could not bear his whole weight, so Sennos took the other side. Together they carried him through the service approach while Edda's team came up with a stretcher.

Tobious tried to ask whether Mariya had seen the Salt Gate close. There was no path by which an answer could return. The last thing he saw before the clinic lights replaced the concourse was Severance in Ypin's hand, its broken core no longer shining.

* * *

Three weeks later, Veyr had bridges made for temporary use and queues for water that stretched past gardens no longer cooled by the root. Some families were still living in borrowed rooms. Food towers had lost a harvest; their workers replanted under independent power while the city argued over whose ration would change first. The skyway's three dead had names on the inquiry's first public page. The city did not hide them beneath a category called structural load.

Tobious stood in one of the queues once, against Edda's advice to avoid the crowd until his ribs healed. The woman who had sold greens from her window was ahead of him. She had lost plants in the move and was trading their surviving seeds for a place in another growing room. She recognized him, took her measured water, and said, "I still want my old room back."

“I know.”

“The clinic kept my neighbor's medicine cold. Tell them that too when they count what worked.”

He promised to tell the inquiry both things. She did not ask him to thank her for allowing him to stand in line. They waited while a reservoir worker adjusted the flow, and each person took the amount the ward could supply that morning.

Tobious had watched Edda read those names to the families before the public page appeared. The crews had saved several people from the broken span. They had not reached three. One family asked why the city had kept anyone crossing so close to the measured deadline. The transit supervisor answered with the evacuation order and the delayed carriage records. The explanation did not bring their son home. It did show which decision could be examined and changed, rather than leaving them with a disaster called inevitable.

The woman with the bright work sash had survived. She sat at the hearing with one arm held close to her body and told the supervisor that the last carriage had waited while a service ramp was checked. She did not know whether the delay was necessary. The ramp crew had a log. Tobious saw the supervisor request it instead of asking her to guess. She glanced at Tobious once, recognizing the man who had stood below with the sword, and then returned to the people examining her route. He could bear being looked at. He did not have an answer that belonged in place of the ramp log.

Suss remained in custody while civil investigators gathered testimony. His field decisions were examined alongside the records that had once protected them. Panjios's old closure of the ninety-seven was published with his final act at the isolation door. Tobious objected when a draft memorial called him redeemed. The words they chose instead described what he had done on both days. He could love the man who had taught him without asking the dead to pay for a spotless story.

Tobious testified too. He told the inquiry he had seen the far-floor warning before freeing the first twelve and that he had concealed the Storehouse spike after the cooling-shutter rescue. Suss's counsel asked whether his own intervention had not made everything worse. Tobious answered that it had harmed people and

that the command's hidden routing had made the harm useful to its policy. Both statements could be true without one excusing the other. The clerk entered them under his name, where anyone reviewing the case could challenge them.

Edda examined Tobious's hand in the rehabilitation ward. The cut had left a persistent tremor in his right fingers and a grip weaker than it had been on the farm. Some days it tired quickly. She showed him how to brace a tool against his forearm and use the left hand for the fine adjustment. The scar beneath his left eye remained. The ribs were healing more slowly than he liked.

On the first day she asked him to pick up a cup with the right hand, he spilled half its water. He was angry at how small the task was. Edda gave him a cloth and let him dry the table. On the next attempt he used both hands. He drank without spilling, but the grip shook afterward. They recorded what he had done, not whether it looked graceful. At night he sometimes woke with the sensation of Severance's core breaking in his palm. By morning there was only his hand and another set of exercises to learn.

Ypin visited with a small water regulator from the lower ward. It needed a seating ring replaced, a job no one would put in a memorial. He set it on the table between them. Tobious held the housing with his left hand while Ypin used his recovering forearm to guide the ring. They stopped when either hand began to shake and began again after resting. The regulator held pressure on the third attempt.

When it worked, Tobious asked whether the lower ward had enough spare parts to keep replacing the rings. Ypin said the supply shop had begun cutting them from a new material, and that half of the first batch would probably fail the pressure test. They would have to tell the shop which half. The future beyond the root was not a single crisis ending in a single rescue. It was a long sequence of ordinary corrections, some of which his injured hand could still help make.

"You can come with me tomorrow," Ypin said. "There are more than I can do alone."

"I don't know all your valves."

“You know when water is going somewhere it shouldn't. We'll work out the rest.”

Tobious looked past him at the city. Its tall roads still crossed the air, though one span ended in a clean temporary brace. He had survived the moment he had once seen from a cold chamber beneath Aras. He did not know how Mariya's next morning had begun. She did not know his hand could still mend a small thing. The separation would not become less real if he filled it with imagined messages.

He picked up the regulator. Its weight was manageable in his left hand. When the tremor came through the right, he waited for it to pass and kept working.

What Is Kept

The first autumn rain arrived while Mariya was reading the relief charter.

Therren's scribe had pressed it into clay that morning, under the captain's seal and the marks of household witnesses from Aras and three neighboring villages. The terms were limited: the garrison would leave the village houses and withdraw to the ridge, the remaining ordinary labor detainees would be released, and the harvest levy would be reduced for the season. Telassar still held the citadel and the road beyond it. A future captain might contest the charter when the weather changed.

For now, Therren needed the carriers who had stopped moving grain and oil through the harbor. His secret surveyor was dead. The ancient Receiver had become silent stone, and the soldiers who had worked beside it wanted no part of another opening. The concession came from their costs and the neighboring villages' refusal to carry them alone. Mariya accepted it for what it was, not for the conversion of a man who had once called their seed the king's measure.

The negotiation had taken place in the yard where his soldiers first weighed the jars. Therren wanted the carriers to resume at once and offered to remove only the men quartered inside the houses. A boatbuilder's daughter asked whether the workers held at the ridge counted as people inside a house. The captain said they were subject to a separate labor order. The neighboring carriers pushed their unloaded carts into the road and said the distinction would matter when he tried to feed his garrison.

One of Therren's soldiers had a brother among the ridge laborers. He did not speak in the negotiation. When the captain called for the labor tablet, the soldier found it quickly and placed it where the household witnesses could read the names. Therren saw the gesture and said nothing. His men had watched Darran die beside a worksite they had been told was safe to guard. Their obedience had limits

now, though those limits might change again under a different commander. Mariya did not ask the soldier to become a symbol of a kinder occupation. She checked his brother's name against her board.

Mariya had brought the names from the old clay tablets. She could not read every palace mark, but she could put each household beside the person missing from it. Therren recognized several as useful craftsmen. He wanted their labor available for the autumn repairs. The carriers wanted those hands at the boats and mills that supplied the district. He agreed to release the ordinary detainees under a seasonal charter, keeping a smaller detail at the ridge to protect the road. No one called it justice. It changed where the men would sleep that night.

When the scribe wrote the levy relief, he used a measure without stating its size. Mariya put the old wooden measure on the table. Therren glanced at it, then had the dimensions pressed into the clay. One band of wood had once taken a year's seed from them. She would not leave a new band to the next scribe's discretion.

She read the charter aloud in the meeting yard with Nerissa beside her. She did not tell the households it made them safe forever. The scribe had made a copy for the ridge; two village witnesses would hold another. The carrier households would report if the old toll returned. Samon wanted a mark added for workers still kept at the citadel; Therren's scribe resisted until one of the neighboring carriers named the road he would close again. The mark was added.

"We'll need to check it after the next levy," Mariya said. "If they take more, bring the seal and the names here before anyone tries to settle it alone."

The boatbuilder's daughter asked who would keep the copy if Mariya was away. Mariya gave it to three household witnesses to hold in separate jars, each marked in the meeting record. The carriers promised to compare the ridge copy at the next market. The charter would survive only if more than one person knew how to challenge it. Mariya had learned that a good count could be made powerless by keeping it in one careful hand.

There was no cheer. People discussed who would watch the road, which boats would bring grain before the rains made the northern path difficult, and whether a family could move back into a house the soldiers had used as a kitchen. Their questions sounded like the village recovering its voice. They did not sound like peace, and Mariya did not require them to.

* * *

Forty-three people had come out of the annex alive. Aras held many more than forty-three, and the returned captives did not stand apart as a single body. Some had gone back to households where fields needed work; others slept longer or started at every sudden click. One woman preferred the shore to the ancestor terrace and spent her mornings helping mend nets. The shelter lists were revised as people changed their minds about where they wished to be.

Nerissa resumed her visits to mothers and children. She kept a careful watch on those whose legs or hands still failed them after the field surges. She could not cure every injury by naming it; she could make sure no one disappeared from care because a list was finished. Samon taught the younger workers how to set a sluice gate without twisting the damaged left leg beneath him. He used his cane to point at mistakes and laughed when they finally found one he had made himself.

One of the returned stoneworkers asked for his place at the sluice back. Samon told him the work was there, but the old hours were not. The man had lost sleep under the Receiver and startled whenever a hammer struck stone behind him. For the first week he would work in the open yard with a partner who could trade tasks when noise became too much. He disliked the arrangement until the partner admitted he also needed help lifting the heavier gate boards. They worked out a day both could finish. Mariya watched from the terrace and left them to settle it.

Lios brought water to the work crews in the morning by choice and spent the late light playing a game of stone marks with his aunt's grandchildren. The village agreed that no soldier could assign him a labor route again under the old commission. His cup, made

from the bottom of the broken jug, stood by the well when he played. He always took it home at dusk.

On a new clay record, Mariya and the household witnesses wrote the five who had died in the annex and its evacuation: Thesia, Pehl, Annet, Orran, Hessah. The dead from the first attack and the ordinary occupation were written on the same tablet with a space between the groups, so no one could mistake the causes or merge them into a single useful total. Pehl's daughter asked for his name to be read again. Mariya did. Thesia's sister brought her children; they remembered the bread Thesia had asked Mariya to give them. Hessah's mother set the repaired water skin beside the tablet while the clay was still soft.

Pehl's daughter had brought the small stone he used to test fired clay. She struck the edge of the new tablet when it was dry enough to sound. The note was clear. She said her father would have called it good work, then asked whether she could make another tablet for people whose names the first could not hold. Mariya said yes, and asked who would help gather them. The girl named two neighbors at once. Grief had given her no special knowledge; she had learned the craft and knew who could carry clay.

The record could not keep any of them alive. It made it harder for a future scribe to call their absence zero.

After the tablet dried, the households carried the woman-with-bowl statue back toward the ancestor terrace. The Telassari soldiers had wrapped it to keep it from breaking when they removed it. One corner of its base had chipped during the summer; the figure still held her bowl. Mariya and two others helped set it above the well, not in exactly the old place, because a new wall brace occupied the stone beneath it. Nerissa poured a small amount of the first water over its feet. Lios asked whether that would bring anyone back. Nerissa said no. He poured the next small cup anyway, because the living still needed ways to remember who had drawn water before them.

Mariya had no report from Veyr. She had seen Tobious cross Salt Gate alive, wounded and intent on a task he understood. The silence after the root failed told her the doors were closed, not how he had fared beyond one. She would not fill that silence with certainty she

had not earned. She also would not live as though uncertainty were a command to stop.

Some mornings she missed him most when the work was easy: when she found a sound jar without checking its rim twice, when the sluice opened after the first turn, when she reached for a second piece of bread and remembered he would have argued over which half was larger. She did not want the missing to become her only way of speaking his name. She told Lios how Tobious had once repaired a water channel after insisting for an hour that it was not broken. Lios laughed and asked whether Tobious had admitted it. Mariya said no; the water had made the admission for him.

* * *

The last protected seed jar waited in the lower granary. Mariya had opened the other during the hungry weeks, first in secret and later with the households' knowledge. Its grain was gone. The jar Tobious's mother had marked with a leaf had been cracked at the threshold and its seed carried away by soldiers on the ninth day of occupation. No shard had returned to become a relic.

The households gathered around the remaining jar with seed bought and borrowed from the neighboring carriers. Mariya brought a fresh clay tag. She scratched a leaf on it, not to pretend the old vessel had been restored, but so they would know which lot had come from the seed they had kept under the bull seal. A second tag named the grain brought by the coastal villages. Each could be planted and judged by how it grew.

The household witnesses disagreed over how much of the last jar to sow on the high terrace. The soil there drained well but had lost a strip of wall to the occupation works. A lower field had deeper earth and a greater chance of flood. Mariya proposed dividing the lot; a farmer who knew the storm channels argued for keeping the old seed together in one place so they could judge it. They went to see both plots before deciding. Samon showed where the first rain would run. They divided the seed only after the people who would tend each field had said what they could manage. Mariya wrote the choice on the new tag. She had once broken a seal at dawn and explained

herself weeks later. The grain went into the ground in daylight with the argument still audible around it.

At the terrace, the rain softened the upper earth without flooding it. Samon marked the first water turn from his chair. Nerissa passed seed to the people kneeling in the rows. Mariya began to set the spacing and then stopped when a younger farmer showed her where runoff would gather after a heavy storm. He moved the next row a little higher. She tested the ground with her fingers and agreed. No one needed her to be right before they could plant.

Lios came down the slope with his cup and asked whether he could put seed in a row. His aunt said he could have a short one after helping carry water to the workers. Mariya showed him how deep to press each grain. He made two holes too close together, corrected them himself, and looked up for approval. She told him the row was his to finish.

The rain grew steadier. It darkened the backs of the people bending over the terrace. Mariya could see the bay between them, the same water that would never again carry a road to Tobious. She remembered his hand beside hers on the granary step and the week they had wanted with no counts at all. She could grieve that life and still want the one beginning here. Neither feeling made the other a lie.

She pressed a seed into the opened earth and reached for another.